APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025: Stablecoins, Tokenization & Integration

CONSENSUS

Feb 10-12, 2026
Hong Kong

CoinDesk

Protocol Theory

Foreword

Asia–Pacific continues to shape the future of digital finance – not only through innovation, but through its ability to translate innovation into inclusion. At Consensus, our mission is to support that transformation by bringing together builders, investors, and policymakers to advance an open, accessible, and sustainable financial future.

This year's State of Crypto in APAC report reflects that vision. It reveals a region defined by pragmatism and purpose, where access – not ideology – is driving progress. Across economies at different stages of development, people are engaging with digital assets because they meet real needs: lowering costs, increasing control, and expanding opportunity.

We are proud to collaborate with Protocol Theory and CoinDesk on this landmark study, which captures a pivotal moment in the evolution of the region's digital economy. The findings provide clarity for leaders shaping a future in which financial innovation is not only possible but inclusive by design.

Michael Lau
Chairman of Consensus

Asia–Pacific has become the world's most dynamic testing ground for digital assets. From individual users in emerging markets to institutions in global financial hubs, the region continues to define what adoption looks like in practice. Yet as this report shows, the story is evolving. The question is no longer who believes in digital assets, but who can access them – easily, confidently, and within systems they already trust.

In 2025, awareness and optimism are near universal, and regulatory foundations are in place. The next phase of growth will be defined by usability, integration, and human experience. At Protocol Theory, we believe that evidence and empathy must guide this transition. When access aligns with trust and design, belief turns into behavior – and inclusion becomes scalable.

This report represents that philosophy in action: rigorous, data-driven, and focused on what it takes to make the promise of digital assets real for everyone. Access is not the end goal – it is the bridge to adoption, empowerment, and enduring participation across the region.

Jonathan Inglis
Founder & CEO, Protocol Theory

About this report

The CoinDesk APAC *State of Crypto 2025* report, produced by CoinDesk in partnership with Protocol Theory, explores how digital asset adoption across Asia-Pacific is shifting from awareness to accessibility. Drawing on a quantitative survey of over 4,000 internet-connected adults across ten markets, the study examines how usability, integration, and trust now determine participation more than ideology or speculation.

This year's report builds on the 2024 edition by focusing on stablecoins, remittances, tokenized assets, and integration with traditional finance as the practical foundations of the region's digital economy. It shows that while belief in digital assets remains strong, adoption now depends on how easily people can access and use them in their daily financial lives.

About the authors

CoinDesk

CoinDesk is the leading global media, research, and events platform covering digital assets, blockchain, and the future of finance. Founded in 2013, CoinDesk provides trusted news, analysis, and data that help investors, institutions, and policymakers understand the forces shaping the digital economy.

Through its award-winning journalism, original research, and flagship events such as Consensus, CoinDesk serves as the definitive source of insight for the global crypto and Web3 community. Its mission is to bring clarity, transparency, and credibility to a rapidly changing financial world.

Learn more at: www.coindesk.com

Protocol Theory

Protocol Theory is the world's leading consumer insight, analytics, and strategic consulting company dedicated to Web3, AI, and emerging technology. Combining deep industry expertise with decades of experience in consumer behavior and marketing science, Protocol Theory delivers data-driven insights and bold perspectives that help clients understand adoption, build competitive advantage, and uncover new growth opportunities. Trusted by leading global brands, the company's research powers product innovation, optimizes user experiences, and shapes market strategies for the onchain era.

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Executive Summary

Asia–Pacific remains the global centre of gravity for digital asset adoption

Approximately 535 million adults in the region now own or use cryptocurrency, accounting for around three-quarters (74.6%) of global crypto owners. This scale underscores Asia–Pacific's pivotal role in advancing digital assets from niche innovation to everyday utility.

Awareness and optimism are near universal, yet growth is no longer driven by belief alone. The next phase of adoption will depend on access: the degree to which people can reach, understand, and use digital assets within the financial systems they already trust.

Based on a survey of more than 4,000 adults across ten markets, APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025 finds that participation is now shaped by usability, integration, and inclusion rather than speculation. Stablecoins, remittances, and tokenized assets are emerging as the practical foundations of a digital economy that operates across borders and devices, supported by regulatory frameworks designed to enable rather than restrict participation.

Access has become the defining measure of progress. Where digital assets feel simple, safe, and embedded in familiar everyday experiences, adoption accelerates. Where they remain complex, opaque, or disconnected from daily life, participation slows.

Key Insights

- **24.3% of internet-connected adults** across APAC (around 535 million people) now own or use cryptocurrency – significantly higher than the global average (16.9%).
- **95% of adults** in the region are aware of cryptocurrency, underscoring a persistent gap between widespread awareness and active participation.
- **17.0% of internet-connected adults** across APAC (around 372 million people) use stablecoins, with adoption in emerging markets (17.8%) roughly three times that of developed economies (5.8%).
- **Nearly half of adults (47%)** say stablecoins are difficult to access – more than twice the share who say the same of remittance services (23%).
- **Expanding accessibility** across digital assets could unlock participation among 63% of non-users in emerging markets, representing a significant *accessibility dividend*.

Access is the new adoption

The next phase of growth in Asia–Pacific will be defined by how easily people can experience, trust, and use digital assets in their daily lives. As usability, interoperability, and confidence align, these technologies will become embedded within the region's financial architecture, turning innovation into everyday inclusion.

Asia–Pacific's digital asset story is evolving toward inclusion. Regulation provides the foundation of trust, integration advances usability, and broader access enables participation across everyday financial contexts.

Introduction: From Adoption to Access

For more than a decade, Asia-Pacific (APAC) has stood at the forefront of the global digital asset story[1]. Across the region, early believers and everyday users have built one of the world's most dynamic digital finance ecosystems. In CoinDesk & Protocol Theory's 2024 State of Crypto in APAC report, *Driven by Demand: The People-Powered Crypto Movement in Asia-Pacific*, we described this movement as **people-powered** – driven by optimism, pragmatism, and a shared belief that digital assets and cryptocurrencies have the potential to expand economic opportunity and redefine participation in finance.

In 2024, that conviction translated into scale. Emerging markets such as Thailand, the Philippines, and the UAE led the region with some of the highest cryptocurrency adoption rates globally, while developed economies like Singapore, Australia, and Hong Kong saw accelerating participation and growing confidence. Awareness of cryptocurrencies became near universal, and digital assets entered mainstream financial conversation.

This year, the story moves further. *APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025: Stablecoins, Tokenization & Integration* explores what happens after awareness – how access transforms familiarity into everyday use. The report examines the single question now shaping the region's next phase of growth:

If awareness, interest, and optimism are already high, what makes participation effortless for everyone?

When Simplicity Becomes Strategy

The evidence shows that demand is no longer the constraint. More than nine in ten adults across APAC are aware of cryptocurrency, and just over half (51%) intend to use it within the next year – around twice the proportion who already do. Yet over the past 12 months, adoption has grown only marginally. The limiting factor is not interest but *access*: whether digital assets feel usable, familiar, and integrated into the systems people already rely on in their everyday financial lives.

Across APAC, most consumers can open a digital bank account in minutes, transfer money internationally with a few taps, and pay bills through mobile apps that feel effortless. Against that backdrop, the complexity of wallets, exchanges, and token transfers can feel unnecessary or opaque. The next phase of adoption will depend less on education and more on design – making participation as natural as paying with a phone or checking a balance online.

Access as Experience

Access is the moment when technology disappears and participation begins – when people stop learning how to use something and simply use it. It defines how digital assets are experienced, not just whether they exist. Four conditions shape that experience:

1. **Reach**
   Are products available where people already transact?
   Example: crypto-enabled payments integrated into existing mobile wallets.
2. **Ease**
   Is the interaction simple, safe, and reversible?
   Example: paying a utility bill through a wallet that feels like any other app.
3. **Fit**
   Do digital assets align with existing financial habits?
   Example: the ability to move between bank accounts and digital assets in seconds.
4. **Confidence**
   Do people trust the process because it feels predictable?
   Example: seeing clear redemption rules for a stablecoin, with assurance that funds are protected.

When these elements align, adoption becomes instinctive.

A clear precedent exists in mobile banking. Early users were cautious about managing money on a phone. Confidence grew only when interfaces simplified, jargon was removed, and reliability was demonstrated by embedding the experience into everyday routines[2]. Behavior changed first; attitudes followed.

The same evolution is now required for stablecoins, tokenized assets, and other digital instruments that promise practical value yet remain seen as complex or distant. As design, clarity, and integration improve, access will convert interest into participation – and participation into habit.

A Region Ready for What Comes Next

The 2025 findings confirm that Asia–Pacific remains the world's global frontier of digital asset adoption. The region's diversity – spanning developed markets with advanced regulation and emerging economies with high practical need – creates an unparalleled environment for understanding how innovation becomes experience. Stablecoins and real-world asset (RWA) tokenization, in particular, reveal both the opportunity and the obstacle ahead: *demand has outpaced access*.

- **Stablecoins** are recognized for their stability and payment potential, yet only a small share of adults believe they can easily obtain or use them.
- **Tokenized assets** promise broader investment access, but participation remains limited because entry points still feel technical and remote.
- **Integration with traditional finance** is increasingly expected – most adults want seamless transfer between digital assets and their existing accounts – but interoperability remains incomplete.

Together, these patterns define a pivotal moment for the region. The infrastructure exists, the motivation is clear, and the benefits are widely understood. What remains is transforming technical possibility into lived experience – where access defines the next chapter of adoption.

Purpose of This Report

APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025: Stablecoins, Tokenization & Integration provides an evidence-based examination of this transition: from awareness to accessibility, and from potential to participation. It analyses the conditions under which digital assets become usable for ordinary people, the role of design and regulation in enabling that shift, and the commercial opportunities that emerge as barriers are removed.

Each chapter draws on quantitative data from more than 4,000 respondents across ten APAC markets, paired with interpretive analysis grounded in consumer behavior and innovation-adoption science. The goal is to present a clear, data-driven view of where the region stands and what must change for digital assets to evolve from early adoption to everyday use.

References
[1] **Source**: Arner, D. W., Buckley, R. P., Didenko, A., Park, C.-Y., Pashoska, E., Zetzsche, D. A., & Zhao, B., *Distributed Ledger Technology and Digital Assets: Policy and Regulatory Challenges in Asia* (Asian Development Bank / UNSW Law Research Paper 19-60, 2019).
[2] **Source**: Al-Jabri, Ibrahim & Sohail, M. Sadiq, *Mobile Banking Adoption: Application of Diffusion of Innovation Theory(Journal of Electronic Commerce Research*, Vol. 13, No. 4, pp. 379–391, 2012).

The Defining Idea

Access is the new adoption.

Progress in digital assets will be defined not by innovation alone, but by experience – by how easily people can discover, understand, and use these tools in the flow of everyday life. When access becomes intuitive, adoption follows naturally, and technology moves from promise to participation at scale.

Chapter 1:
The APAC Crypto Adoption Landscape

At a Glance: Experience and Scale Across APAC

Asia–Pacific remains the engine of global digital asset growth. With 535 million adults now owning or using cryptocurrency, the region accounts for nearly three-quarters (74.6%) of the world's 717 million crypto owners, confirming APAC's position as the world's most engaged digital asset region.

Key insights

- **24.3% of internet-connected adults across APAC** (around 535 million people) own or use cryptocurrency – a 1.9-percentage-point increase year on year.
- **Emerging markets lead usage (33%)** versus 25% in developed economies, driven by remittances, mobile-first finance, and inflation protection.
- **Public confidence remains resilient** despite market corrections, with sentiment stabilizing as adoption matures.
- **Female participation continues to rise** (from 20 to 22%), and adoption among adults aged 45–54 now exceeds 20%, showing mainstream reach.
- **Stablecoins and tokenized assets** are emerging as the new access layer, linking digital assets and traditional finance across payments, investment, and trade.
- **Markets such as Thailand, India, the Philippines, and the UAE** set regional benchmarks through clear rules, local infrastructure, and consumer-centred design.

APAC's digital asset market is entering a new commercial phase defined by **scale, stability, and integration**. The opportunity ahead lies in expanding seamless access – turning the region's vast base of crypto-aware consumers into confident participants across finance, commerce, and daily life

A Region of Scale, Maturity, and Momentum

Asia–Pacific remains the gravitational centre of the global digital asset economy. The region's combination of population scale, technological fluency, and behavioral openness makes it the most instructive environment for understanding how crypto transitions from early adoption to everyday use.

As of late 2025, approximately 24.3% of internet-connected adults across APAC own or use cryptocurrency – around 535 million people[1], a 1.9-percentage-point increase year on year[2].

Exhibit 1.1

APAC's adult adoption rate remains well above the global average, underscoring the region's outsize role in mainstreaming digital assets.

24.3%

APAC crypto adoption rate,
internet-connected adults (weighted),
November 2025

Change vs Dec 2024: **+1.9 p.p.** (from 22.4%)

16.9%

Global crypto adoption rate,
internet-connected adults,
November 2025

Change vs Dec 2024: **+1.3 p.p.** (from 15.6%)

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; nationally representative survey of 4,020 internet-connected adults (18–64) across 10 APAC markets, September 2025; weighted by internet penetration and crypto awareness. Global estimate derived from a16z (*State of Crypto 2025*), Crypto.com (*Market Sizing H1 2025*), and UN DESA (*World Population Prospects 2024*); Protocol Theory analysis.

Note: Both figures are calculated on the basis of internet-connected adults (18–64 years). Global and regional estimates are harmonized to allow direct comparison of adoption among populations with regular Internet access. See Appendix C for explanation of the distinction between internet-connected and total-population adoption figures.

When measured against the total population, adoption continues to demonstrate the region's global leadership. Approximately 11.1% of adults in APAC now own or use cryptocurrency, compared with 8.7% globally – an increase of 1.1 percentage points year on year versus 0.7 points worldwide – reinforcing the region's role as the largest and most active market for digital assets.

Exhibit 1.2

APAC's total-population adoption rate continues to outpace the global average, highlighting the region's scale and maturity.

Metric	Adoption Rate	Users (Millions)	Change vs. Dec 2024
APAC crypto adoption rate (total population)	11.1%	535M	+1.1 p.p (from 10.0%)
Global crypto adoption rate (total population)	8.7%	717M	+0.7 p.p (from 8.0%)

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; nationally representative survey of 4,020 internet-connected adults (18–64) across 10 APAC markets, September 2025; weighted by internet penetration and crypto awareness. Global and regional total population estimates derived from a16z (*State of Crypto 2025*), Crypto.com (*Market Sizing H1 2025*), and UN DESA (*World Population Prospects 2024*); Protocol Theory analysis.

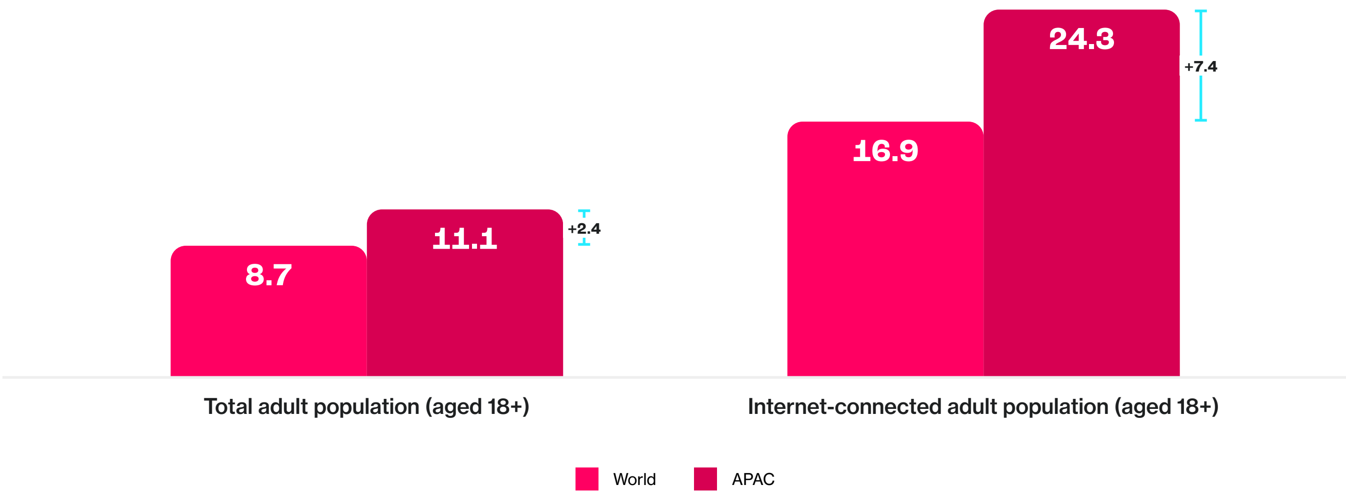
Note: Both figures are expressed as a share of the total population to allow direct comparison with global owner estimates; corresponding figures for internet-connected adults are higher (24.3% APAC; 16.9% global).

Notably, across the total population, crypto ownership in APAC only modestly exceeds the global level. Yet when measured among adults with Internet access, the gap widens sharply: 24.3% in APAC versus 16.9% worldwide. In other words, where people can connect, they participate.

Exhibit 1.3

Among internet-connected adults in APAC, crypto adoption rises sharply relative to global peers. Access translates enthusiasm into participation.

Share of adults owning or using cryptocurrency, total adult population vs. internet-connected adult population, by region (% of population)



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This distinction captures the central idea of the report: the role of **access as a multiplier of enthusiasm**. Asia–Pacific's advantage lies not in greater connectivity or lower costs, but in stronger intent among those who can participate. When opportunity exists – through connectivity, financial inclusion programmes, or supportive regulation – people across the region display a uniquely high willingness to engage with new financial technologies.

Access, in this sense, is the mechanism that converts optimism into use. It determines not only who participates but how readily they do. The more people can reach and interact with digital assets, the more naturally adoption grows.

Even as growth moderates from the exuberance of earlier cycles, the region's trajectory points toward maturity. Adoption is stabilizing into everyday behaviour, driven less by speculation and more by utility. Consumers now treat digital assets as part of their wider financial routines, using them for payments, remittances, and savings rather than experimentation – a pattern mirrored in the region's adoption of digital wallets[3] and real-time payments[4].

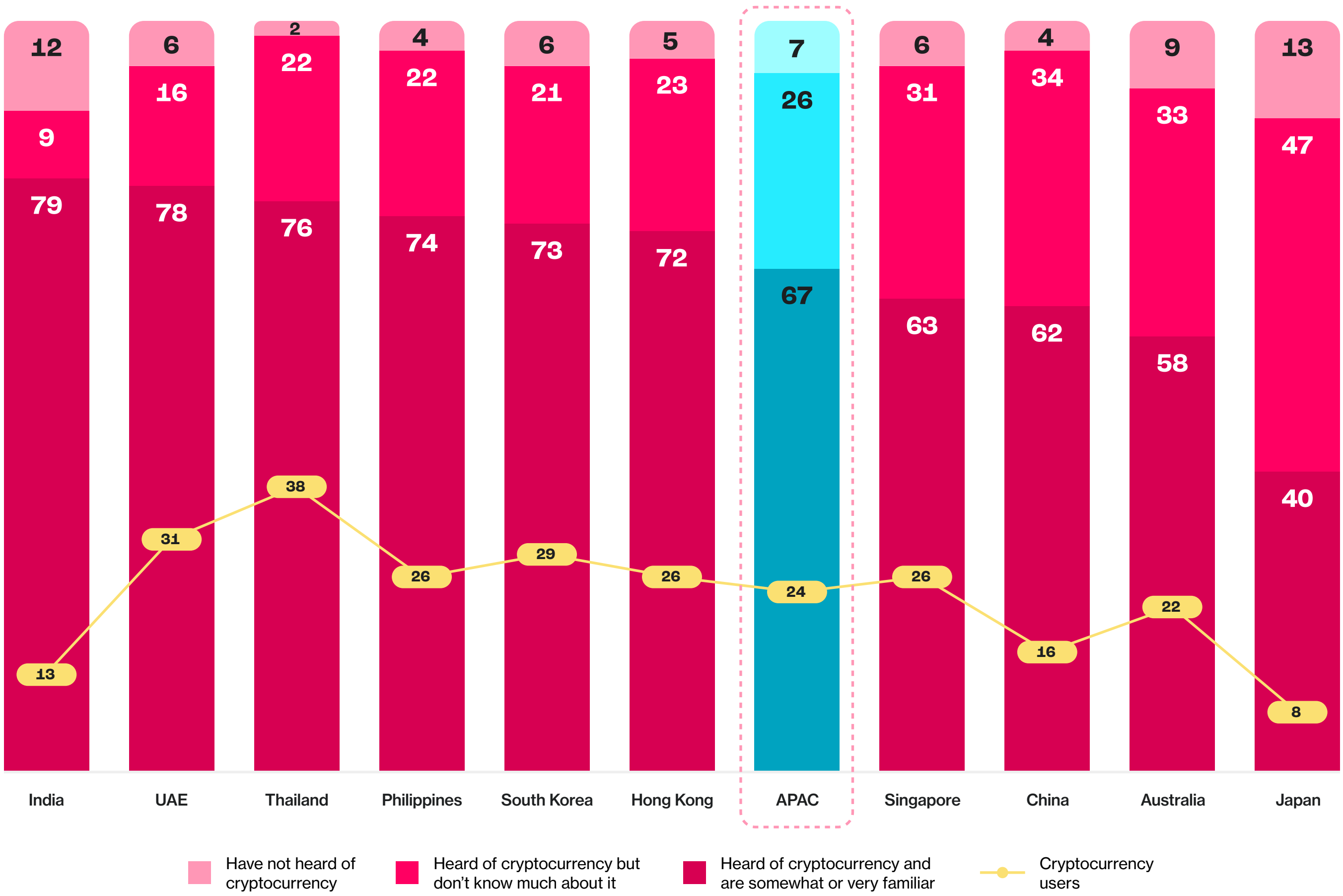
Awareness, Familiarity, and Use in Everyday Contexts

Awareness of cryptocurrency in APAC is now near universal, with around 95% of adults having heard of it. Familiarity, however, is less even. In emerging markets, 74% describe themselves as somewhat or very familiar with cryptocurrency, compared with 61% in developed economies. This suggests that depth of understanding – not awareness – will define the next frontier for participation.

Exhibit 1.4

Crypto awareness is near-universal across APAC, but familiarity and usage vary sharply by market.

Awareness, familiarity, and current usage of cryptocurrencies by market, % of general population



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Cryptocurrency usage weighted by internet penetration and awareness of cryptocurrency. "Users" represent respondents who currently own or use cryptocurrency. Totals may not sum to 100% due to rounding.

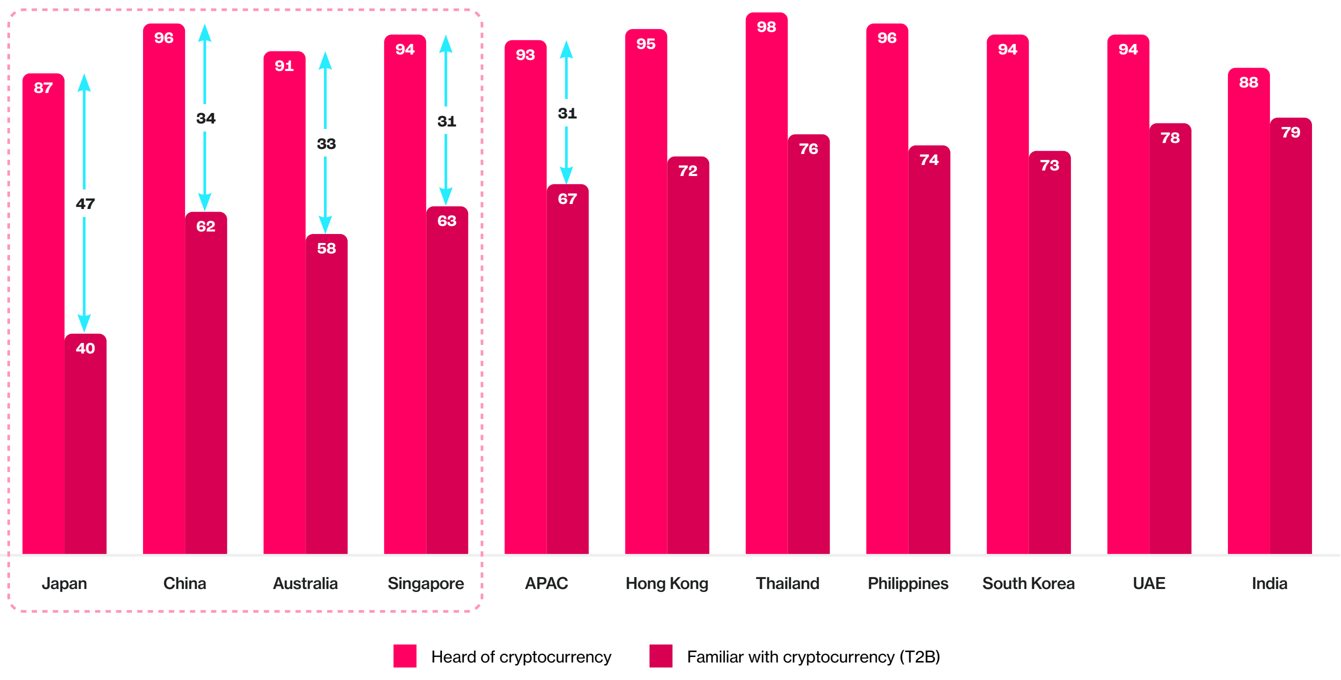
Cross-market evidence shows a growing gap between recognition and experience as digital finance ecosystems diversify. In Hong Kong, 95% of adults are aware of cryptocurrencies, but fewer than half are familiar with stablecoins (47%), tokenized real-world assets (32%), or decentralized finance (40%).

Across the region, 93% have heard of crypto, yet only 32% say they understand how it works. Financial literacy today depends less on exposure and more on contextual confidence – understanding how digital assets integrate with existing payment and banking systems rather than as a parallel economy.

Exhibit 1.5

Despite near universal awareness of cryptocurrency across Asia-Pacific, familiarity remains uneven across markets.

Share of adults who have heard of cryptocurrency and are familiar with it (Top 2 Box) by market, % of general population



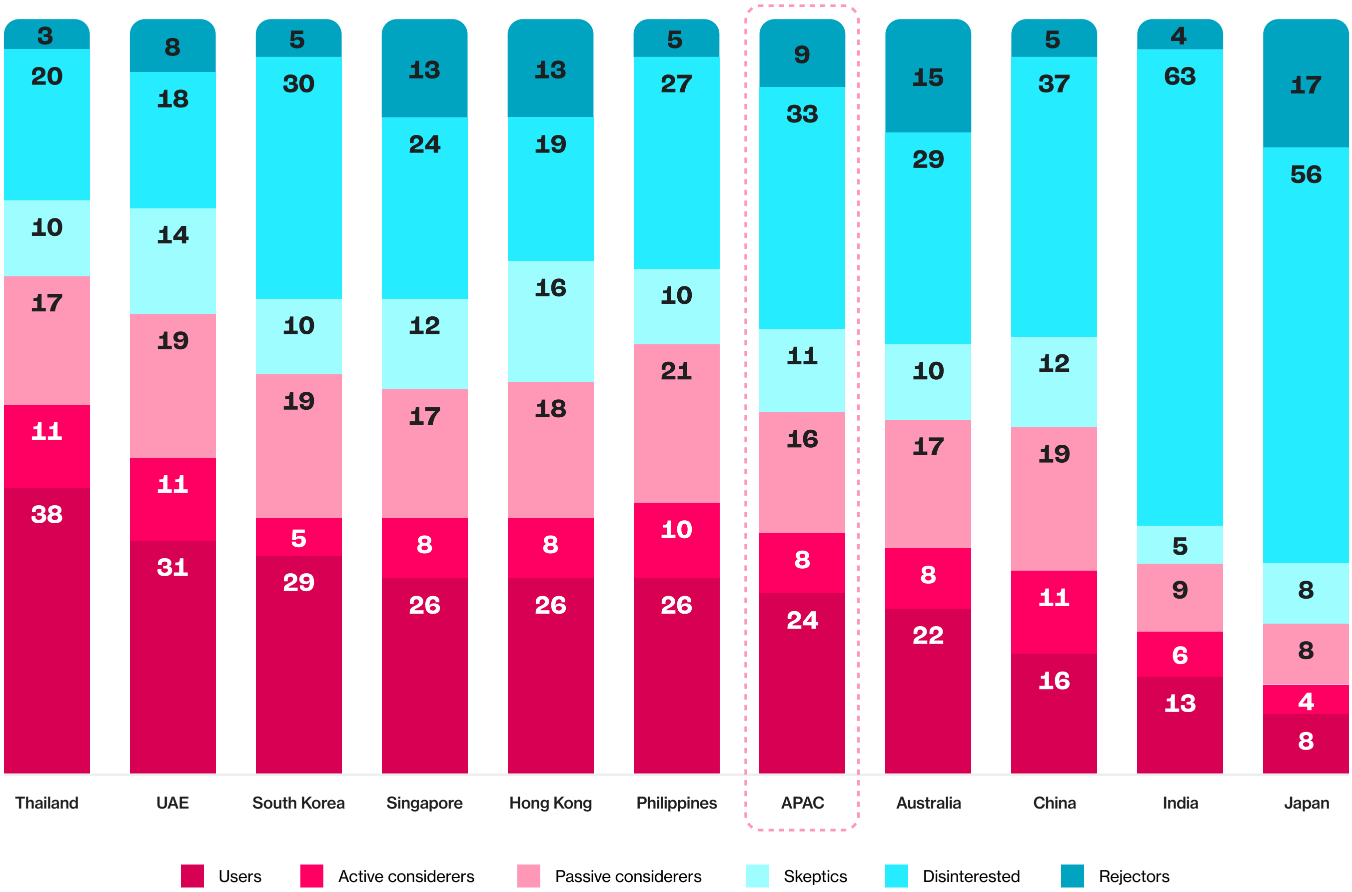
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Cryptocurrency usage weighted by internet penetration and awareness of cryptocurrency. Familiarity defined as Top 2 Box (somewhat or very familiar with cryptocurrency).

Across the ten surveyed markets, 33% of adults in emerging economies use crypto compared with 25% in developed ones. Emerging markets such as India, Indonesia, Vietnam, and the Philippines continue to drive momentum, fueled by remittances, mobile-wallet transactions, and inflation protection[5]. In highly banked markets like Japan and Australia, usage has stabilized as crypto becomes an additional investment or utility layer within existing financial systems.

Exhibit 1.6

Thailand and the UAE record the highest levels of crypto participation, while consumers in Japan and China remain cautious.

Distribution of crypto adoption and consideration segments by market, % of general population



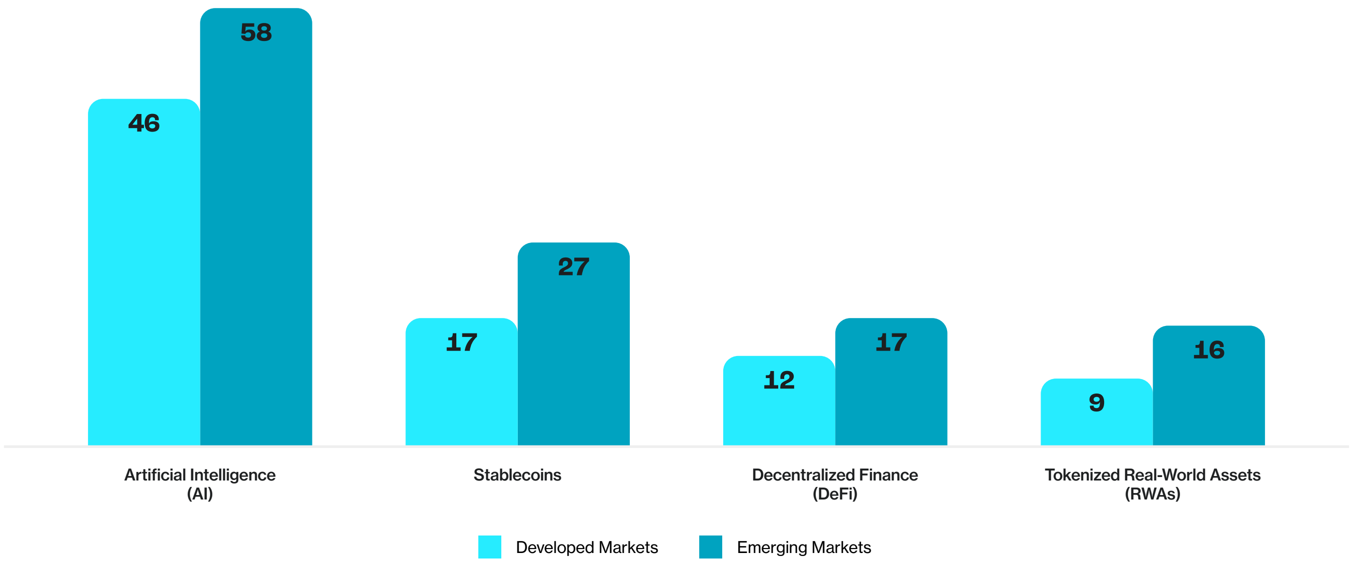
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Cryptocurrency usage weighted by internet penetration and awareness of cryptocurrency.

The same divide between awareness and experience appears in how different markets use emerging digital-finance tools. Adoption of technologies such as stablecoins, decentralized finance (DeFi), and tokenized assets is notably higher in emerging economies, where they serve practical needs like payments, remittances, and savings. This pattern reflects a recurring principle across the region: when digital assets feel useful, familiar, and easy to access, participation expands rapidly.

Exhibit 1.7

Emerging markets report higher usage of stablecoins and DeFi, reflecting faster adoption of accessible digital finance tools.

Share of adults who currently use selected emerging technologies, by region, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Statistical significance tested at the 95% confidence level; triangles indicate values significantly higher or lower than prior-year results.

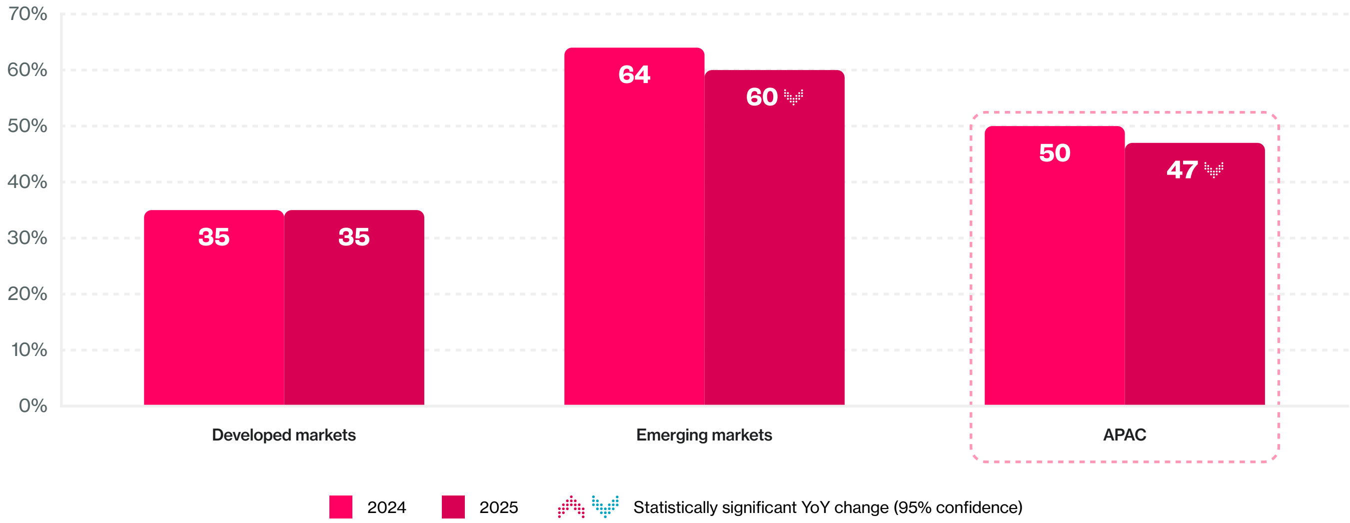
Confidence, Legitimacy, and the Normalization of Use

Across APAC, public confidence in cryptocurrency has eased modestly. Overall positive sentiment declined from 50% in 2024 to 47% in 2025 – a measured recalibration as markets move from optimism to practical evaluation. Sentiment fell in most markets except Australia, where it rose by five points, and India, where it remained steady.

Exhibit 1.8

Emerging markets sustain strong positive sentiment towards cryptocurrencies; developed markets remain measured.

Year-on-year change in overall positive sentiment (T2B) of cryptocurrencies by region, % of general population



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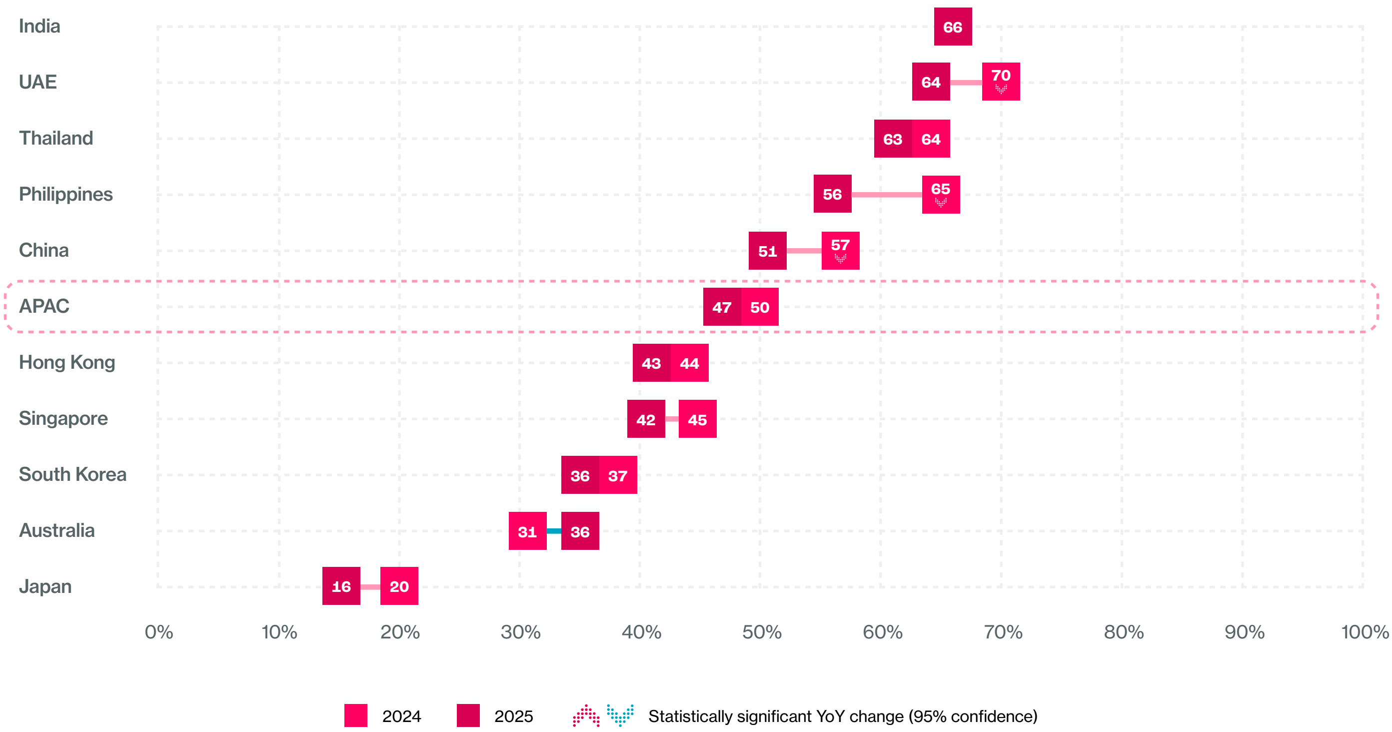
Confidence today mirrors earlier phases of digital-finance normalization. Optimism is strongest where practical value is most visible – India's remittance corridors, Indonesia's mobile-first economies, and Australia's regulated investment platforms – and more measured where utility feels remote. The regional pattern reflects maturity, not decline: confidence is rebuilding around transparency, predictability, and everyday benefit instead of market cycles or complexity.

Exhibit 1.9

Sentiment toward crypto softens across APAC, stabilizing only in India and modestly improving in Australia.

Year-on-year change in overall positive sentiment (T2B) of cryptocurrencies by market, % of general population



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Demographic Broadening and Diffusion of Adoption

Crypto use in APAC is no longer concentrated among young, tech-focused investors. Female ownership has risen from 20 to 22%, narrowing the historical gender gap. Participation among adults aged 45–54 now exceeds 20%, showing diffusion across age groups. Younger users remain most active (18–34), but older consumers are increasingly engaging through familiar channels – fintech apps, remittance services, and institutional products they already trust[6].

Exhibit 1.10

Female cryptocurrency participation increased in 2025, narrowing the historical gender gap observed in earlier years.

Year-on-year change in cryptocurrency ownership or usage, by gender, % of respondents

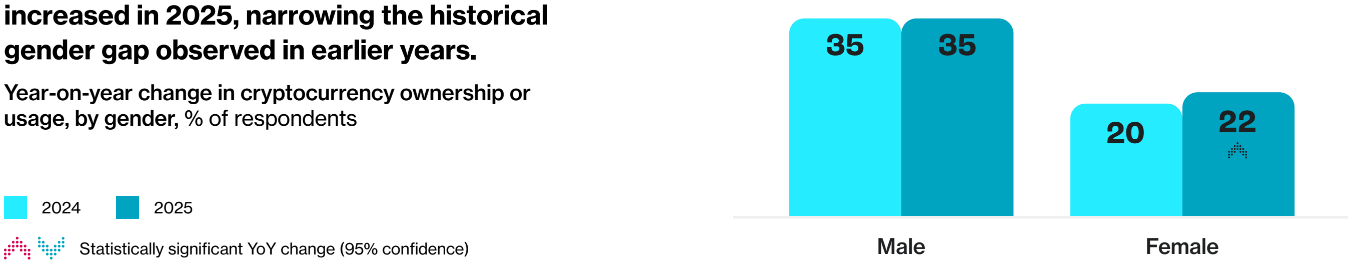

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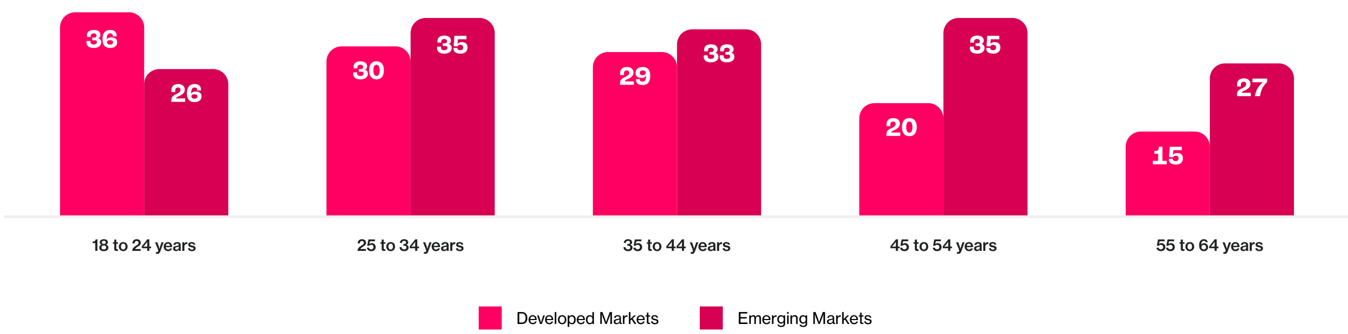
Exhibit 1.11

In emerging markets, crypto adoption is consistent across age groups, while developed markets show a skew towards younger cohorts.

Share of adults who currently own or use cryptocurrency, by age group and region, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks.

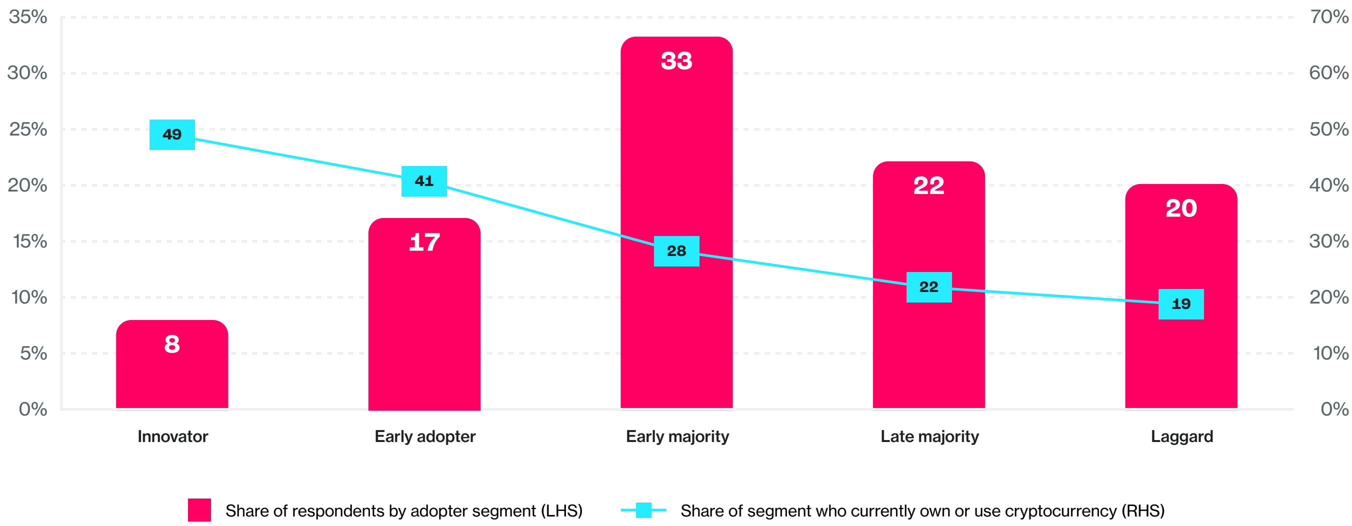
In emerging economies, participation continues to grow as access barriers decline. Awareness has reached saturation, but new users keep entering through accessible pathways such as exchange-linked wallets, super-app integrations, and regulated on/off-ramps.

The diffusion pattern aligns with Everett Rogers' innovation curve: innovators and early adopters (25%) now represent almost half of all users, while the early and late majority (55%) remain the largest untapped potential. As digital asset experiences become simpler and more trusted, these segments will drive the next phase of growth – as they did with mobile banking and real-time payments[7].

Exhibit 1.12

Innovators and early adopters represent one-quarter of adults but account for nearly half of current crypto users.

Share of adults by innovation adopter segment and proportion who currently own or use cryptocurrency, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks.

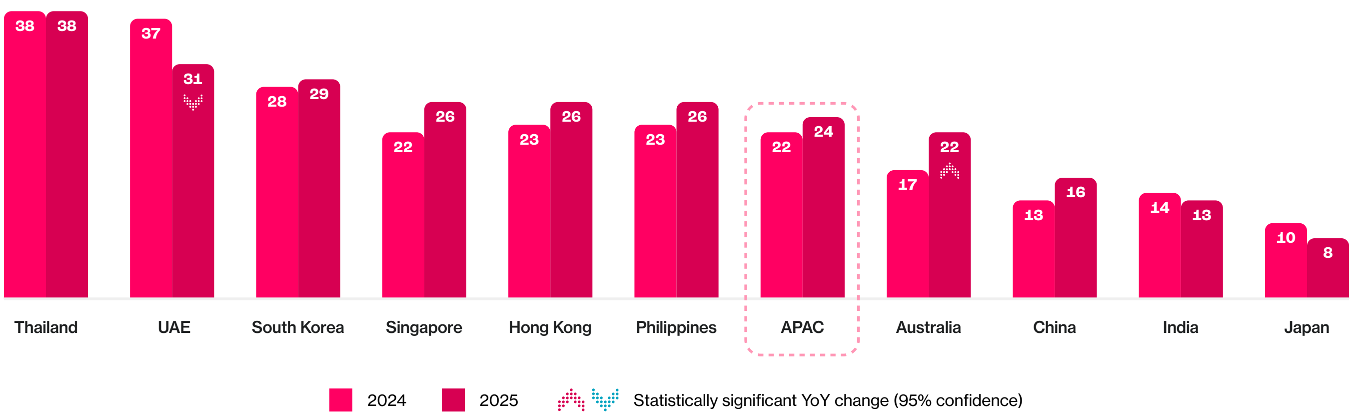
Regional Patterns: Diversity of Access Paths

Beneath APAC's shared momentum lie distinct national trajectories. Thailand (38%) and the UAE (31%) lead current usage, illustrating how clear rules and high digital engagement accelerate integration. South Korea (29%) and Singapore (28%) follow, while Australia (22%), China (16%), and India (13%) and Japan (8%) trail the regional average, reflecting either regulatory limits or lower perceived necessity[8].

Exhibit 1.13

Regional cryptocurrency adoption continues to rise modestly, reflecting a gradual transition from rapid growth to consolidation.

Year-on-year change in cryptocurrency adoption by market, % of general population



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Across these differences, a consistent behavioral pattern emerges: people are moving from experimentation to embedded use. In Vietnam and Indonesia, stablecoins increasingly power cross-border remittances. In the UAE, over 30% of residents hold crypto under clear licensing and AED-backed stablecoin frameworks. Even in Japan, recent tax reforms and the approval of yen-pegged stablecoins have renewed interest. Participation is now driven by **ease of use, perceived legitimacy, and fit within existing financial habits.**

From Regional Momentum to Local Realities

Asia–Pacific's digital asset landscape is defined by both shared progress and distinct realities. Across the region, adoption has evolved from experimentation to routine participation, driven by trust, usability, and everyday relevance. Yet beneath this momentum lie ten different stories of access – each shaped by its own blend of culture, infrastructure, and confidence. Understanding these local dynamics is essential to explaining why access takes different forms across APAC – and why the next chapter turns to those country-level drivers in detail.

References

[1] **Source**: a16z, State of Crypto 2025 (October 2025); Crypto.com Research, *Crypto Market Sizing H1 2025* (June 2025); United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division (2024). *World Population Prospects 2024—mid-year population estimates (1 July 2025)*; Protocol Theory analysis. See Appendix C for calculation notes.

[2] **Source**: CoinDesk & Protocol Theory, *Driven by Demand: The People-Powered Crypto Movement in Asia-Pacific* (December 2024).

[3] **Source**: Mercuryo & Protocol Theory, *Beyond Early Adopters: What It Takes for Crypto to Matter in Everyday Life* (2025).

[4] **Source**: Worldpay, *Global Payments Report 2025* (March 2025).

[5] **Source**: Chainalysis, The 2025 Geography of Crypto Report: What Regional Trends Reveal About What's Next in Crypto (2025).

[6] **Source**: Chainalysis, The 2025 Geography of Crypto Report: What Regional Trends Reveal About What's Next in Crypto (2025).

[7] **Source**: Al-Jabri, Ibrahim & Sohail, M. Sadiq, *Mobile Banking Adoption: Application of Diffusion of Innovation Theory (Journal of Electronic Commerce Research*, Vol. 13, No. 4, pp. 379–391, 2012).

[8] **Note**: India's lower overall adoption reflects limited internet penetration (46.5%). When measured among internet-connected adults, adoption rises to 28.3%, indicating strong participation once access is available.

Chapter 2:
Country-Level Adoption and Local Drivers

At a Glance: Ten Markets, Ten Modes of Access

Asia–Pacific's adoption story is unified by momentum but diversified by experience. Each country's path reflects a different balance of necessity, design, and trust – the forces that determine how people reach and rely on digital assets in daily life.

Key insights

- **Adoption rates vary widely:** from 38% in Thailand to 8% in Japan, averaging roughly 24% across the region.
- **Positive sentiment remains strong** in Thailand (63%), India (66%), and the UAE (64%), where regulation and real-world use cases reinforce confidence.
- **Familiarity predicts use:** it explains half of individual adoption variance in emerging markets and more than a third in developed ones.
- **Motivations divide by context:** investment and innovation in developed economies; utility and inclusion in emerging ones.
- **Barriers are contextual:** risk perception in developed markets; usability and comprehension in emerging markets.
- **Access and relevance together explain** more than half of cross-country adoption variance.

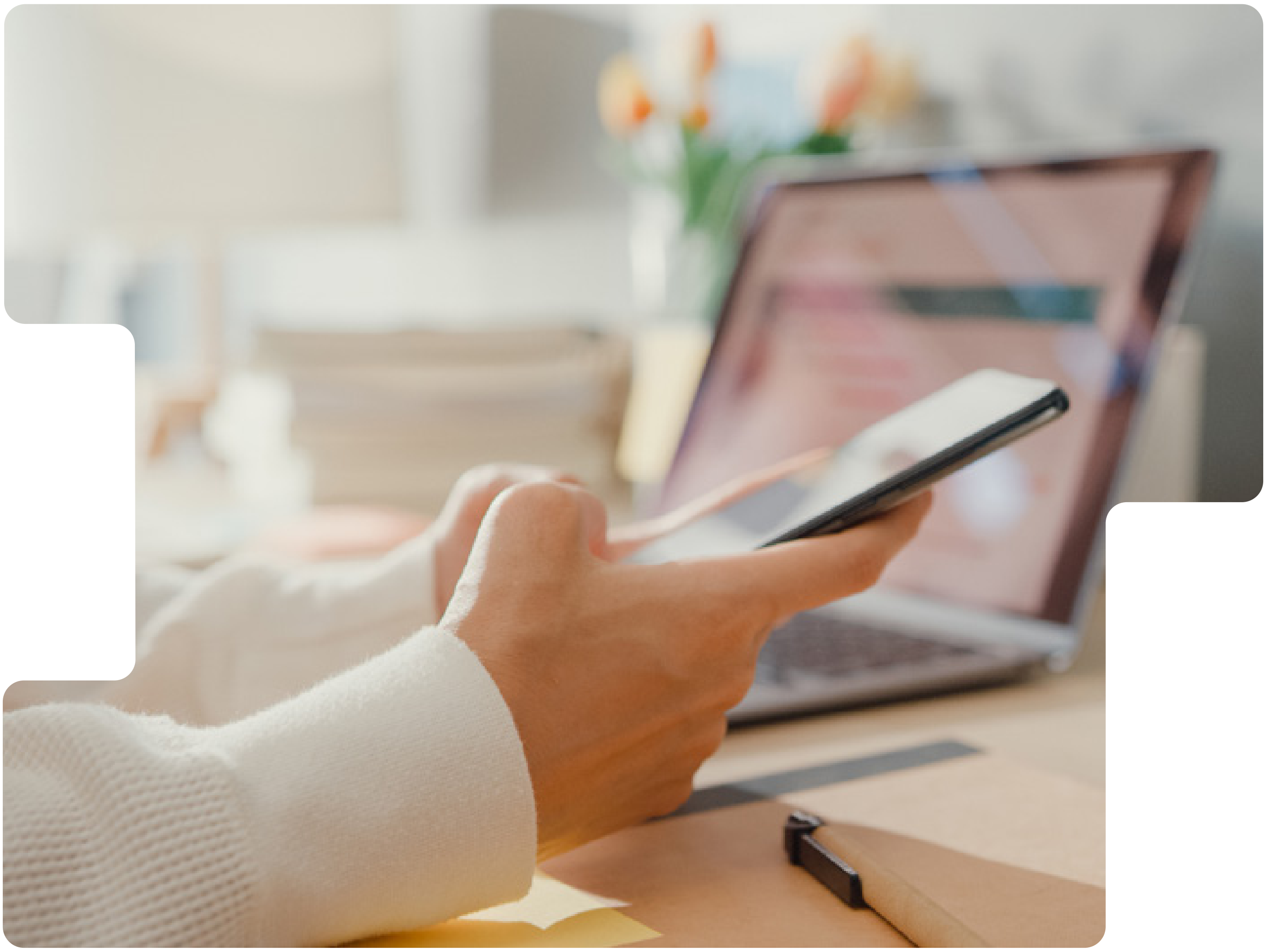
The diversity of APAC's markets demonstrates a single principle: **access is local.** How people experience confidence, clarity, and convenience determines how fast adoption becomes participation.

Understanding Why Adoption Differs

Asia–Pacific's digital asset markets have advanced together in scale yet diverged in character. The region's shared momentum is unmistakable, but its diversity defines it. Each economy sits at a unique intersection of economic need, regulatory maturity, and cultural attitudes toward technology, creating adoption patterns that reflect local realities as much as global trends.

In some markets, crypto operates as essential infrastructure – a means of sending money, preserving value, or accessing services unavailable through traditional finance. In others, it functions as an investment instrument or a novel means of portfolio diversification. These contrasts show that participation is shaped less by perception or principle than by confidence, ease, and relevance to everyday financial life.

The following sections trace these dynamics – how sentiment, familiarity, and motivation interact with local systems to enable, or limit, access across the region.



The Local Picture: Sentiment, Familiarity, and Adoption

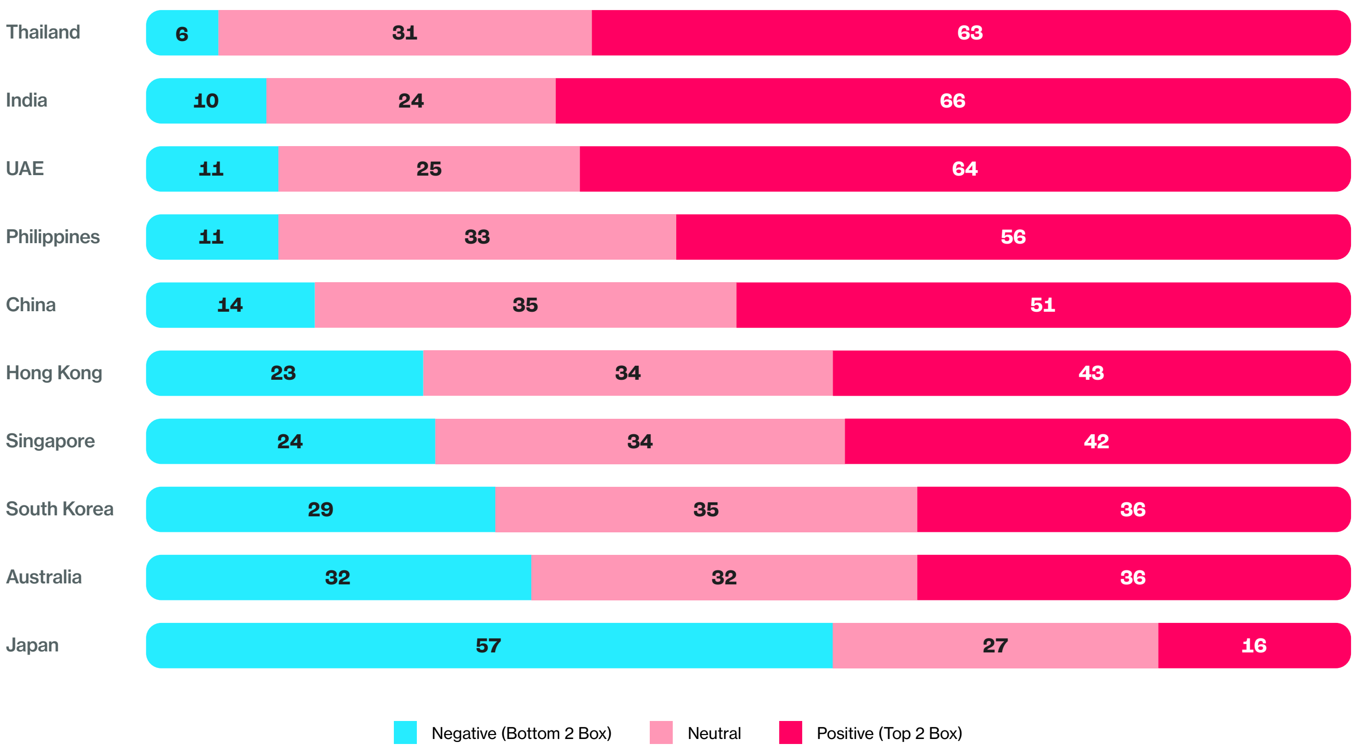
APAC's regional adoption average of roughly 24% conceals striking variation – from 38% in Thailand to 8% in Japan. Developed markets narrowed the gap slightly in 2025, but public sentiment softened overall. Japan remains a clear outlier, with 57% of adults expressing an unfavorable view, more than all emerging markets combined.

Positive sentiment remains strongest in Thailand (63%), India (66%), and the UAE (64%), where consumer-facing payment and remittance use cases make crypto visible and useful in daily contexts[1].

Exhibit 2.1

Positive sentiment toward crypto holds firm across APAC, but developed markets show signs of fatigue.

Share of adults expressing positive, neutral, or negative sentiment toward cryptocurrency by market, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Sentiment measured on a 5-point scale; results shown as Top 2 Box (Somewhat positive/Very positive) and Bottom 2 Box (Somewhat negative/Very negative).

Sentiment and Adoption Move Together

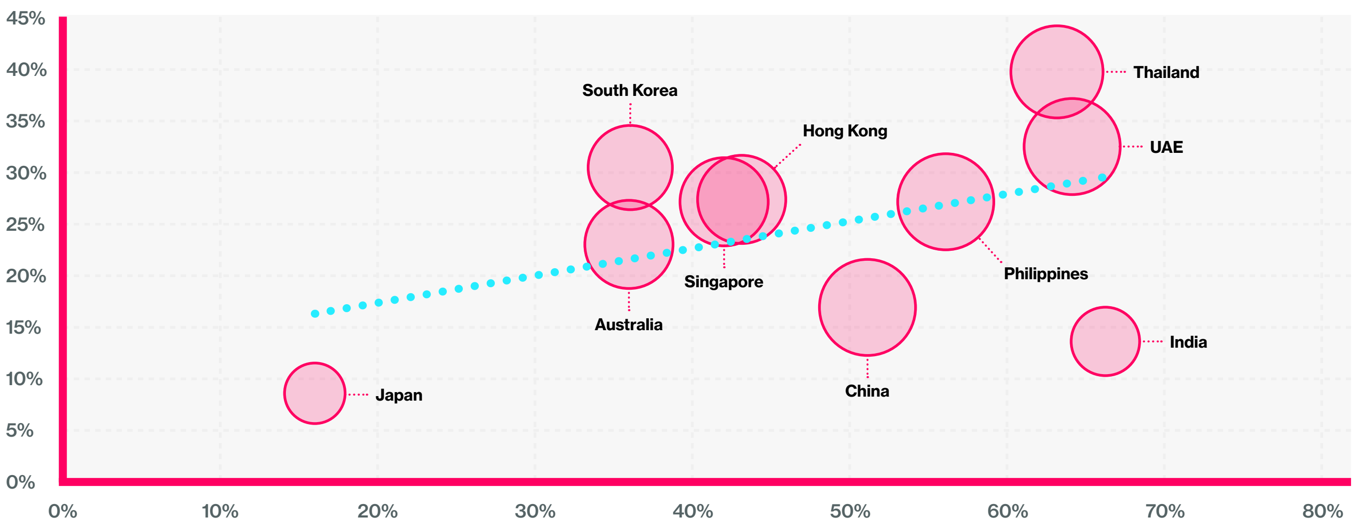
When plotted against national adoption rates, sentiment proves a reliable predictor. Regression analysis indicates that overall favorability explains roughly 20% of cross-country variance. Where optimism exists, adoption tends to follow – but familiarity and usability amplify that effect.

Exhibit 2.2

Public favorability toward cryptocurrency is a strong predictor of adoption across APAC markets.

Relationship between overall sentiment toward cryptocurrency (Top 2 Box favorable) and adoption rate (% of adults who currently own or use cryptocurrency), general population

Note: Bubble size represents total consideration (% Active and Passive Considerers, per market)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Sentiment measured on a 5-point scale; results shown as Top 2 Box (Somewhat positive/Very positive). Adoption defined as self-reported current ownership or use of cryptocurrency.

In developed economies, optimism has plateaued as crypto shifts from a retail story to an institutional one. In emerging economies, momentum continues through necessity and opportunity – people adopt tools that help them move, save, and secure money. Explaining these differences requires understanding the beliefs and experiences that underpin them.

The Belief Effect: What People Think Drives What They Do

Across APAC, confidence bridges awareness and action. Familiarity with cryptocurrencies and digital assets is the single strongest predictor of individual adoption, explaining 38% of variance in developed markets and 50% in emerging ones after controlling for demographics.

Three expectation dimensions consistently influence usage:

1. **Utility (Everyday Relevance)**
   Confidence that digital assets can serve ordinary purchases or transfers.
2. **Trust (Reliability)**
   Assurance that digital assets can function safely alongside banks.
3. **Inclusion (Social Benefit)**
   Perception that digital assets promote financial access globally.

Their relative influence differs by market development level:

Exhibit 2.3
Relative importance of belief dimensions in predicting crypto adoption, by market type.

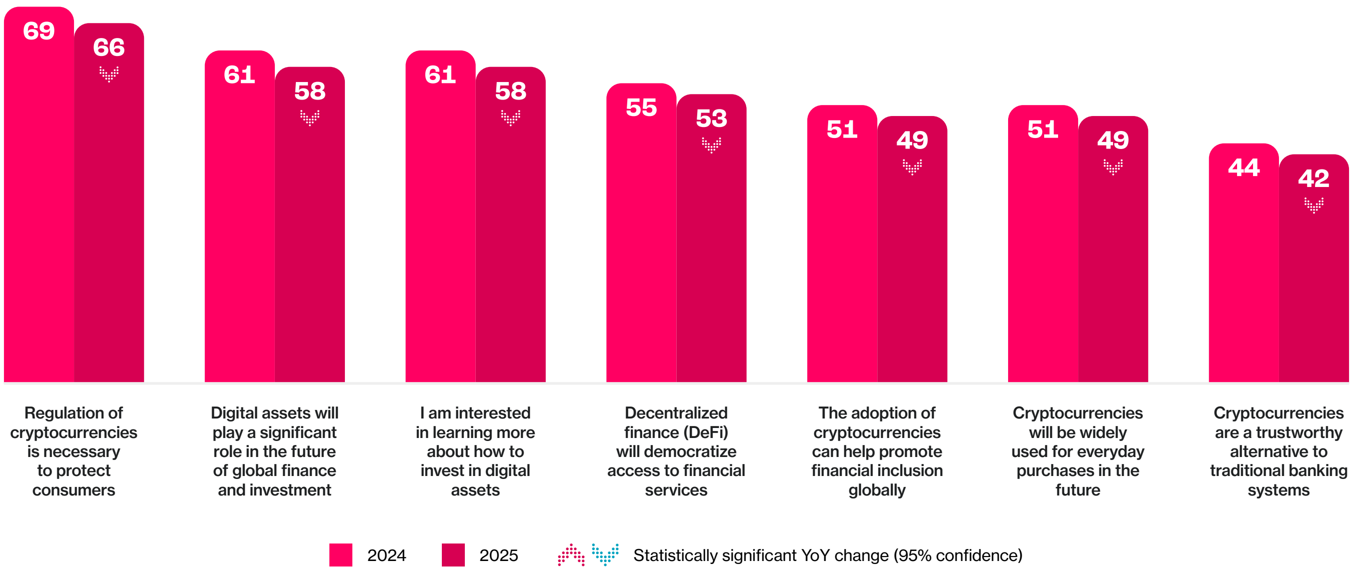
Market	Utility	Trust	Inclusion
Emerging markets	13%	8%	6%
Developed markets	8%	8%	10%

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; Shapley relative-importance regression model estimating variance in individual-level cryptocurrency adoption (n = 4,020, general-population sample, internet-connected adults 18–64 across 10 APAC markets).

Exhibit 2.4

Confidence in crypto's long-term potential remains high, though enthusiasm has moderated slightly year on year.

Year-on-year change in agreement with statements about cryptocurrency and digital assets across APAC, % of respondents



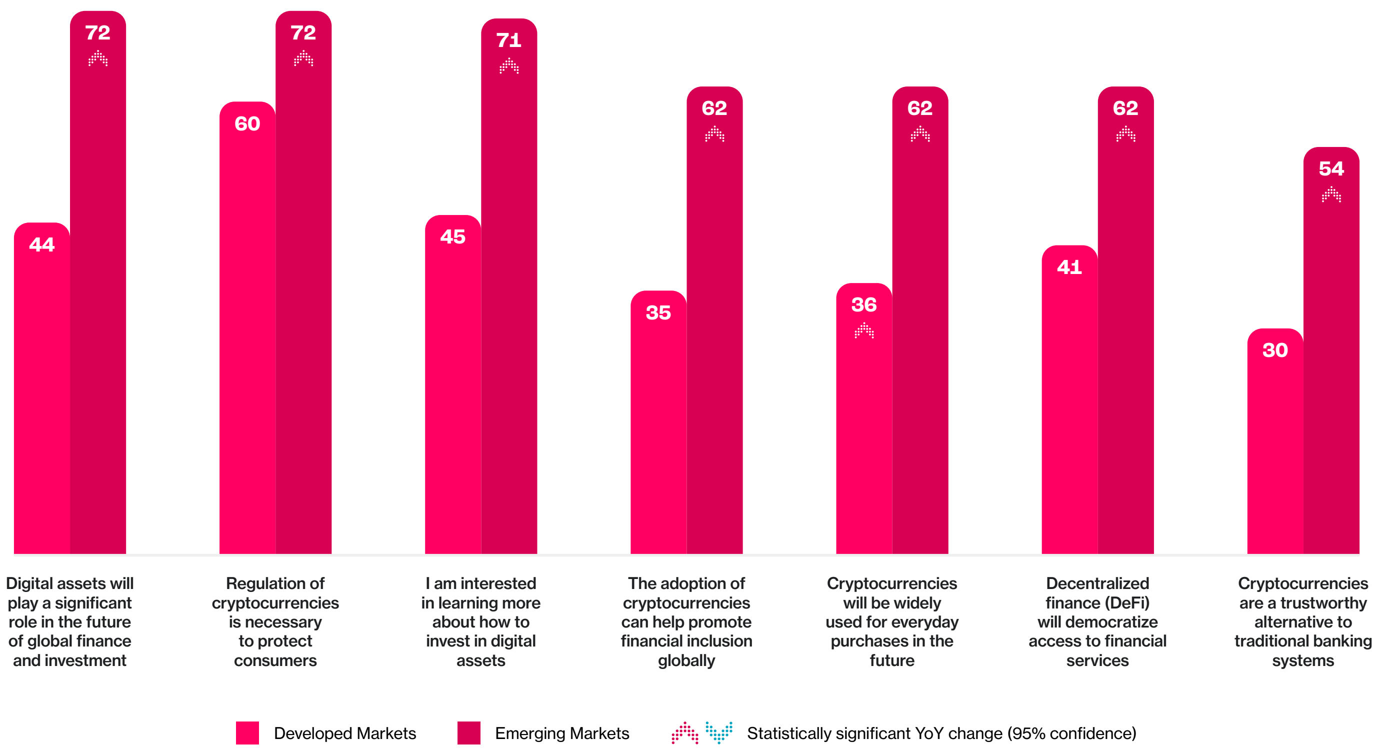
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Cryptocurrency-related attitudes measured on a 5-point agreement scale; results shown as Top 2 Box (agree/strongly agree).

Agreement that *"digital assets will play a significant role in global finance"* declined from 69 to 66%, alongside a small drop in perceived trustworthiness – evidence of maturing expectations rather than disengagement.

Exhibit 2.5

Emerging markets continue to outpace developed peers in optimism, trust, and perceived value of crypto.

Top 2 Box (T2B) agreement with statements about cryptocurrency and digital assets by region, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Cryptocurrency-related attitudes measured on a 5-point agreement scale; results shown as Top 2 Box (agree/strongly agree).

In developed economies, people tend to see crypto as a sign of progress and modern finance. In emerging markets, it's valued more for what it can do – helping people make payments, send money, or save. Together, these perspectives show two forms of access: one shaped by social progress, the other by everyday practicality.

Motivations for Use: Diverging Reasons for Engagement

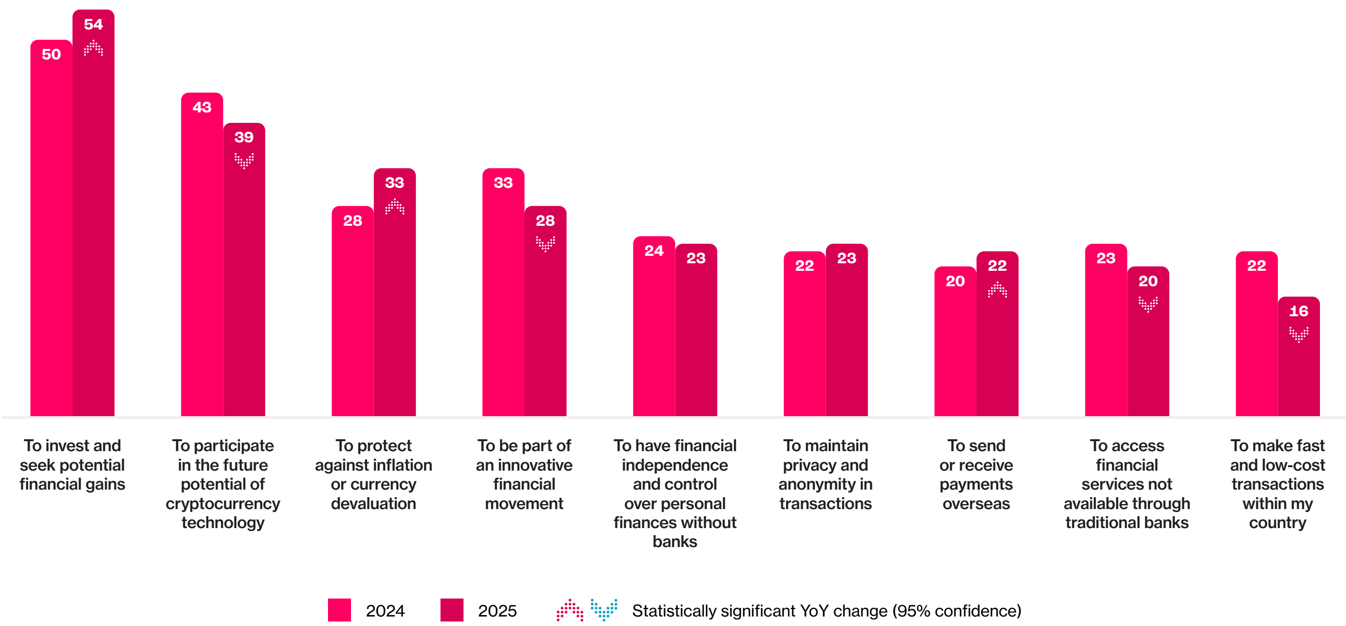
Motivations reveal how people position crypto within their financial lives. Across the region, investment and participation in emerging technologies remain the top reasons for engagement. Yet the relative weight of these motivations continues to evolve, reflecting the different ways people experience value across markets.

In **developed economies**, crypto use remains primarily aspiration-led – driven by investing for potential financial gains (54%) and participating in the future of crypto technology (39%). However, a notable change since 2024 is the rise of inflation protection, which now ranks above the desire to be part of an innovative financial movement. This shift suggests a gradual transition from symbolic to functional motivations as digital assets become a more established part of financial portfolios.

Exhibit 2.6

Investment remains the primary motivation for crypto use in developed markets, while utility-driven reasons have softened.

Year-on-year change in top motivations for using or considering cryptocurrency, crypto users and active considerers in developed markets, % of respondents



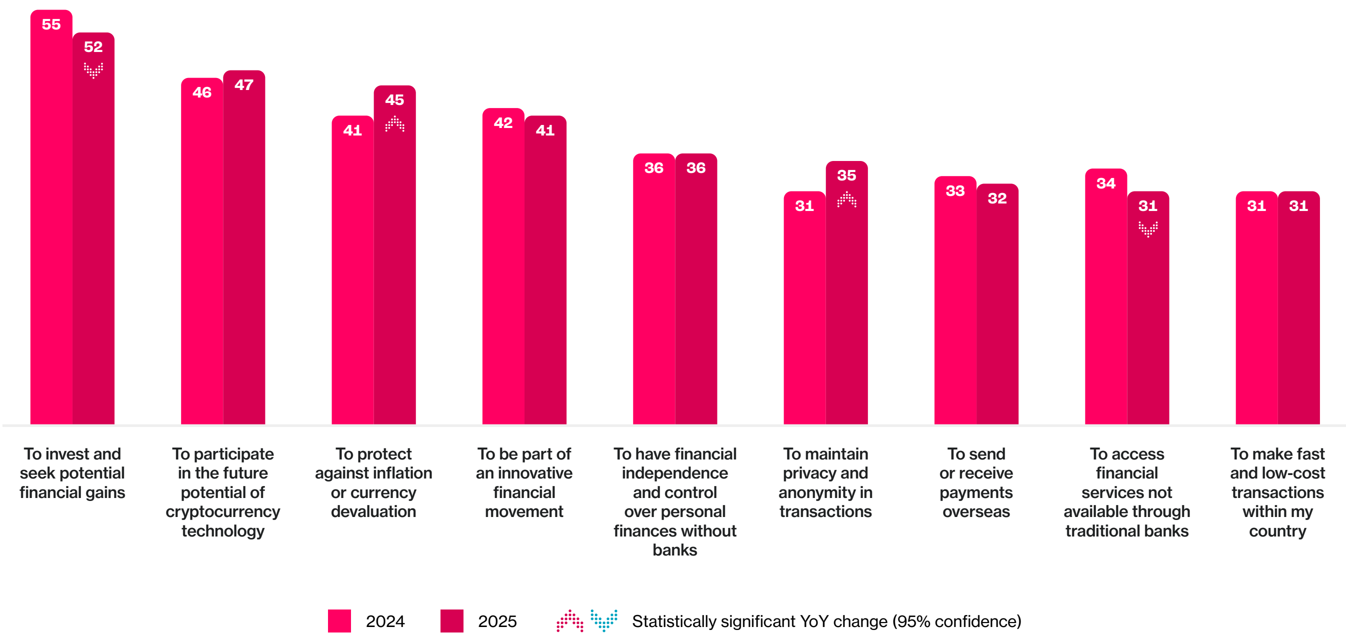
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: cryptocurrency users and active considerers in developed markets (Australia, Singapore, Hong Kong, Japan, and South Korea).

In **emerging economies**, motivations are broader and more practical. While investment (52%) and participation in innovation (47%) still rank highly, people are equally motivated by financial independence (45%), inflation protection (36%), and low-cost transactions (35%). These patterns highlight crypto's role as financial infrastructure – a tool that complements, and in some cases substitutes for, traditional banking.

Exhibit 2.7

Crypto motivations in emerging markets remain broad, with sustained interest in innovation and inclusion.

Year-on-year change in top motivations for using or considering cryptocurrency, crypto users and active considerers in emerging markets, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: cryptocurrency users and active considerers in emerging markets (China, India, Thailand, Philippines, and UAE).

Together, the data confirm that intent across APAC is anchored in **access and utility**. Where crypto feels useful and easy to integrate into existing habits – whether as an investment, payment method, or savings tool – participation strengthens naturally.

Barriers to Adoption: The Friction Points

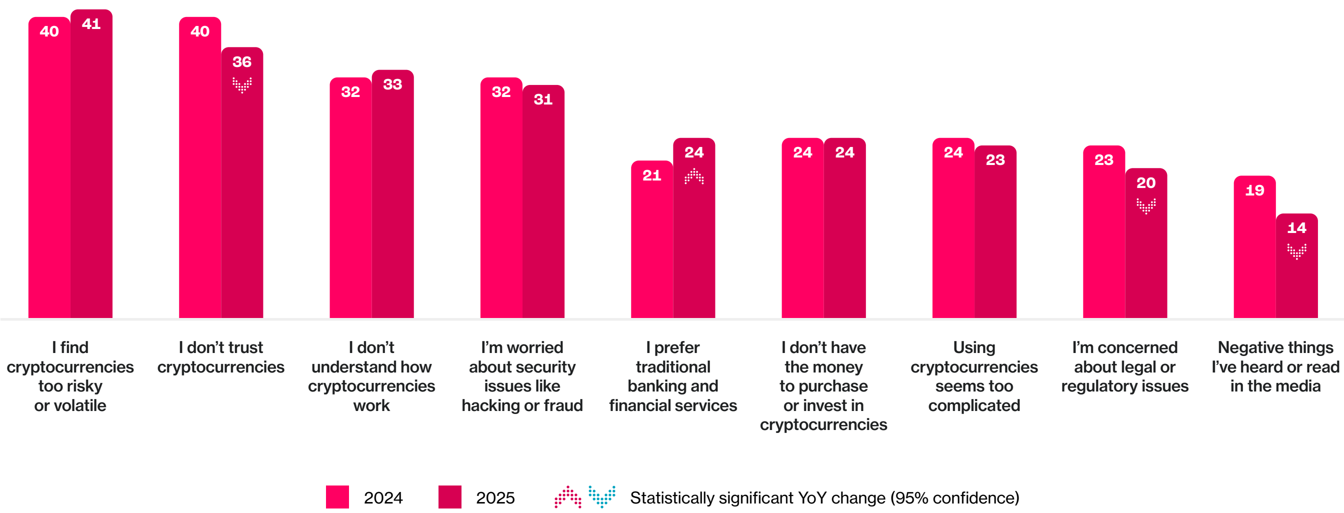
Barriers are as revealing as motivations. While risk, trust, and complexity remain universal, their weight varies across contexts.

In **developed markets**, psychological barriers dominate: volatility (41%), lack of trust (36%), and complexity (33%). These stem less from access issues than from reputational memories of past volatility.

Exhibit 2.8

Risk and trust remain the dominant barriers to crypto adoption in developed markets, showing little change year-on-year.

Year-on-year change in top barriers to adoption for non-users and passive considerers in developed markets, % of respondents



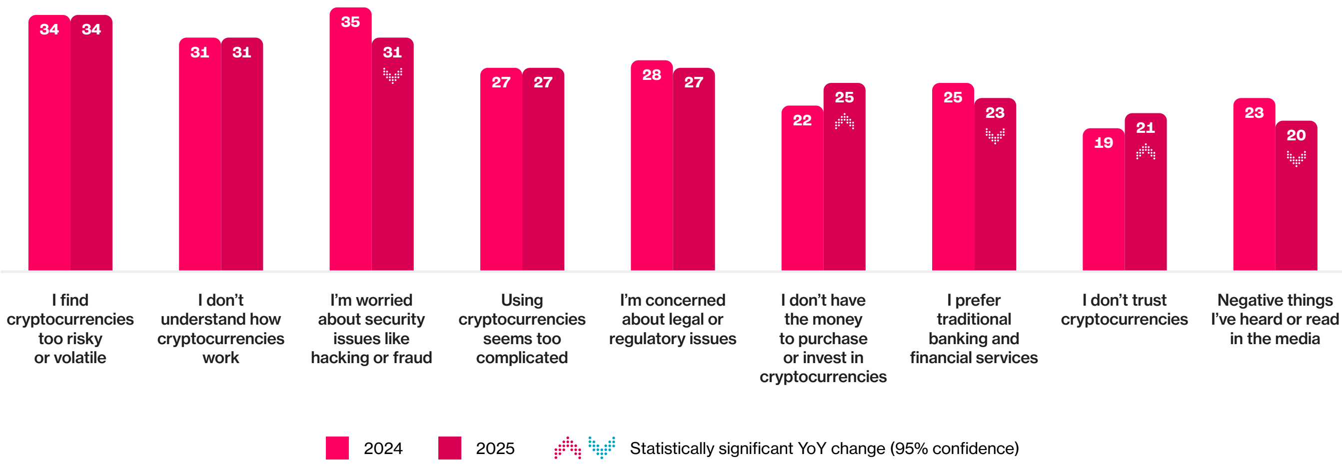
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: non-users and passive considerers in developed markets (Australia, Singapore, Hong Kong, Japan, and South Korea). Respondents selected all barriers applicable to their lack of adoption or consideration.

In **emerging markets**, functional barriers matter more: understanding (31%), security concerns (31%), and complexity (27%). Here, people are not skeptical of the concept, but cautious about the process. The experience of India's UPI system shows how intuitive design, open infrastructure, and zero-cost, user-friendly interfaces can overcome such friction and translate curiosity into confidence. Year-on-year, risk perceptions in developed economies remain largely unchanged. Concerns about volatility and safety persist, maintaining a psychological distance between consumers and providers.

Exhibit 2.9

Risk and trust remain the dominant deterrents, showing minimal change year on year.

Year-on-year change in top barriers to adoption for non-users and passive considerers in emerging markets, % of respondents



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: cryptocurrency users and active considerers in emerging markets (China, India, Thailand, Philippines, and UAE).

The Local Drivers of Behavior: Why Adoption Differs

Country-level regressions show that **sentiment and familiarity together explain more than half of the variance** in adoption rates across APAC.

The pattern is clear:

- **Thailand and the UAE** combine high confidence with strong access infrastructure – government support, licensed exchanges, and everyday payment use.
- **India and the Philippines** benefit from remittance ecosystems that normalize wallet use and strengthen familiarity.
- **Japan and Australia** illustrate how risk perception can temper adoption even under favorable conditions.

This creates a maturity gradient:

- **Emerging markets → Functional adoption** (payments, inclusion, inflation protection).
- **Developed markets → Institutional integration** (integration, reputation rebuilding).

The conclusion is consistent across markets: behavior follows access and relevance. When digital assets align with existing habits, adoption accelerates; when they remain abstract or investment-centric, progress slows.

From Access to Enablement

Across Asia–Pacific, adoption reflects lived context more than regional average. Economic structure, culture, and technology shape distinct national patterns of confidence and capability. As these differences widen, policy and infrastructure become crucial – not to create demand, but to enable access.

The next chapter explores that connection, showing how regulation serves as the region's foundation for predictable, trustworthy participation – an **enabler of access, not a driver of demand.**

References
[1] **Source**: CoinDesk & Protocol Theory, *Driven by Demand: The People-Powered Crypto Movement in Asia-Pacific* (December 2024).

Chapter 3: Regulation: The Enabler, Not the Driver

At a Glance: Rules That Build Confidence

Regulation has become one of Asia–Pacific's most influential access enablers. Across ten markets, policymakers are replacing reaction with readiness, building frameworks that make participation predictable, safe, and trusted.

Key insights

- **Regulation is converging globally:** from the FSB's 2023 global framework to MiCAR (2024 EU), the GENIUS Act (US 2025), and aligned reforms in Singapore, Hong Kong, Japan, Korea, and Australia.
- **Every major APAC market** now operates a virtual-asset service-provider (VASP) or digital asset licensing regime grounded in the *same activity, same risk, same rule* principle.
- **66% of adults** across APAC agree that regulation of cryptocurrencies is necessary to protect consumers, a level unchanged year-on-year.
- **Support is strongest in emerging markets (72%),** where rules are seen as protection and pathways to participation.
- **Crypto users are more supportive** of regulation than non-users (77% vs. 62%), suggesting they recognize that clear rules are essential to enabling access and participation.

Across the region, regulation now functions as infrastructure, providing the connective tissue that turns innovation into usable, inclusive finance.

From Rules to Readiness

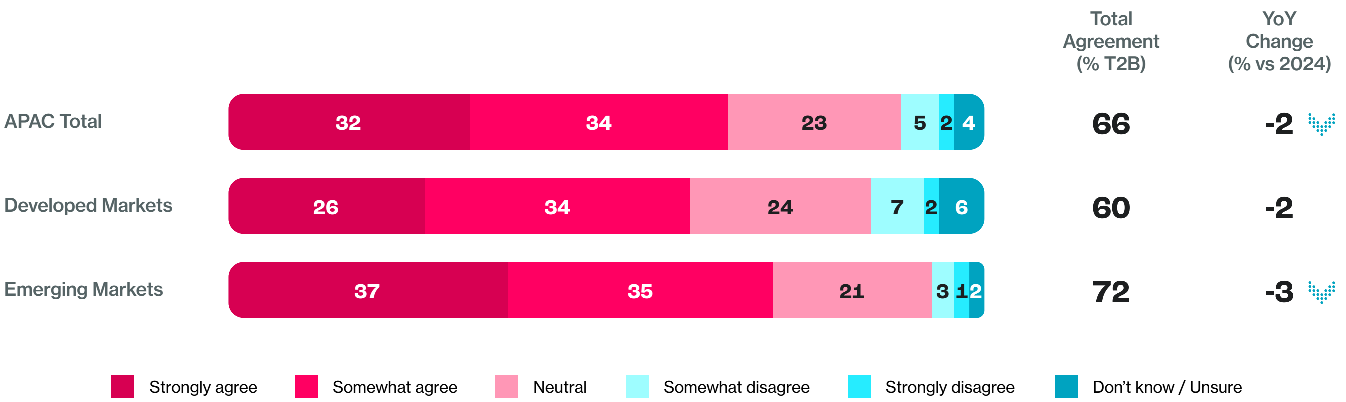
Regulation has become the scaffolding of access across Asia–Pacific's digital asset landscape. Policymakers are translating lessons from past volatility into frameworks that balance innovation with accountability. The impact is visible not just in policy but in sentiment and behaviour.

Two-thirds of adults across APAC (66%) agree that regulation of cryptocurrencies is needed to protect consumers. Support is highest in emerging markets (72%) – where regulatory visibility often substitutes for institutional trust – and lower in developed economies (60%), where compliance and consumer protection are already deeply embedded within financial systems.

Exhibit 3.1

Public support for cryptocurrency regulation remains strong across APAC, led by emerging markets that see oversight as protection rather than constraint.

Share of adults agreeing with the statement "Regulation of cryptocurrencies is necessary to protect consumers," by region (% of population aged 18–64)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent responses to the statement "Regulation of cryptocurrencies is necessary to protect consumers," showing Top 2 Box agreement ("strongly agree" or "somewhat agree") and year-on-year change from 2024 results.

Public Confidence and the Meaning of Regulation

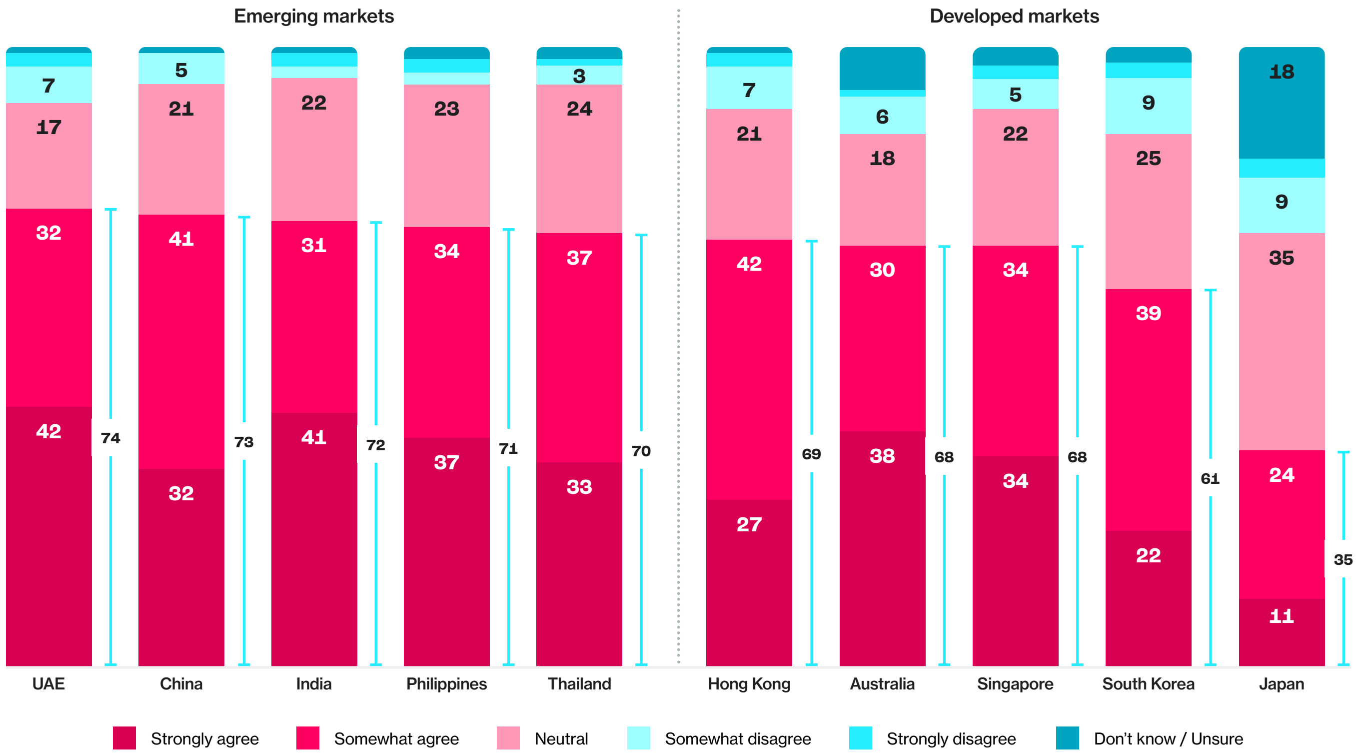
Support for oversight is broad, but its motivations differ. In emerging economies, endorsement is nearly universal: seven in ten adults or more across the UAE, China, India, the Philippines, and Thailand agree that regulation is essential to safeguard consumers.

In developed markets, sentiment is more nuanced. Roughly two-thirds of adults in Hong Kong, Australia, and Singapore support regulation, compared with fewer than half in Japan. This divergence reflects differing stages of market confidence. In emerging economies, regulation fills an institutional gap – acting as a proxy for trust and signaling that participation is legitimate. In mature markets, where extensive consumer protections already exist, regulation functions less as a bridge to access and more as a means of managing risk.

Exhibit 3.2

Confidence in regulation as consumer protection is near universal in emerging markets but more divided in developed ones.

Share of adults agreeing with the statement "Regulation of cryptocurrencies is necessary to protect consumers," by region (% of population aged 18–64)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent responses to the statement "Regulation of cryptocurrencies is necessary to protect consumers," showing Top 2 Box agreement ("strongly agree" or "somewhat agree") and year-on-year change from 2024 results.

The underlying drivers of this support reveal two distinct modes of regulatory confidence. In developed markets, it is cautious and defensive – a desire to reduce exposure to fraud, volatility, and complexity. In emerging markets, support is optimistic and inclusion-driven – a belief that regulation is the pathway to legitimacy and broader access. The first sees regulation as a bridge; the second, as a shield.

This duality underscores how access and trust intersect. In developing markets, oversight builds the conditions for first-time participation. In developed markets, it reinforces confidence through consistency. In both, regulation serves the same human need – to make participation feel safe, legitimate, and transparent.

Exhibit 3.3

In developed markets, fraud, volatility, and comprehension concerns dominate belief drivers behind support for cryptocurrency regulation.

Relative importance of belief drivers explaining support for cryptocurrency regulation, derived from Shapley regression model (developed markets; adults 18–64; September 2025)

Relative importance %

22.3%
Concern about scams and fraud

19.1%
Belief that investing in crypto is too risky due to price volatility

14.4%
Find digital assets confusing and difficult to understand

11.8%
Belief that crypto facilitates illegal activities and should be restricted

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; Shapley relative-importance regression models explaining support for cryptocurrency regulation, based on nationally representative surveys of 4,020 internet-connected adults (18–64) across 10 APAC markets, conducted 18–26 September 2025. Models estimated separately for developed (n = 2,004; Australia, Hong Kong SAR, Japan, Singapore, South Korea) and emerging markets (n = 2,016; India, Indonesia, Philippines, Thailand, UAE).

Exhibit 3.4

In emerging markets, optimism and inclusion drive support for regulation alongside concern about volatility and fraud.

Relative importance of belief drivers explaining support for cryptocurrency regulation, derived from Shapley regression model (developed markets; adults 18–64; September 2025)

Relative importance %

17.6%
Belief that digital assets will play a significant role in the future

17.3%
Belief that investing in crypto is too risky due to price volatility

16.3%
Concern about scams and fraud

14.9%
Belief that cryptocurrencies can help promote financial inclusion globally

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; Shapley relative-importance regression models explaining support for cryptocurrency regulation, based on nationally representative surveys of 4,020 internet-connected adults (18–64) across 10 APAC markets, conducted 18–26 September 2025. Models estimated separately for developed (n = 2,004; Australia, Hong Kong SAR, Japan, Singapore, South Korea) and emerging markets (n = 2,016; India, Indonesia, Philippines, Thailand, UAE).

From Perception to Practice

The evolution from perception to practice is already underway. Across Asia–Pacific, regulators are translating public demand for confidence into formal frameworks that govern how digital assets are issued, traded, and safeguarded.

What was once a patchwork of national experiments is becoming a connected regional model built on shared global principles. As rules become visible and predictable, they transform from abstract policy into practical access infrastructure – the mechanism that turns trust into participation for consumers, businesses, and institutions alike.

National Perspectives: From Patchwork to Policy

In 2025, APAC's regulatory landscape has shifted from fragmentation to alignment, converging around global norms and shared standards for licensing, custody, and disclosure. All major jurisdictions are now anchored in global standards set by the FSB, IOSCO, and FATF under the principle of *same activity, same risk, same rule*[1].

Exhibit 3.5

Summary of 2024–25 regulatory reforms in developed APAC markets (Australia, Hong Kong, Japan, Singapore, South Korea).

Market	2024–25 Regulatory Highlights
Australia	***Licensing the Rails*** Australia's *Digital Asset Platform (DAP)* and *Tokenized Custody Platform (TCP)* bills (2025) represent the region's most comprehensive infrastructure-oriented framework. Under the proposed law, any platform that holds or acts on instructions for clients must hold an *Australian Financial Services Licence (AFSL)*, with ASIC standards governing segregation, reconciliation, and safekeeping[2]. The *Payments System Modernization Reforms* extend this to *tokenized stored-value facilities (SVFs)* – regulated stablecoins backed by 1:1 reserves and subject to APRA oversight for systemic issuers[3]. Temporary relief under ASIC *Instrument 2025/631* allows intermediaries to deal in approved coins (AUDM, AUDF) before licensing takes effect – creating a bridge to access, where compliance becomes a live on-ramp, not a hurdle[4].
Hong Kong	***Regulation as Access Architecture*** Hong Kong's *Stablecoins Ordinance (Cap. 656)*, enacted in 2025, introduced Asia's first full licensing regime for fiat-referenced stablecoins with segregated reserves, par-value redemption, and HKMA oversight[5]. The *Fintech 2030* roadmap and *Project Ensemble* pilots further connect stablecoins, tokenized deposits, and e-HKD within regulated payment systems, turning policy into usability[6]. The SFC's updates now permit licensed Virtual Asset Trading Platforms (VATPs) to share order books and distribute regulated stablecoins to professional investors – deepening liquidity while preserving compliance[7]. This is regulation as usable design, not constraint.
Japan	***Access Through Protection*** Japan's 2023–2025 reforms prioritize prudence over speed. Amendments to the *Payment Services Act* limit stablecoin issuance to banks, trusts, and money-transfer firms, guaranteeing redemption and segregated reserves[8]. In 2025, the FSA approved the first foreign stablecoin (USDC) for retail use, proving that import pathways can coexist with domestic oversight[9]. The forthcoming *Financial Instruments and Exchange Act (FIEA)* reform (2026) will classify selected crypto assets as financial products, aligning them with securities-level investor safeguards[10]. Japan's guiding principle remains clear: trust before scale.
Singapore	***Safe by Design*** Singapore's framework continues to set the regional benchmark for regulated innovation. *The Payment Services Act (PSA)* now captures custodial wallets, transfer services, and inducement practices, while the 2025 *Stablecoin Framework* enforces 1:1 reserves, monthly attestations, and five-day redemption rights under MAS supervision[11], [12]. The forthcoming *Digital Token Service Provider (DTSP)* regime will extend licensing to overseas-facing entities operating from Singapore, ensuring that safety by design applies across borders[13]. These measures make trust tangible: predictable custody, reversible redemption, and seamless integration with banking infrastructure.
South Korea	***Turning Protection into Participation*** The *Virtual Asset User Protection Act (VAUPA)*, effective 2024, codifies segregation (80% cold-wallet storage), insurance for hot wallets, and explicit prohibitions on market manipulation . A forthcoming *Stablecoin Act* will permit bank-issued KRW tokens with 1:1 reserves, while the *Token Securities Act (2024)* integrates tokenization into capital-market law – bridging innovation with regulatory assurance[15], [16].

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; based on analysis of public legislation, regulator releases, and official statements from the Australian Treasury, ASIC, HKMA, SFC, FSA, and Japan's Financial Services Agency, 2024–25.

Exhibit 3.6

Summary of 2024–25 regulatory developments in emerging APAC markets (China, India, Philippines, Thailand, UAE).

Market	2024–25 Regulatory Highlights
China	*Controlled Access through e-CNY* Mainland China continues its prohibition on private crypto trading and stablecoins, focusing on the e-CNY integrated into WeChat and Alipay with "controllable anonymity." Access is permitted by design, but defined by the state.
India	*Controlled, Monitored, and Sovereign-Aligned* India's approach remains deliberate: high taxes constrain speculation, but coverage under *PMLA* ensures traceability. Policymakers are studying a sovereign, G-sec-backed stablecoin to complement the digital rupee – signaling state-aligned access as the likely equilibrium.
Philippines	*Access Through Protection* The *Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas (BSP)* and *Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC)* now run coordinated regimes for payments and capital markets. The BSP's *PHPC* stablecoin graduated from sandbox to full supervision in 2025, while the SEC's *CASP* rules require local incorporation and disclosure. Here, user protection and access are one and the same.
Thailand	*Incentives for Onshore Access* Thailand is aligning incentives with enforcement to drive onshore migration. Tax exemptions (2025–2029) on trades executed on licensed platforms encourage participation under domestic supervision. Parallel sandbox pilots for THB stablecoins and programmable payments show how policy can simplify participation while maintaining prudence.
UAE	*Access by Design* The UAE operates one of the world's most integrated frameworks. The *Central Bank's Payment Token Regulation (2024)* licenses AED and foreign-currency stablecoins with 1:1 backing and real-time redemption. Together with *VARA's Rulebooks* and ADGM's fiat-token regime, the UAE's multi-rail model unites banks, custodians, and exchanges within a coherent oversight structure.

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025; analysis of public legislation, central bank publications, and regulatory announcements from the PBOC, RBI, BSP, SEC, BOT, and CBUAE, 2024–25.

Stablecoins and Global Convergence

Stablecoin regulation has become a defining measure of policy maturity in digital finance. Across Asia–Pacific, regulatory frameworks now reflect the same structural rigor seen in major global regimes such as the GENIUS Act in the United States and MiCA in the European Union, both of which establish clear requirements for 1:1 reserve backing, redemption rights, and independent attestations[17, 18].

In APAC, frameworks in Singapore, Hong Kong, and Japan have adopted similar standards, embedding stablecoins within existing payment laws rather than treating them as speculative assets[19]. The outcome is the same: stablecoins formalized as part of financial infrastructure – trusted, redeemable, and supervised – providing regulatory clarity for issuers and confidence for users.

This alignment positions Asia–Pacific not as a follower but as an equal participant in the global evolution of regulated digital money. While the GENIUS Act and MiCA define stablecoins within Western financial architecture, APAC's frameworks are more explicitly oriented toward inclusion and usability.

In markets such as Thailand, the Philippines, and the UAE, stablecoins are being designed for retail payments, cross-border remittances, and programmable financial services – use cases that extend access to everyday money movement[20, 21]. Rather than competing with traditional institutions, these models integrate stablecoins into existing payment systems, showing how regulation can translate new technology into accessible, reliable, and human-centred financial tools.

Access, Adoption, and the Role of Regulation

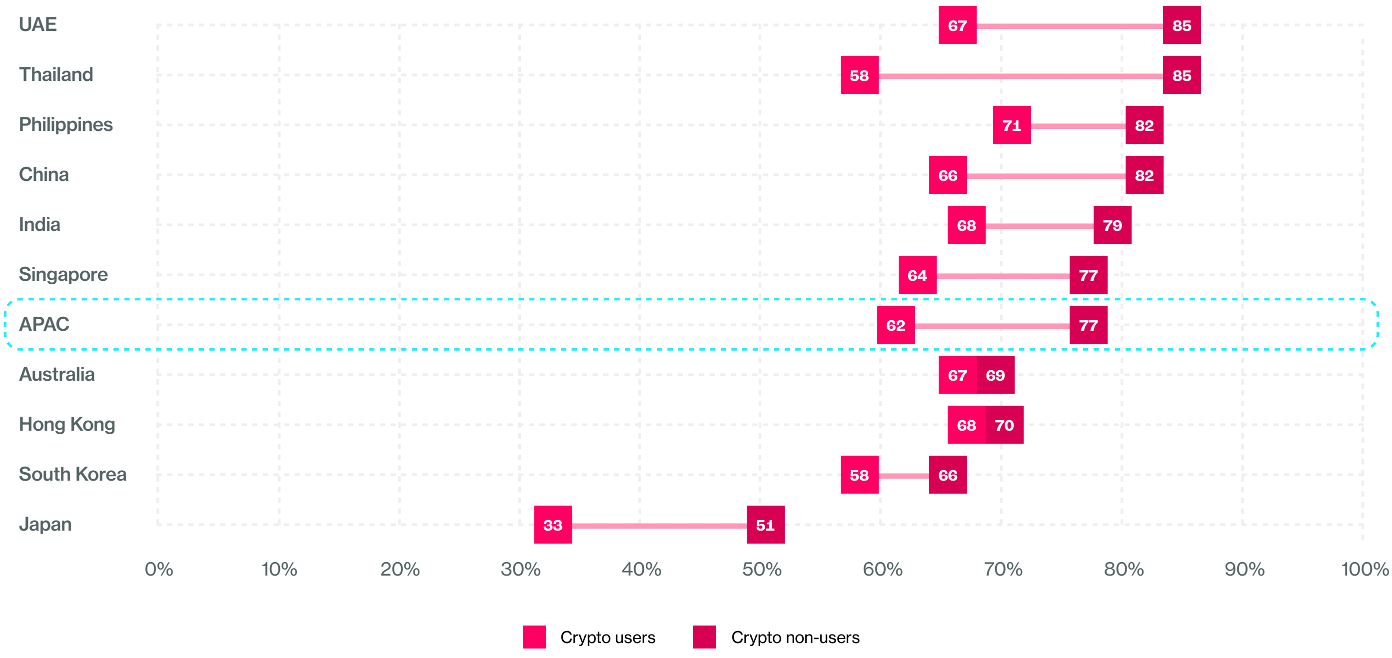
Regulation provides the conditions for confidence, but confidence alone does not create participation. Across Asia–Pacific, those already engaged in digital assets are among the strongest supporters of oversight – challenging widely held assumptions that the majority of crypto users resist regulation.

In nearly every market, support for regulation is higher among users than among non-users – from over 80% in the UAE and Thailand to more than two-thirds in Singapore and Australia. Users appear to recognize that clear, consistent rules make participation possible: regulation converts engagement into access by ensuring systems are transparent, predictable, and safe for everyday use.

Exhibit 3.7

Across nearly all markets, crypto users express stronger support for consumer-protective regulation than non-users.

Share of adults agreeing with the statement "Regulation of cryptocurrencies is necessary to protect consumers," by market and crypto user segment (% of responses per segment)



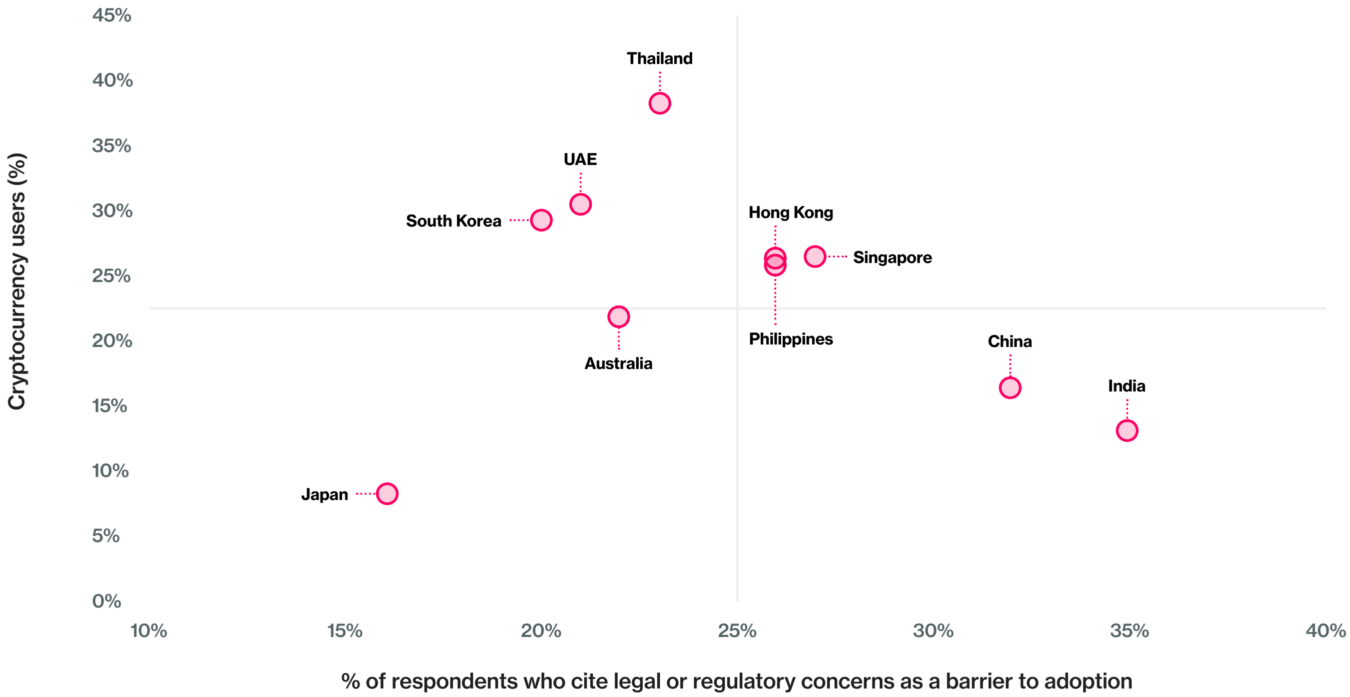
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent Top 2 Box agreement ("strongly agree" or "somewhat agree") with the statement, shown by market and user segment.

Yet the relationship between regulation and adoption is not linear. Markets expressing greater concern about legal or regulatory uncertainty often also record higher levels of use, as seen in Thailand and the UAE. Conversely, markets with minimal concern – such as Japan – show the lowest participation. The pattern suggests that awareness of regulation does not deter users; rather, it coexists with confidence when rules are credible and consistent.

Exhibit 3.8

Concern about cryptocurrency regulation does not appear to influence adoption levels across markets.

Relationship between concern over legal or regulatory issues (% agreeing "I'm concerned about legal or regulatory issues") and cryptocurrency adoption (% of adults who currently use cryptocurrency), by market



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the share of adults citing legal or regulatory concerns as a barrier to adoption versus the share who report currently using cryptocurrency.

In this sense, regulation acts as an enabler rather than a driver of adoption. It defines the conditions in which access can take hold, but the motivation to participate comes from relevance and usability – the ability to send, invest, or transact in ways that feel intuitive and useful. Across Asia–Pacific, consumers are not waiting for perfect regulatory certainty to engage; they are responding to the availability of safe, comprehensible entry points. Where access exists, adoption follows.

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[2] **Source**: Australian Government Treasury, *Explanatory Materials: Treasury Laws Amendment Bill 2025—Digital Asset Platforms and Tokenized Custody Platforms* (2025).
[3] **Source**: Australian Government Treasury, *Payments Licensing Reforms* (2025).
[4] **Source**: Commonwealth of Australia, *ASIC Corporations (Stablecoin Distribution Exemption) Instrument 2025/631* (2025).
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[6] **Source**: Hong Kong Monetary Authority, *Fintech 2030 Strategy and Project Ensemble Releases* (2025).
[7] **Source**: Securities and Futures Commission, *Circular on Shared Liquidity by Virtual Asset Trading Platforms* (2025).
[8] **Source**: Chambers & Partners, *Fintech 2025: Japan—Trends and Developments* (2025).
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[10] **Source**: Reuters, *Japan to Give Crypto Assets Legal Status as Financial Products* (2025).
[11] **Source**: Monetary Authority of Singapore, *Payment Services (Amendment) Regulations 2024* (2024).
[12] **Source**: Monetary Authority of Singapore, *Finalizes Stablecoin Regulatory Framework* (2023).
[13] **Source**: Allen & Gledhill, *Regulatory Framework for Digital Token Service Providers under FSMA 2022* (2025).
[14] **Source**: Financial Services Commission (Korea), *Act on the Protection of Virtual Asset Users* (2024).
[15] **Source**: Reuters, *South Korea Prepares Stablecoin Act to Permit Bank-Issued Tokens* (2025).
[16] **Source**: Financial Services Commission (Korea), *Measures to Permit Issuance and Circulation of Security Tokens* (2023).
[17] **Source**: Deloitte, 2025 – *The Year of Payment Stablecoins* (2025), Deloitte Insights
[18] **Source**: Oliver Wyman, *Compliance in the Era of Stablecoins* (2025).
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[20] **Source**: McKinsey & Company, *The Stable Door Opens: How Tokenized Cash Enables Next-Generation Payments* (2025).
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Chapter 4: Access as the Missing Link

At a Glance: From Intent to Experience

Across Asia–Pacific, awareness of digital assets is near universal and optimism remains high. Yet everyday participation has not kept pace. Many people understand what crypto is and recognize its potential, but few find it easy or familiar enough to use regularly. The gap between knowing and doing is not one of belief, but of access – how easily and confidently people can participate

Key insights

- **Access drives participation:** Familiarity with crypto accounts for around half of adoption variance in emerging markets and more than a third in developed ones.
- **Ease and trust move together:** Markets that offer simpler, safer experiences and clear regulation see higher conversion from intent to use.
- **The conversion deficit persists:** 95% are aware of crypto and 63% intend to use it, yet only 25–33% currently do.
- **Perceived ease and trust move together:** Markets with simpler experiences and clear regulation see higher conversion from intent to use.
- **Access compensates for exclusion:** Where banking barriers are high, crypto fills the gap as an alternative on-ramp to financial services.
- **The accessibility dividend:** 63% of non-users in emerging markets say they would adopt crypto if it were easier to use.

Across the region, access has become the human infrastructure of adoption – the bridge between interest and everyday use

Reframing the Adoption Challenge

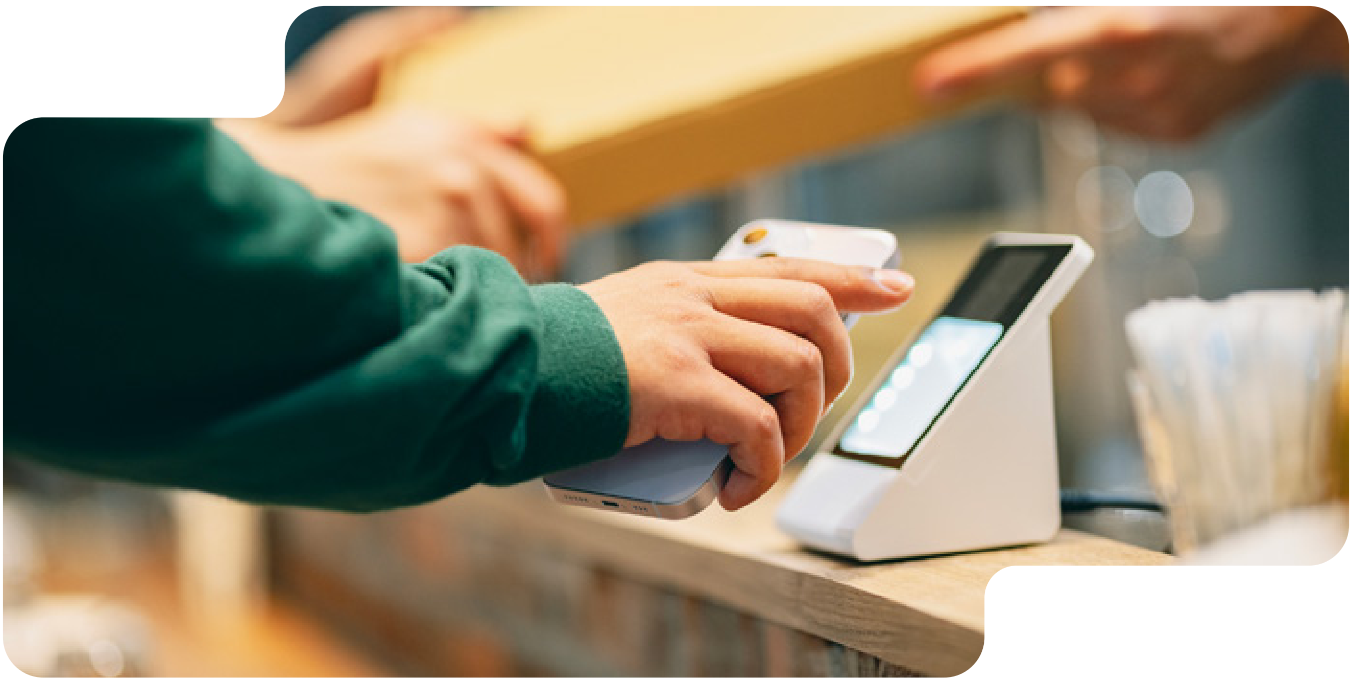
Belief in digital assets is no longer in question. People understand their potential and increasingly welcome stronger rules to guide them. What limits growth is not demand but experience – how usable, safe, and familiar crypto feels in practice.

Where participation feels intuitive, adoption expands naturally. Where the process is fragmented or opaque, progress slows. In this sense, access acts as both engine and brake: it accelerates inclusion when designed well and creates friction when it does not.

From Intent to Action: The Two Faces of Access

Two realities define the region's access story. In **emerging markets**, limited banking access pushes people toward crypto as a functional alternative. In **developed economies**, complex onboarding and unfamiliar terminology constrain participation even when interest is strong.

This duality positions access as both solution and obstacle. Where finance excludes, digital assets invite; where crypto complicates, people disengage. Understanding this divide begins by examining what kind of access people actually experience.



Familiarity as Access

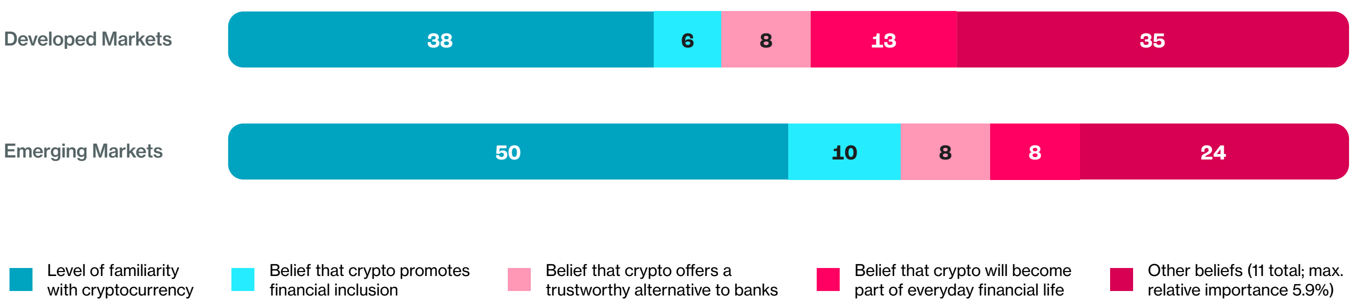
Familiarity with crypto is the most consistent behavioral driver across all ten markets. Statistical modeling shows it accounts for half of adoption variance in emerging economies and over a third in developed ones, even after controlling for income and sentiment.

This pattern reframes access as cognitive confidence: the belief that one can use digital assets without confusion or risk. In behavioral terms, feeling capable is the first form of access.

Exhibit 4.1

Familiarity is the strongest predictor of individual crypto adoption across APAC.

Relative importance of attitudinal beliefs in predicting individual-level cryptocurrency adoption, based on Shapley regression analysis controlling for age, gender, and overall sentiment toward crypto



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Shapley relative importance analysis conducted to isolate the contribution of attitudinal beliefs to individual likelihood of cryptocurrency adoption, controlling for age, gender, and overall favorability toward crypto. Figures represent each factor's percentage contribution to total explained variance.

Access therefore begins with comprehension. Clear language, intuitive design, and guided onboarding reduce cognitive friction and make participation feel predictable.

The Conversion Deficit: When Awareness Doesn't Equal Use

Across APAC, 95% of adults know what cryptocurrency is, and 63% intend to use it. Yet only one in three actually does. The steepest drop occurs between intent and action – a behavioral bottleneck best described as the conversion deficit.

This shortfall reflects friction, not disinterest. People understand the concept but encounter practical barriers: complicated wallets, unintuitive interfaces, or limited on-ramps they can trust.

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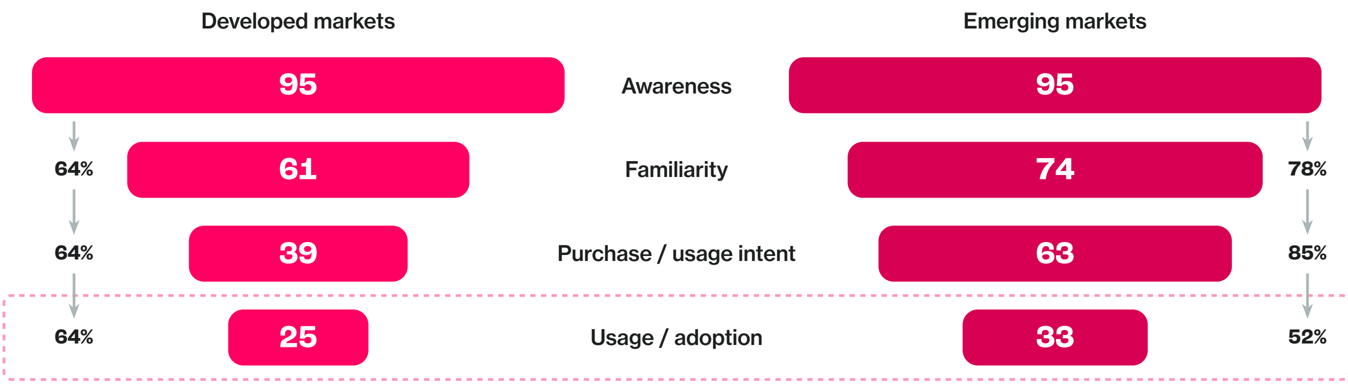
Exhibit 4.2

High awareness and intent have not yet translated into widespread adoption – especially in emerging markets.

Progression from awareness to familiarity, intent, and usage/adoption of cryptocurrency by region, % of general population



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Metrics represent share of general population at each stage of the awareness-to-adoption funnel.

Access, then, acts as behavioral infrastructure: the system that converts curiosity into participation.

Friction and Trust: Why Ease Matters

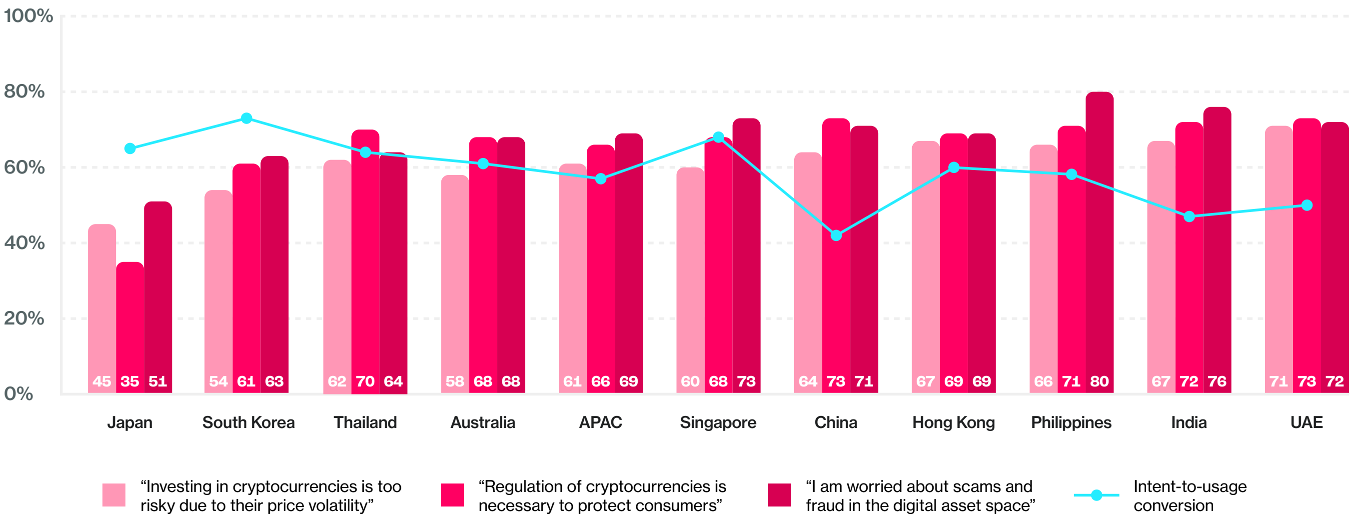
Markets with higher perceived risk see weaker conversion from intent to use. In Japan, South Korea, and Australia – where concerns about volatility or scams are highest – conversion rates are roughly half those of the UAE, Thailand, or the Philippines.

Trust and usability are intertwined. People often equate simplicity with safety: if an experience feels predictable, it feels secure. When processes are confusing or irreversible, perceived risk rises.

Exhibit 4.3

Markets with stronger concerns about volatility, scams, and regulation show weaker intent-to-usage conversion.

Relationship between intent-to-usage conversion rate and agreement with key perception statements by market, % of general population



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Agreement measured as Top 2 Box (somewhat/strongly agree). Intent-to-usage conversion defined as share of those intending to purchase or use cryptocurrency who currently own or use it.

Friction in design, language, or process does more than slow adoption – it undermines confidence among those already interested.

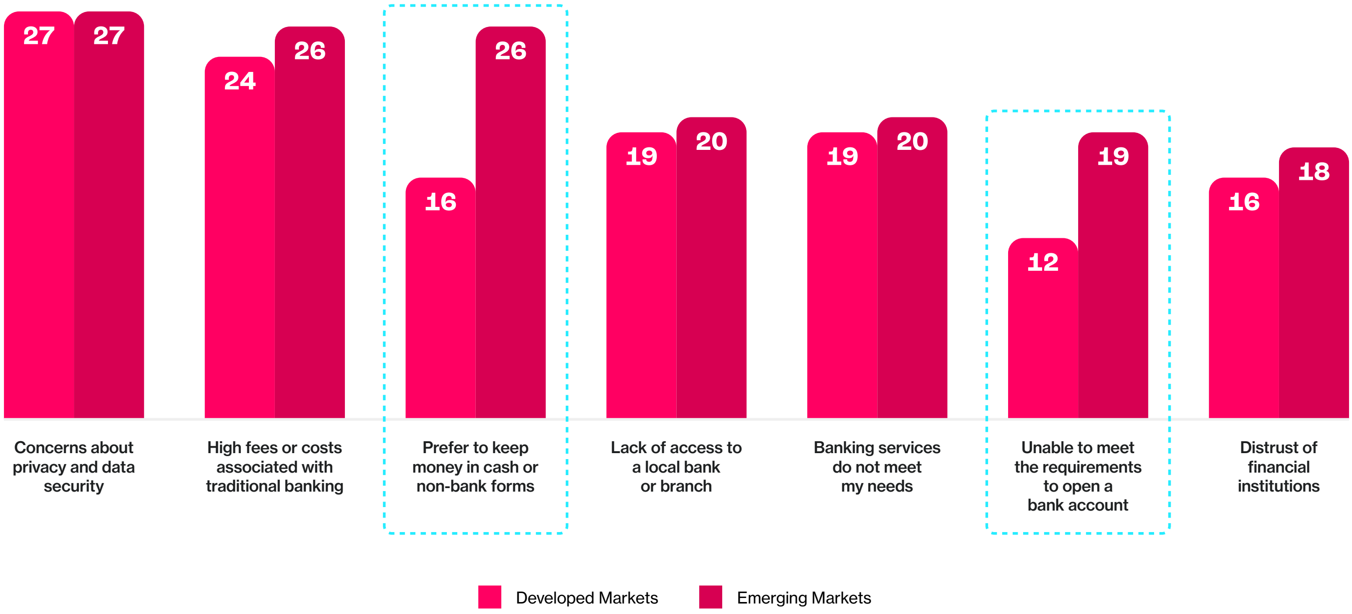
Access Through Absence: When Banks Exclude, Crypto Includes

Across emerging markets, crypto adoption often fills the gaps left by traditional finance. Among unbanked individuals, the top reasons for exclusion are high fees (24–27%), limited branch access (20–26%), and ineligibility due to income or documentation (16–19%).

Exhibit 4.4

Access limitations and institutional distrust continue to shape banking exclusion in emerging markets.

Top self-reported reasons for not using traditional banking services, by region, % of responses



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: respondents who do not currently use traditional banking services. Multiple responses permitted.

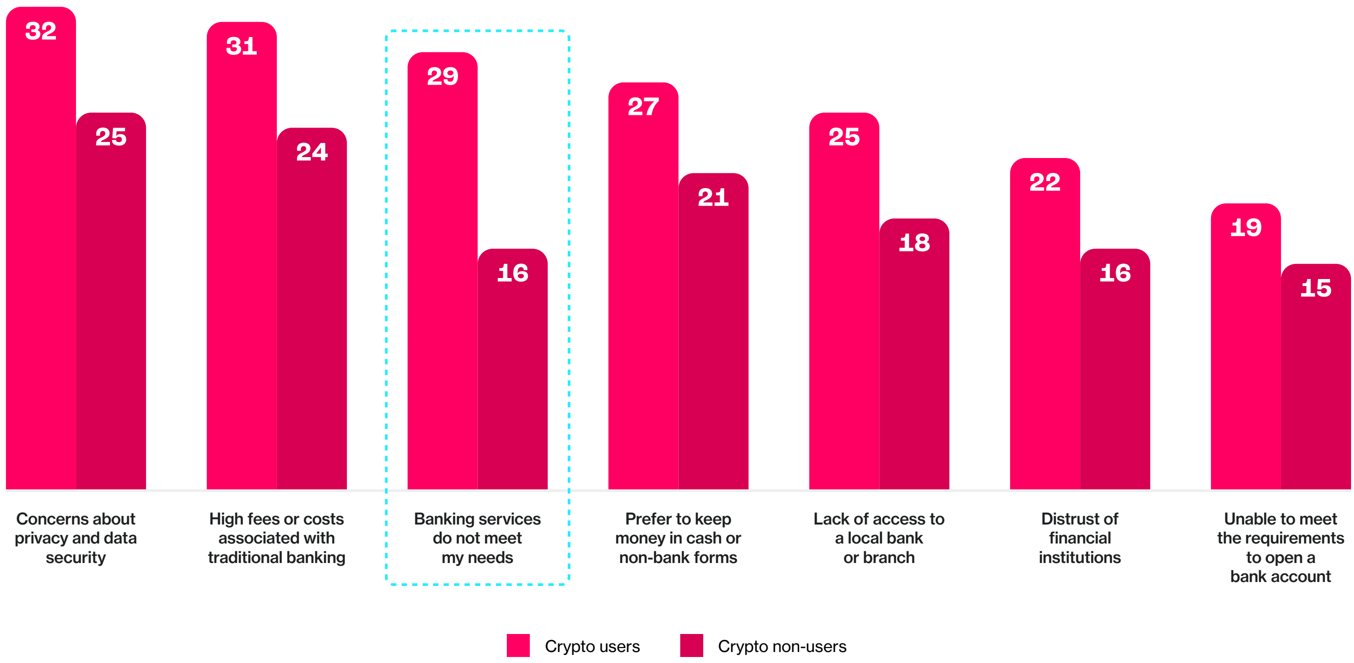
Crypto users are disproportionately represented among these financially excluded groups. They are more likely to cite unmet banking needs or distrust of institutions – evidence that digital assets act as functional access infrastructure when traditional systems fall short.

In other words: where banks close doors, digital wallets open them.

Exhibit 4.5

Crypto users are more likely to face banking barriers, underscoring access as a driver of adoption.

Top self-reported reasons for not using traditional banking services, by crypto user status, % of responses



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: respondents who do not currently use traditional banking services. Results shown for total APAC, segmented by cryptocurrency user status. Multiple responses permitted.

The Access Deficit as Demand Driver

Limited banking access does more than explain current use – it predicts future intent. Those unable to open bank accounts are significantly more likely to plan to use crypto within the next year.

The pattern is strongest in India and the Philippines, where formal financial infrastructure leaves large segments underserved, and remains positive in Thailand and the UAE.

Exhibit 4.6

In markets with restricted banking access, people turn to crypto to fill financial gaps.

Relationship between lack of access to traditional banking and use of crypto as a substitute, % of responses

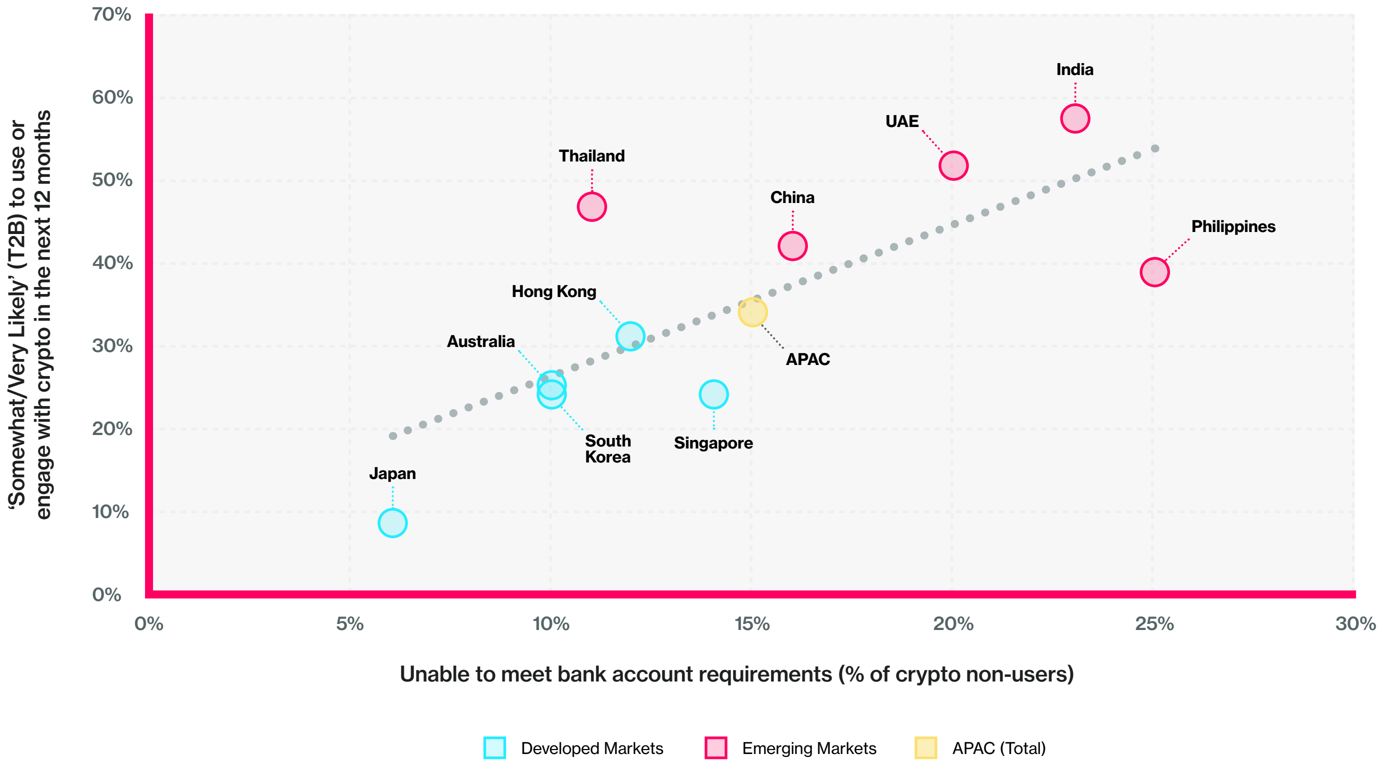
Note: Bubble size represents country-level crypto adoption rate (% of adults)

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. "Unable to meet bank account requirements" reflects responses from all adults; crypto financial service usage reflects self-reported activity among cryptocurrency users. Bubble size represents country-level crypto adoption rate.

Exhibit 4.7

Lack of access to traditional banking drives usage intent of crypto, even amongst crypto non-users.

Relationship between lack of access to traditional banking and likelihood to use or purchase cryptocurrency in the last 12 months, % of crypto non-users



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. "Unable to meet bank account requirements" reflects responses from all adults; crypto financial service usage reflects self-reported activity among cryptocurrency users.

In short, when people are excluded from traditional systems, they innovate by necessity. Access gaps create digital openness, and inclusion often begins as a workaround.

The Accessibility Dividend: Unlocking Latent Demand

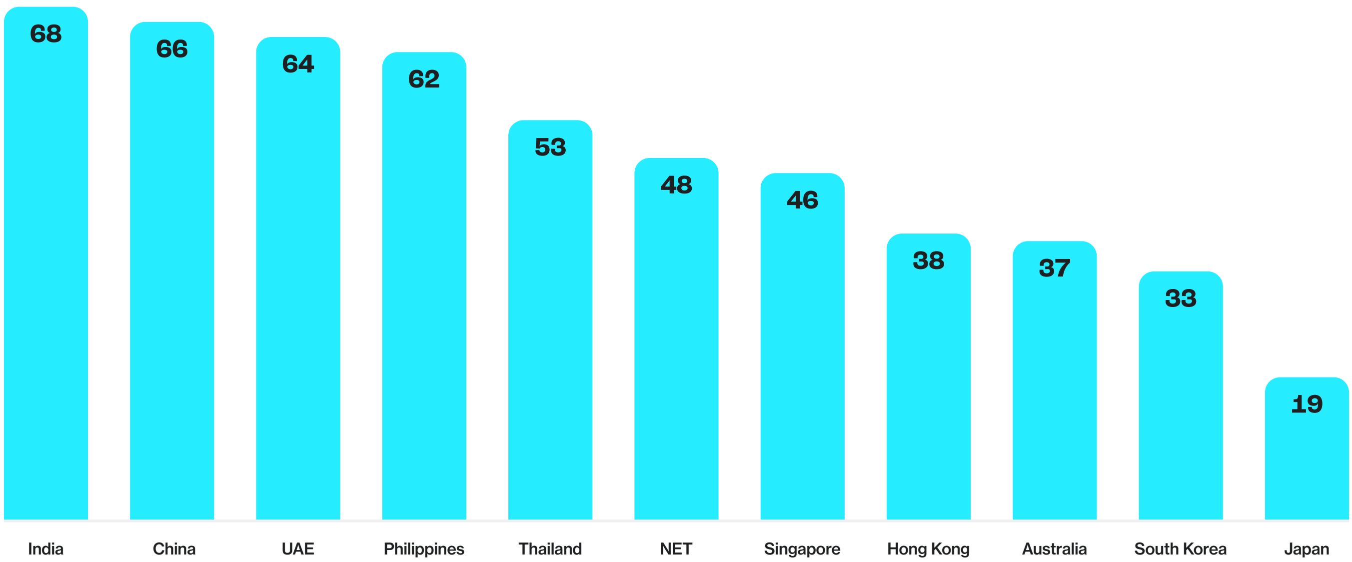
Better design could unlock millions of new participants. Across the region, 63% of non-users in emerging markets and 34% in developed ones say they would adopt crypto if it were easier to use. This elasticity shows that perceived accessibility is the most powerful growth lever. Even small improvements in onboarding, clarity, or integration can produce outsized adoption gains.

This is the *accessibility dividend*: the latent demand released when participation feels simple, familiar, and trustworthy.

Exhibit 4.8

Ease of access is a key unlock for future adoption, especially among non-users in emerging markets.

Share of cryptocurrency non-users who agree (Top 2 Box) that they would be more likely to engage with digital assets if they were easier to access, % of crypto non-users

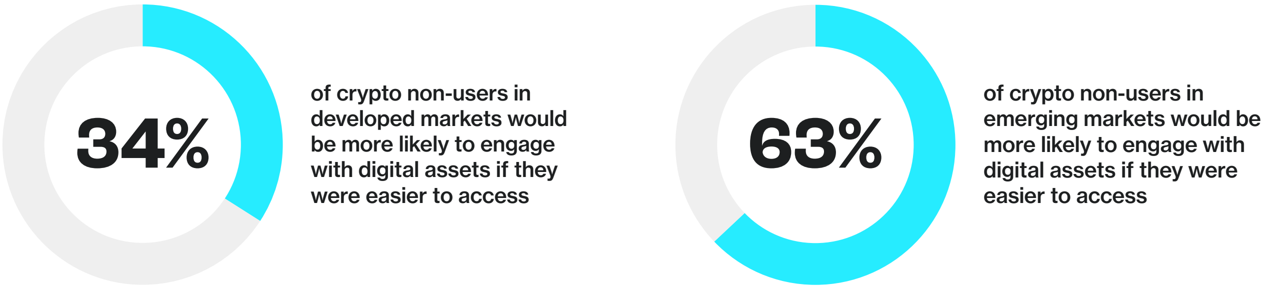


Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: cryptocurrency non-users. Agreement measured as Top 2 Box (somewhat/strongly agree) with statement "I would be more likely to engage with digital assets if they were easier to access."

Exhibit 4.9

Emerging market non-users show nearly twice the willingness to engage with crypto if accessibility improves.

Share of cryptocurrency non-users who agree (Top 2 Box) that they would be more likely to engage with digital assets if they were easier to access, % of general population



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Base: cryptocurrency non-users. Agreement measured as Top 2 Box (somewhat/strongly agree) with statement "I would be more likely to engage with digital assets if they were easier to access."

The data quantify an **accessibility dividend** – the latent demand unlocked when participation feels simple, familiar, and trustworthy.

Redefining Accessibility: The Four Dimensions of Experience

Accessibility is more than availability – it is how effortlessly people can participate.
Four dimensions shape that experience:

1. **Reach**
   Are digital assets available in the channels people already use?
2. **Ease**
   Is the interaction simple, safe, and reversible?
3. **Fit**
   Do digital assets align with everyday financial habits, such as sending money or paying bills?
4. **Confidence**
   Do people trust the outcome because it feels predictable and well-supported?

When these four dimensions align, access becomes experience, and adoption becomes largely inevitable.

Accessibility in Practice

Stablecoins illustrate the difference between what is *available* and what is *accessible*. In theory, most adults in APAC could acquire them. In practice, few find the process simple.

An inaccessible journey involves multiple steps: creating an exchange account, linking a bank, funding it with fiat, purchasing tokens, securing wallets, and managing seed phrases. Each step demands technical literacy and tolerance for risk.

An accessible experience looks different. Stablecoins appear within familiar apps; a user funds their account, taps “send,” and completes a transaction in seconds. The value is described in everyday terms – *fast transfers, lower fees, secure payments* – not technical jargon.

Accessibility removes friction until use feels natural. That difference explains why *availability alone does not equal adoption*.

Behavior Before Belief: The Access–Adoption Loop

Access precedes belief. History shows that familiarity creates trust only after use. Early skepticism toward mobile banking faded once the process became simple and embedded in daily life.

The same pattern now applies to stablecoins and tokenized assets. Exposure drives confidence; usability builds legitimacy. When people experience reliability firsthand, attitudes shift from curiosity to reliance.

Access as the Human Infrastructure of Adoption

Access now defines the frontier of digital asset adoption in Asia–Pacific. Awareness is universal, optimism endures, yet participation depends on one test: *can people reach, understand, and trust these tools in their everyday lives?*

Behavioral evidence shows that accessibility – not regulation or ideology – is the decisive predictor of use. Access determines whether inclusion is real or theoretical, whether innovation becomes habit, and whether digital assets fulfill their promise of empowerment.

The next chapter turns to stablecoins as the clearest demonstration of this principle, showing how usability, integration, and design can transform intent into everyday utility.

Chapter 5: Stablecoins: From Speculation to Utility

At a Glance: When Access Finally Meets Utility

Stablecoins mark the point where digital asset innovation turns into everyday finance. By combining stability, speed, and familiarity, they transform crypto's potential into something practical, trusted, and usable.

Key insights

- **Stablecoins now form a core part of Asia–Pacific's digital-finance ecosystem**, evolving from niche asset to functional payment rail.
- **17.0% of internet-connected adults across APAC (around 372 million people) use stablecoins,** with adoption in emerging markets (17.8%) roughly three times that of developed economies (5.8%).
- **Nearly half of adults (47%) say stablecoins are difficult to access,** more than twice the share who say the same of remittance services (23%).
- **Expanding accessibility** across digital assets could unlock participation among 63% of non-users in emerging markets, representing a significant *accessibility dividend*.
- **52% of adults express positive sentiment** towards stablecoins – five points higher than for crypto overall.

Across the region, stablecoins show what happens when design, trust, and access align – when digital money becomes part of everyday life.

Stability as the Next Frontier of Access

Access defines adoption – and stablecoins demonstrate what happens when access meets utility. Over the past year, they have evolved from a niche within crypto markets to a structural pillar of Asia–Pacific's emerging digital-finance ecosystem. Their appeal lies in stability, speed, and familiarity – qualities that bridge the volatility of Web3 innovation with the reliability of traditional money.

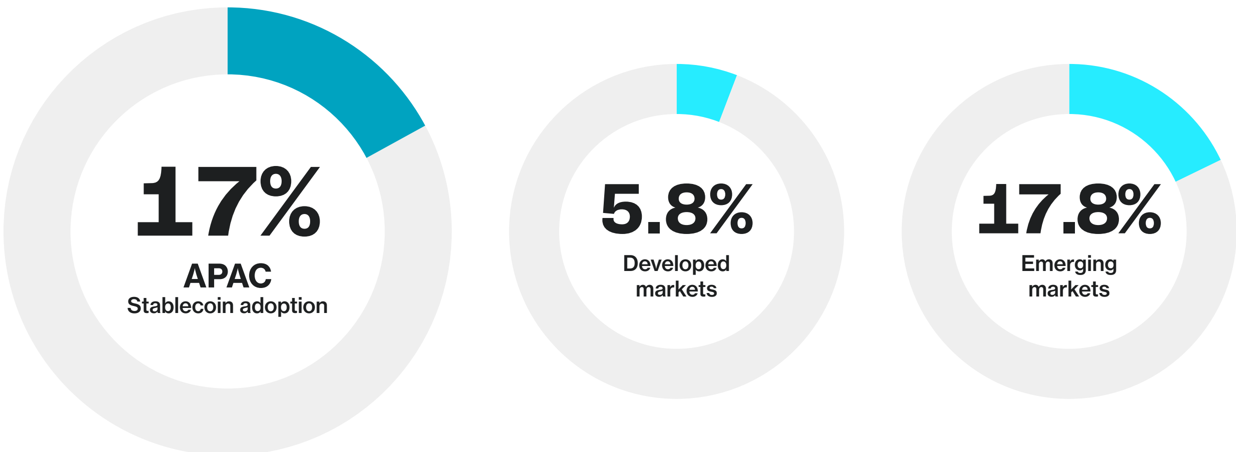
Global indicators highlight the scale of this transformation. Total stablecoin supply now exceeds $250 billion, moving roughly $26 trillion in annual on-chain transaction volume, with about $1.3 trillion already tied to real-world payments for goods and services[1]. At current growth rates, Citi estimates that stablecoins could facilitate around $100 trillion in annual transaction volume by 2030 under its base scenario – and as much as $200 trillion in an accelerated case – driven by an expected fiftyfold increase in transaction velocity[2].

Across APAC, approximately 17.0% of internet-connected adults now use stablecoins – equivalent to 7.8% of the total adult population, or roughly 372.8 million people. Yet beneath this scale lies a sharp divide: use in emerging markets averages 17.8%, almost three times the 5.8% recorded in developed economies. At the general population level, Thailand leads with 30%, followed by the UAE (26%) and Hong Kong (17%), while Japan remains lowest at 2%.

Exhibit 5.1

Stablecoin usage remains higher in emerging markets, reaching almost one in five internet-connected adults across APAC.

Share of internet-connected adults who currently use stablecoins, by region (% of population aged 18–64)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Stablecoin usage weighted by internet penetration and awareness of cryptocurrency. "Users" represent respondents who currently own or use stablecoins.

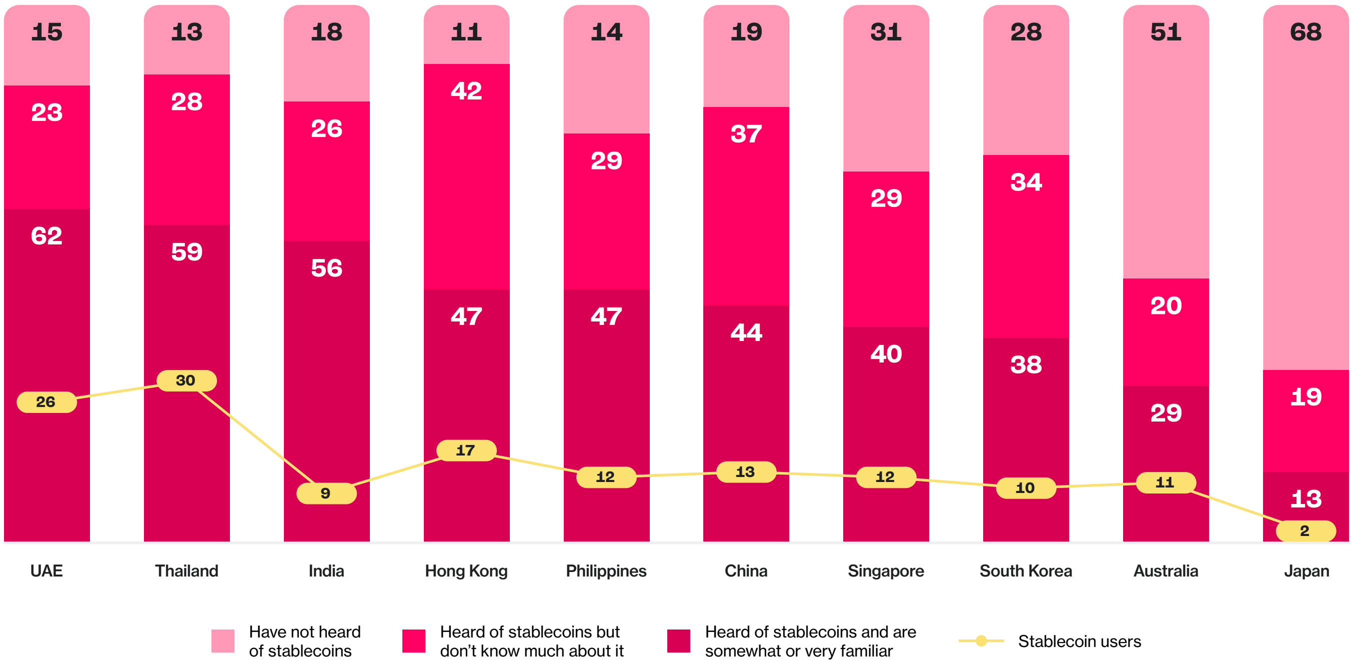
This pattern reflects two complementary forces: necessity and choice. In markets where access to formal finance is limited or costly, stablecoins provide inclusion – an inexpensive means to send money, save in a stable currency, or transact online. In developed economies, adoption depends less on need and more on perception: whether stablecoins feel simple, safe, and legitimate within familiar financial routines.

Familiarity remains a key constraint. While 59% of adults across APAC have heard of stablecoins, only 41% say they understand them, compared with 63% familiarity for cryptocurrency overall.

Exhibit 5.2

Awareness is high across APAC, but familiarity and usage remain limited – especially in developed markets.

Awareness, familiarity, and current usage of stablecoins by market, % of general population



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Stablecoin usage weighted by internet penetration and awareness of cryptocurrency. "Users" represent respondents who currently own or use stablecoins. Totals may not sum to 100% due to rounding.

The result is a behavioral bottleneck: stablecoins are known but not yet integrated. Their promise as stable, interoperable money will depend on how effectively they move from abstract concept to everyday experience.

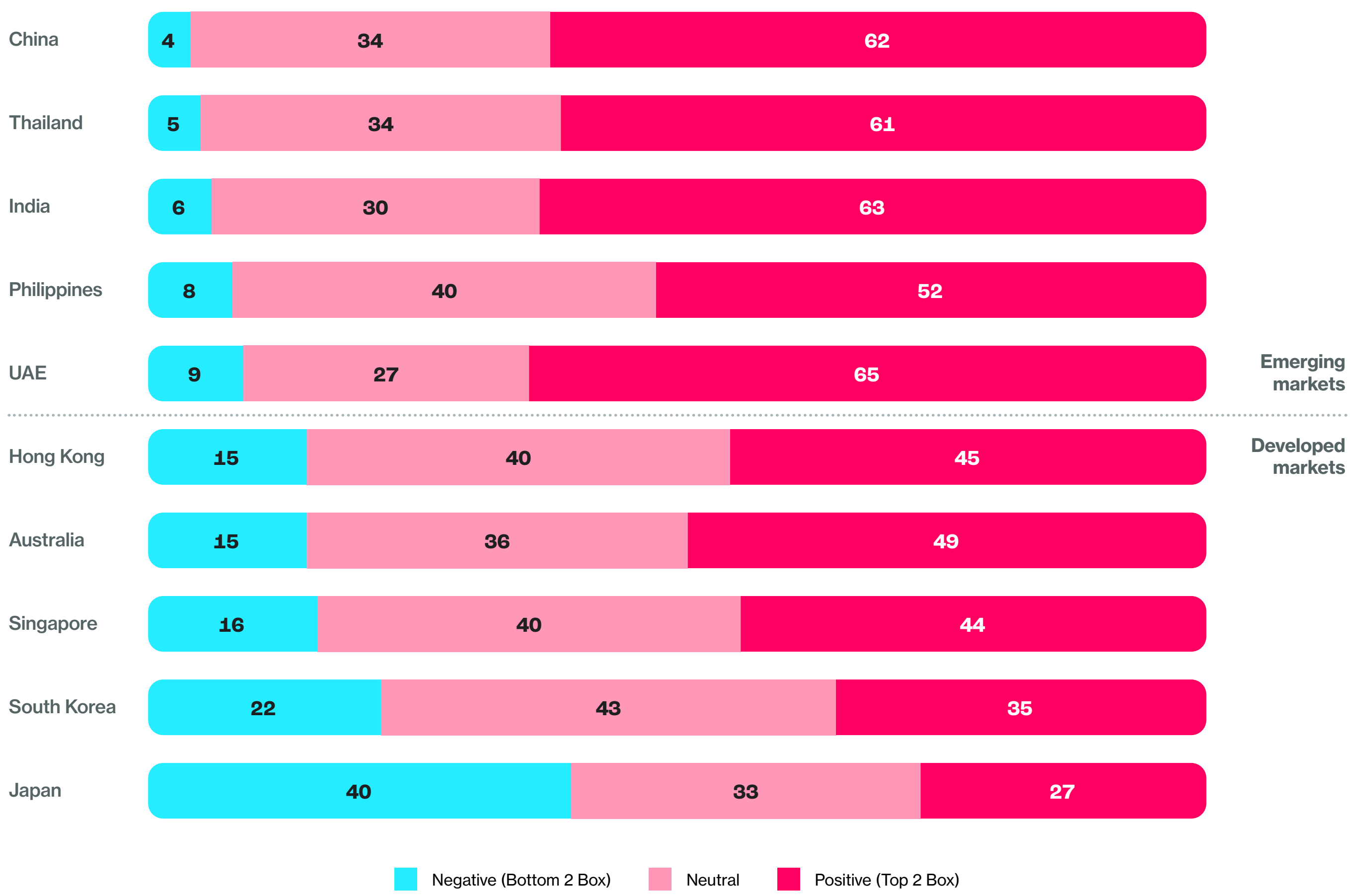
From Volatility to Trust

Trust – once the weakest link in crypto's story – is gradually being rebuilt through stability. Across APAC, 52% of adults express positive sentiment toward stablecoins, five points higher than for cryptocurrency overall. Optimism is concentrated in emerging economies such as Thailand, India, and China, where daily use is visible through remittance and wallet applications. Sentiment in Japan and South Korea remains cautious, reflecting cultural conservatism and lower perceived necessity.

Exhibit 5.3

Positive sentiment toward stablecoins is stronger in emerging markets, while skepticism persists in developed economies – especially Japan.

Share of adults expressing positive, neutral, or negative sentiment toward stablecoins, by market (% of respondents)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Sentiment measured on a 5-point scale; results shown as Top 2 Box (Somewhat positive/Very positive) and Bottom 2 Box (Somewhat negative/Very negative).

Perception has also improved among institutions. Visa's Transforming Global Payments review notes that regulated stablecoins are already being tested as settlement instruments within Visa Net, performing comparably to fiat rails in compliance and security[3]. EY-Parthenon's 2025 survey of 350 financial institutions and corporates found that 65% expect rising interest in stablecoins over the next year, and nearly four in five plan to integrate them through existing banking channels – evidence that institutional confidence is scaling alongside infrastructure maturity[4].

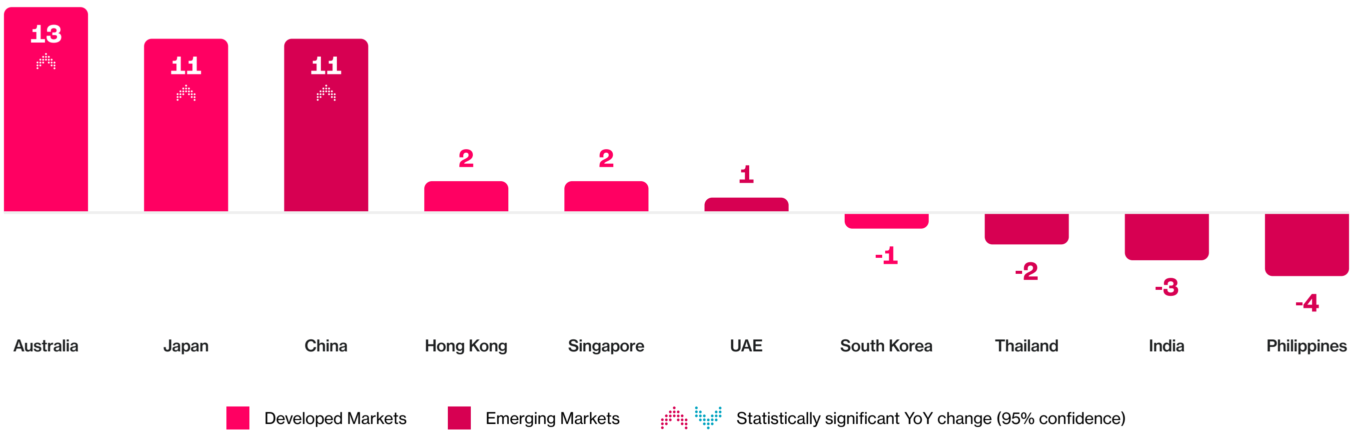
In most developed markets, stablecoins are now viewed more favorably than crypto. In Australia, positive sentiment is 13 points higher for stablecoins; in Japan, 11 points higher. Policymakers have reinforced this trust cycle: across Asia–Pacific, frameworks in Singapore, Hong Kong, and Japan have embedded stablecoins within existing payment laws, formalizing them as trusted, redeemable, and supervised financial instruments rather than speculative assets[5].

Exhibit 5.4

Stablecoins are viewed more favorably than cryptocurrencies in most developed markets, but less so in emerging ones.

Difference in Top 2 Box (positive) sentiment between stablecoins and cryptocurrencies, by market (% of general population)

Note: A positive value indicates a higher share of adults expressing positive sentiment toward stablecoins than toward cryptocurrencies.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Sentiment measured on a 5-point scale; figures represent the net difference in Top 2 Box (positive) sentiment between stablecoins and cryptocurrencies among the general population. A positive value indicates a higher share of adults expressing positive sentiment toward stablecoins than toward cryptocurrencies.

This shift in perception underscores how stability has become the foundation of credibility in digital assets. As regulation formalizes redemption rights, reserve transparency, and consumer protection, stablecoins are beginning to embody the traits long associated with traditional money – reliability, accountability, and ease of use. In doing so, they are transforming trust from a belief into a measurable experience of access.

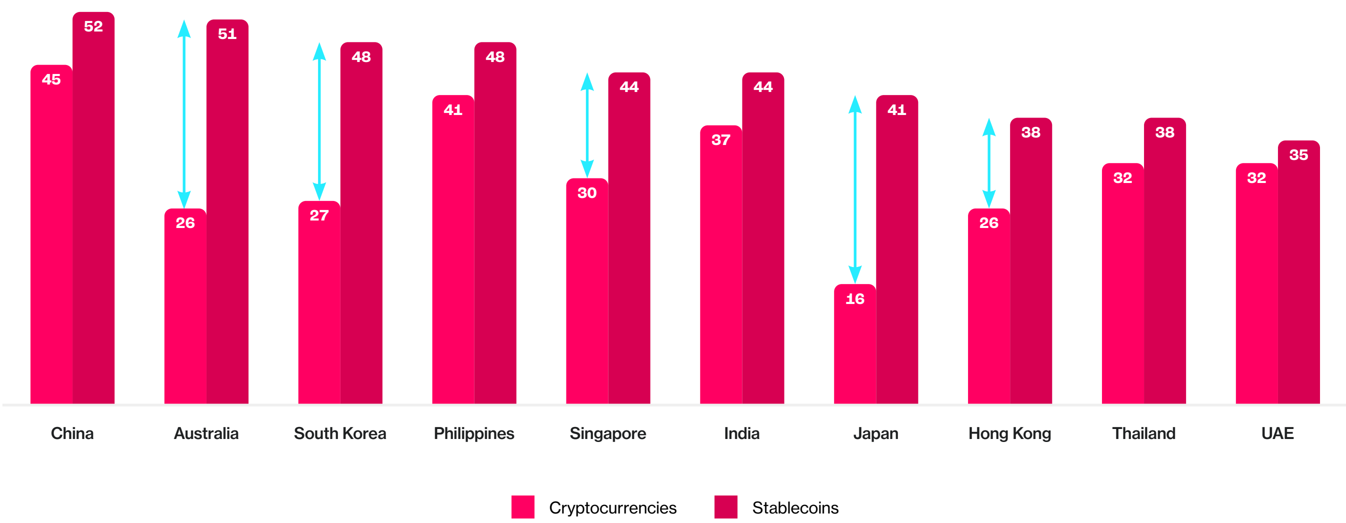
Intent Before Adoption

Across the region, consideration already exceeds ownership. 52% of adults say they are open to using stablecoins compared with 45% for cryptocurrency, confirming that intent has overtaken ideology as the growth driver. Global transaction data strengthen this picture: over $26 trillion in stablecoin transfers were recorded in 2025, with flows rapidly migrating from trading toward commerce, B2B settlement, and remittances[6]. In Asia–Pacific, digital payments already represent 81% of online commerce and 59% of point-of-sale transactions[7], creating the behavioral infrastructure for the next wave of onchain money.

Exhibit 5.5

Stablecoins attract broader consideration than cryptocurrencies across every APAC market.

Share of adults who are currently considering using or open to using each technology, by market (% of general population)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. “Total consideration” represents the combined share of adults who are currently considering adopting stablecoins (“Active Considerers”) or are open to adopting them in the future (“Passive Considerers”).

Positive sentiment toward stablecoins has risen 23 points since 2024, with 63% of emerging-market respondents reporting a more positive view year-on-year. Among active users, 64% use them weekly, placing stablecoins on par with digital payments and traditional banking.

Exhibit 5.6

Positive sentiment toward stablecoins is rising across all markets, led by stronger gains in emerging economies

Share of respondents expressing an increase in positive sentiment toward stablecoins, % of respondents

63%
Emerging markets

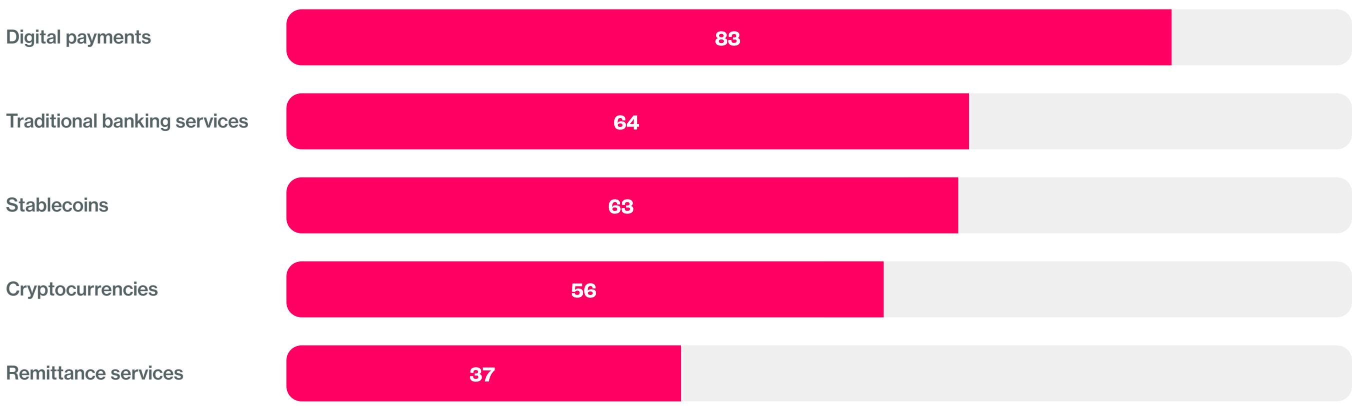
40%
Developed markets

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Sentiment measured on a 5-point scale; results shown as Top 2 Box (Somewhat more positive/Much more positive).

Exhibit 5.7

Stablecoins are used almost as frequently as traditional banking services among active users.

Share of current users of each product or service who use it at least weekly, by category (% of users)



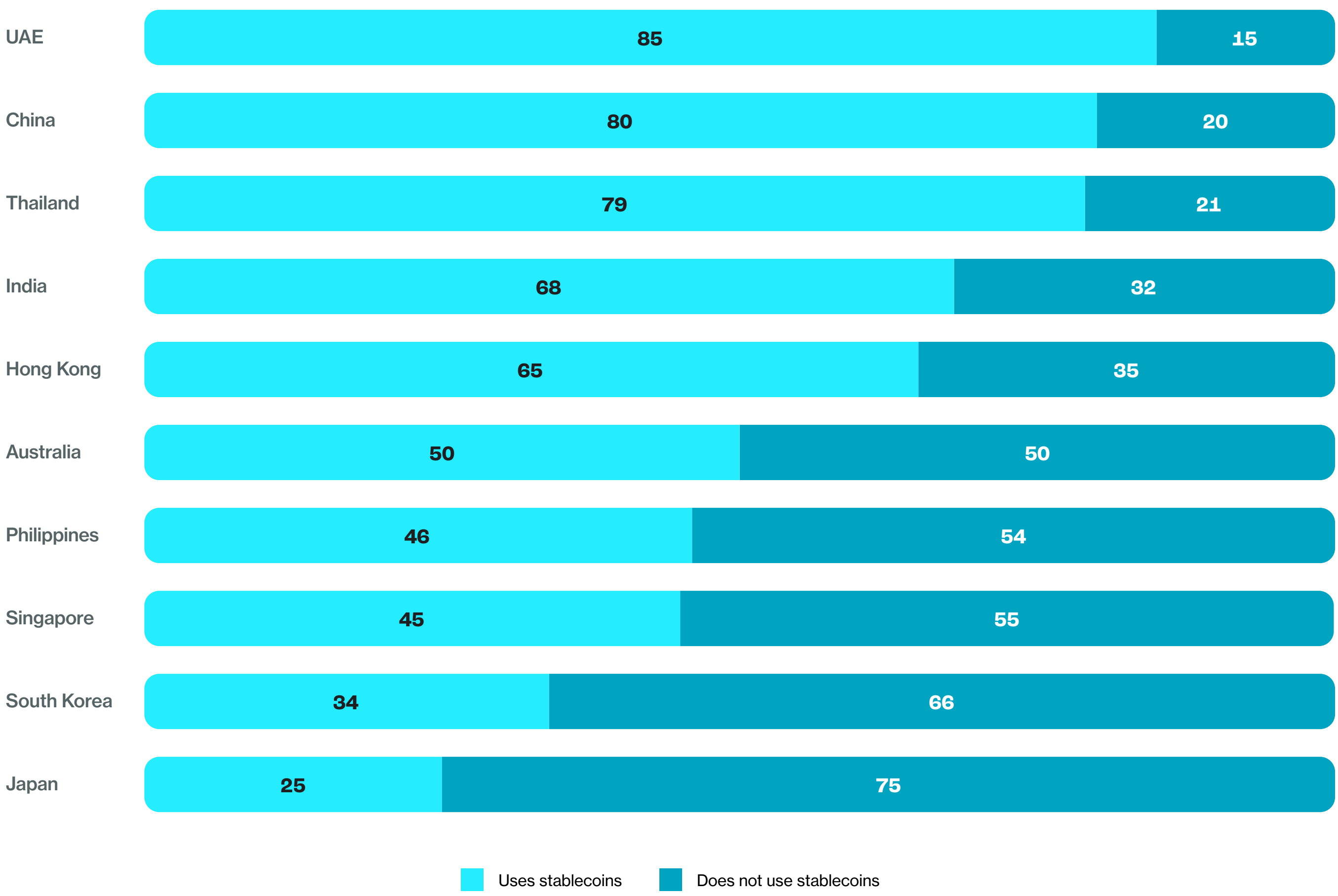
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the proportion of current users of each product or service who report using it at least weekly.

Despite this momentum, adoption remains uneven, and a significant share of crypto users have yet to integrate stablecoins into their financial routines. While markets such as the UAE, China, and Thailand show widespread integration – where over three-quarters of crypto users also use stablecoins – adoption remains limited in developed economies like Japan and South Korea, underscoring the gap between awareness and habitual use.

Exhibit 5.8

A significant share of crypto users have yet to adopt stablecoins in their financial routines.

Share of cryptocurrency users who currently use stablecoins, by market (% of cryptocurrency users)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the proportion of self-identified cryptocurrency users who report currently using stablecoins.

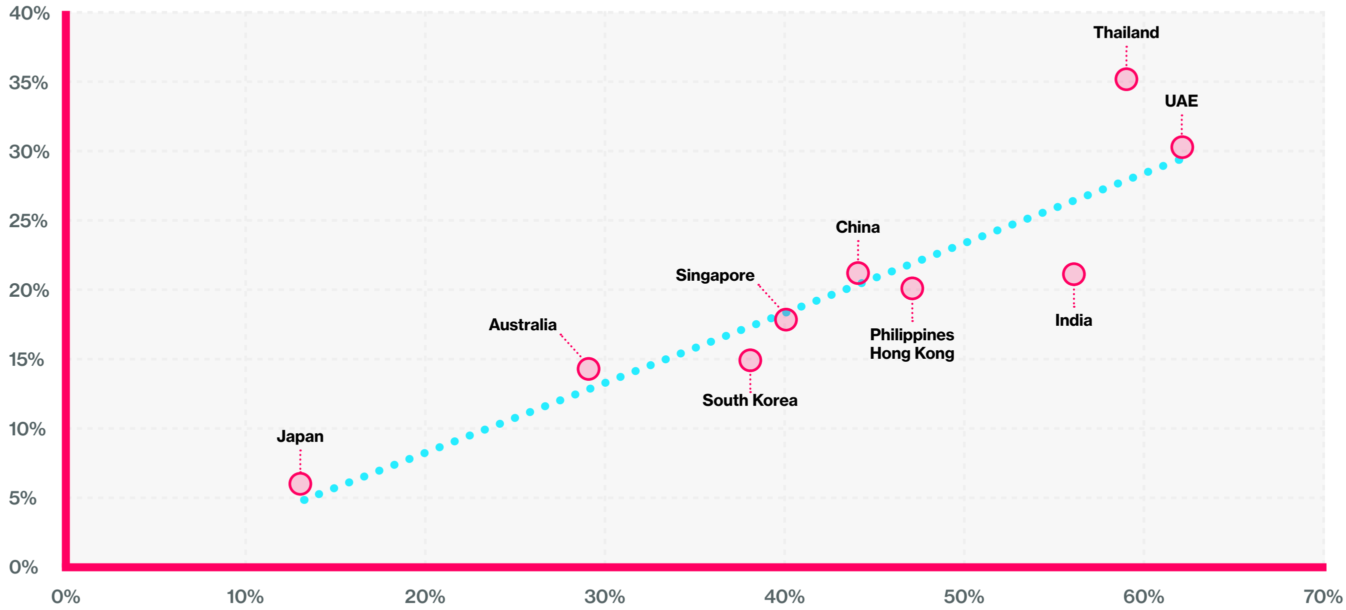
Education as Access

The strongest predictor of adoption remains familiarity. Across markets, **every** 10-point increase in familiarity correlates with a 7-point increase in use. Markets such as Thailand and the UAE lead because they combine consumer education with visible daily utility.

Exhibit 5.9

Stablecoin adoption increases with familiarity, underscoring education as a key driver of growth.

Relationship between familiarity with stablecoins (% of adults somewhat or very familiar) and current usage of stablecoins (% of adults who currently use them), by market



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. "Familiarity" defined as Top 2 Box (somewhat or very familiar) among all respondents aware of stablecoins; "adoption" represents self-reported current stablecoin use.

Payment-behaviour studies reinforce this link. In five emerging-market surveys, 47% of users cited “saving in dollars” and 39% “making payments” as primary motivations[8]. Merchants that offered clear wallet instructions recorded 1.8× higher repeat use. Familiarity – built through direct experience rather than theoretical understanding – turns awareness into habitual use.

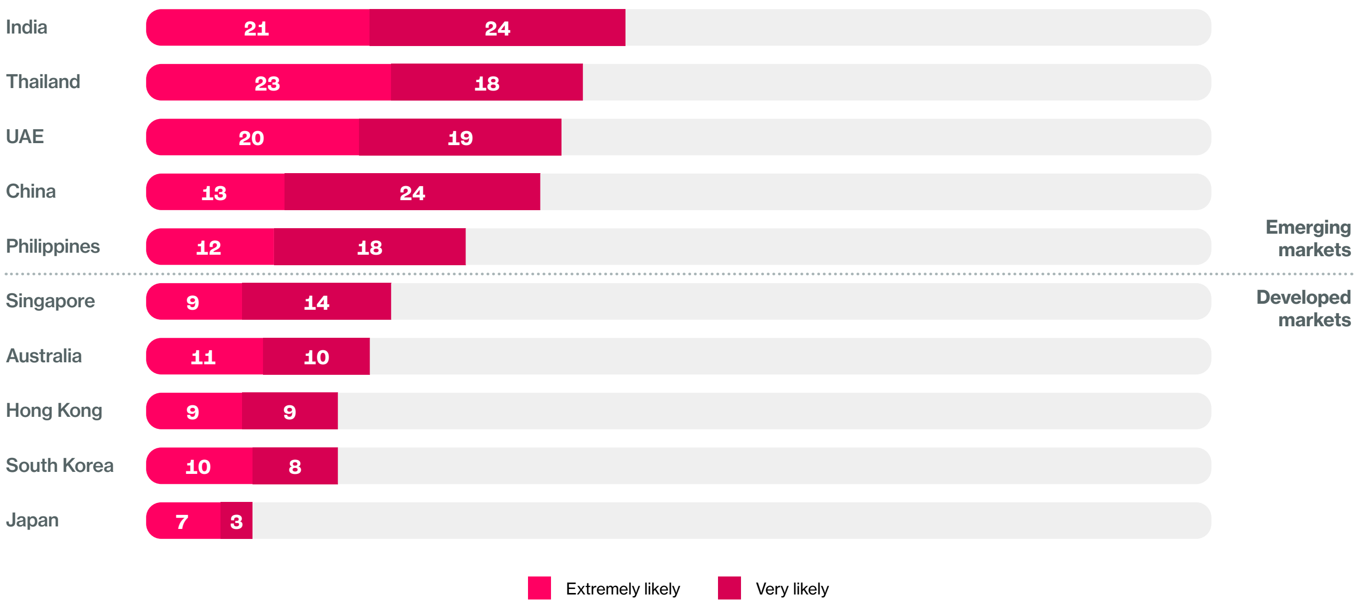
The same pattern appears in broader adoption research. Recent research has shown that complexity, compatibility, and visibility are the strongest predictors of mainstream uptake in digital finance[9]. Its central insight applies here: adoption grows when technology removes the need to be “educated” and instead makes its value self-evident through design, integration, and ease of trial.

When given a neutral explanation of what stablecoins are and how they work, 56% of adults across APAC said they were likely to use them for payments within a year – a figure rising to 70% in emerging markets.

Exhibit 5.10

When provided with a clear understanding of stablecoins, consumers show strong intent to use them for payments – particularly in emerging markets.

Share of adults who say they are “extremely likely” or “very likely” to use stablecoins for payments in the next 12 months, by market (% of respondents)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents selecting “extremely likely” or “very likely” to use stablecoins for payments in the next 12 months after being provided with an objective, neutral description of stablecoins and their relative advantages for consumer payments.

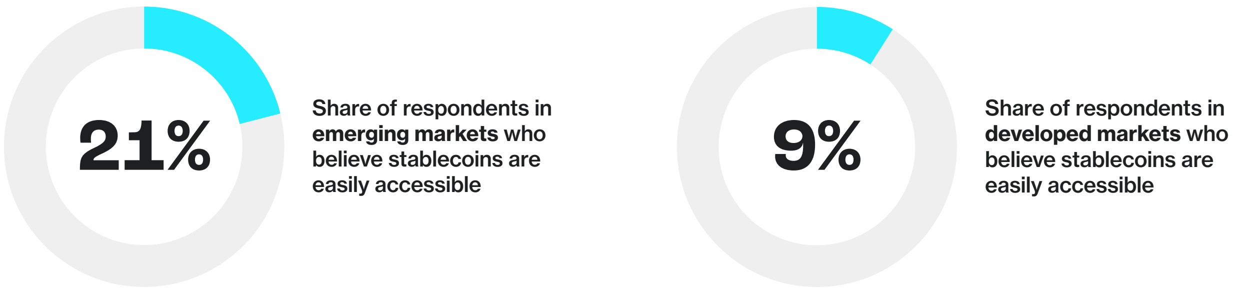
Education is therefore access in cognitive form: it reduces friction, increases confidence, and expands use cases.

The Accessibility Divide

Perceived accessibility remains the decisive bottleneck. Only 15% of adults across APAC believe stablecoins are “easily accessible” – 21% in emerging markets and 9% in developed ones.

Exhibit 5.11

Perceived accessibility remains low across APAC, highlighting the industry’s largest behavioral barrier.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Perceived level of accessibility was measured on a 4-point scale; figures represent the share selecting “Easily accessible” (Top Box).

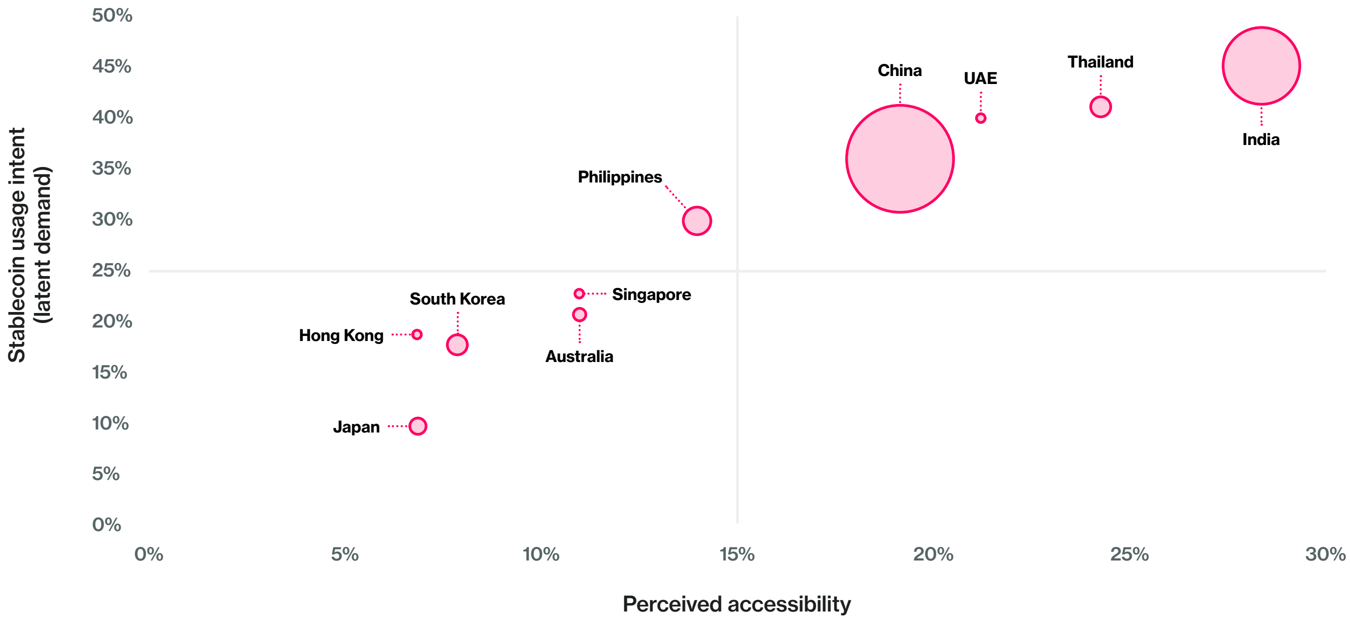
Front-end frictions amplify this gap. More than half of users manage two to five wallets, and 72% hold funds primarily on exchanges, often moving between apps to complete a transaction[10]. Merchant acceptance and fiat ramps are the next hurdles: Shopify, Visa, and Worldpay are piloting acquirer settlement rails that allow merchants to receive stablecoin proceeds instantly[11].

Exhibit 5.12

Greater perceived accessibility drives higher intent to adopt and use stablecoins for payments.

Relationship between perceived accessibility of stablecoins and intent to use stablecoins for payments in the next 12 months, by market

Note: Bubble size represents total consideration (% of respondents who are currently considering using or are open to using stablecoins).



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Perceived accessibility measured as share selecting "Easily accessible" (Top Box) on a 4-point response scale. Intent measured as share selecting "Extremely likely" or "Very likely" to use stablecoins for payments in the next 12 months.

The integration of stablecoins into traditional banking infrastructure – what BCG terms "BaaS 2.0 rails" – is extending access to new demographics, particularly where bank penetration is low. EY-Parthenon reports that 63% of corporates expect to access stablecoin services through their existing banks, signaling a shift from crypto-native channels to mainstream distribution[12].

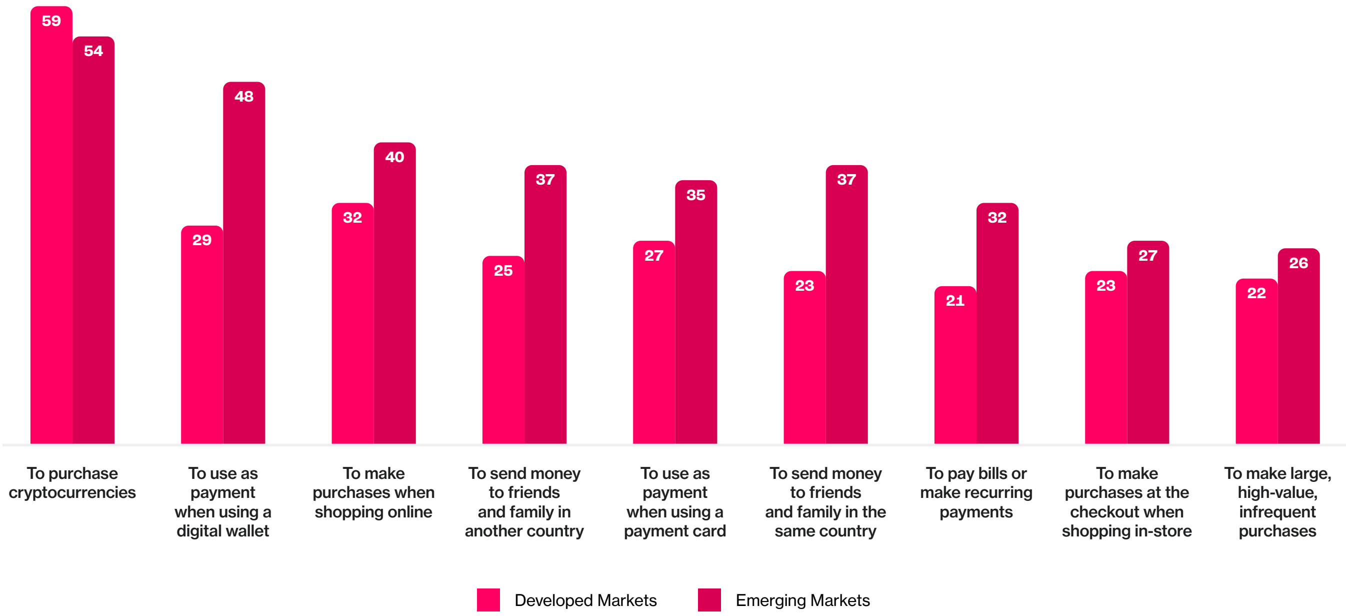
From Bridge Asset to Payment Rail

Stablecoin use is diversifying rapidly. In developed markets, 59% of users still employ them to purchase cryptocurrency, but in emerging economies 40–50% already use them for payments, remittances, and bill settlements. Merchant and processor data now quantify that shift: stablecoins account for 15% of remittance-like flows and 5% of merchant transactions, with B2B corridors running at a $36 billion annualized rate.

Exhibit 5.13

Emerging markets use stablecoins for a broader set of practical activities, while developed markets still use them mainly to buy crypto.

Share of current stablecoin users citing each reason for use, by region (% of current stablecoin users)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent current stablecoin users who selected each reason for use; multiple responses permitted.

Payment networks are embedding these rails into existing systems. Visa, Worldpay, and Nuvei have launched pilots that settle merchant payouts in USDC and other stablecoins, compressing cross-border settlement from T+2 days to T+0[13]. In 2025, travel and hospitality emerged as early testbeds: 77% of Travala bookings and 43% of UAE five-star hotels accepted crypto – mostly stablecoins – for payment. Worldpay (2025) projects that 79% of global e-commerce value will run through digital payments by 2030, giving stablecoins a pathway into mainstream consumer finance[14].

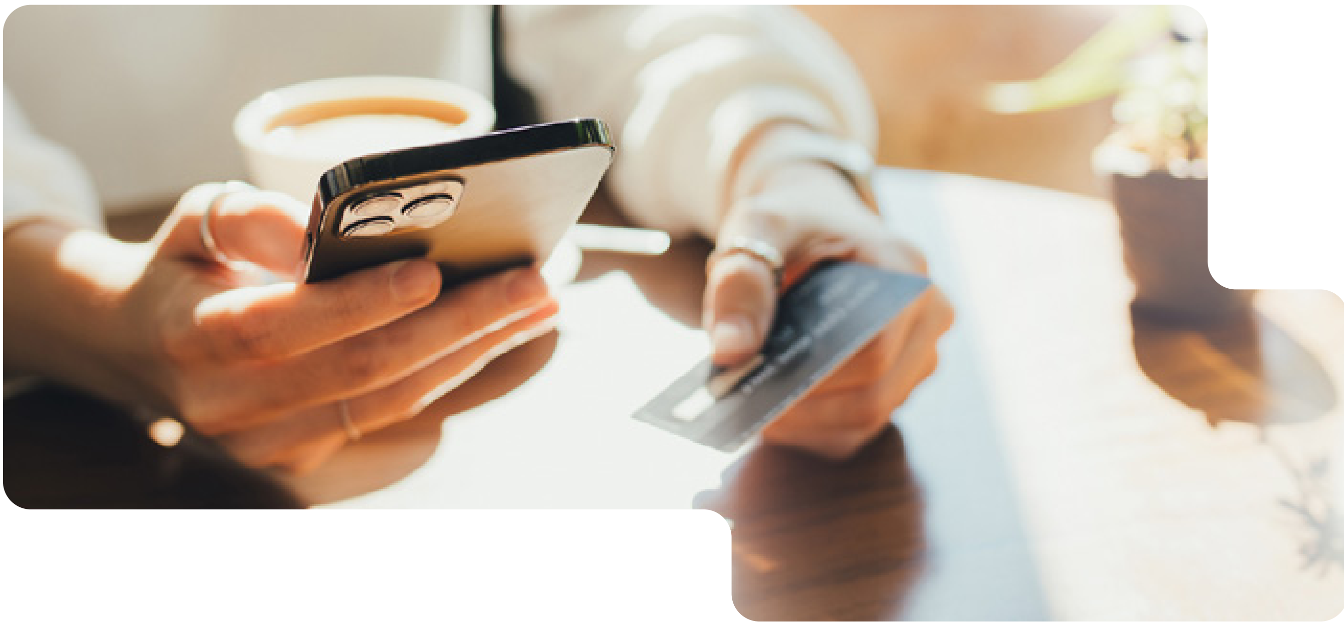
From Potential to Participation

Stablecoins have reached the inflection point where access becomes utility. Across APAC, the determinants of adoption – utility, familiarity, and perceived accessibility – are beginning to align. When consumers understand stablecoins, trust their stability, and can use them through systems they already rely on, adoption follows naturally.

The formula remains simple yet powerful:

Adoption = Utility × Familiarity × Accessibility

Stablecoins now stand as the connective tissue of the new financial stack. Whether they remain a niche trading instrument or evolve into a universal payment medium will depend on one thing: how easily people can reach, understand, and trust them.



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[2] **Source**: Citi Institute. (2025). *Stablecoins 2030: Web3 to Wall Street.* Global Perspectives & Solutions, Citigroup.
[3] **Source**: Visa (2025). *Transforming Global Payments: The Role of Tokenized Money & Funds in Cross-Border Transactions — Interim Report, e-HKD Pilot Programme Phase 2.*
[4] **Source**: Ernst & Young-Parthenon (2025). *Stablecoins in Focus: Navigating the New Digital Financial Landscape.*
[5] **Source**: Monetary Authority of Singapore (2025), *Stablecoin Regulatory Framework*; Hong Kong Monetary Authority (2025), *Stablecoins Ordinance (Cap. 656)*; Financial Services Agency of Japan (2023). *Payment Services Act Amendment.*
[6] **Source**: BCG (2025). *Global Payments Report 2025: The Future Is (Anything but) Stable* (September 2025).
[7] **Source**: Worldpay (2025). *Global Payments Report 2025: The Past, Present and Future of Consumer Payments.*
[8] **Source**: Castle Island Ventures & Brevan Howard Digital (2024). *Stablecoins: The Emerging Market Story*, sponsored by Visa.
[9] **Source**: Protocol Theory & Mercuryo (2025). *Beyond Early Adopters: What It Takes for Crypto to Matter in Everyday Life.*
[10] **Source**: Reown (2025). *The State of Onchain Payments.*
[11] **Source**: Roland Berger (2025). *Stablecoins: The Future of Money?*
[12] **Source**: Ernst & Young-Parthenon (2025). *Stablecoins in Focus: Navigating the New Digital Financial Landscape.*
[13] **Source**: Visa (2025). *Transforming Global Payments: The Role of Tokenized Money & Funds in Cross-Border Transactions — Interim Report, e-HKD Pilot Programme Phase 2.*
[14] **Source**: Worldpay (2025). *Global Payments Report 2025: The Past, Present and Future of Consumer Payments.*

Chapter 6: Remittances: Everyday Utility in Motion

At a Glance: Access That Moves Lives

For millions across Asia–Pacific, remittances are more than financial transfers – they are lifelines. The region accounts for nearly 40% of global remittance inflows, driven by corridors such as the Philippines, India, Thailand, and the UAE. Even with digital progress, sending money home remains expensive, fragmented, and slow

Key insights

- **31% of adults** across APAC use remittance services, led by emerging markets (36.9%) versus developed (26.8%).
- **Stablecoins reduce friction,** collapsing multi-party transfers into single transactions that are cheaper and faster.
- **25% of remittance** users now use stablecoins for cross-border payments, driven by the Philippines, India, Thailand, and the UAE.
- **Accessibility gap:** 61% of adults see traditional remittance services as easy to use vs only 15% for stablecoins.
- **Integration through trusted platforms** – banks, wallets, and telecom apps – remains key to mainstream uptake.

Remittances reveal access in its most human form: when technology simplifies connection, inclusion follows

The Lifeblood of the Region

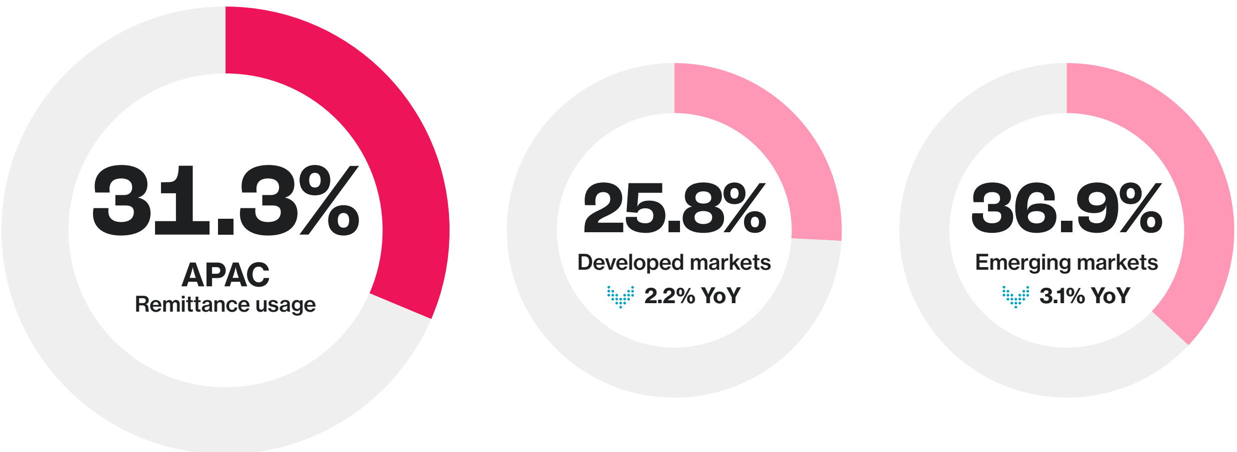
For much of Asia–Pacific, remittances are more than financial flows – they are threads of livelihood connecting families across borders. The region drives nearly 40% of global remittance inflows, with countries such as the Philippines, India, Thailand, and the UAE anchoring some of the world's most active corridors[1]. Despite digital advances, sending money home remains costly, fragmented, and slow.

Across APAC, 31% of adults currently use remittance services, down slightly from 32% in 2024. Usage remains far higher in emerging markets (36.9%) than in developed ones (26.8%), underscoring the continued centrality of remittances to financial inclusion.

Exhibit 6.1

Remittances remain a key component of financial participation in emerging markets.

Share of internet-connected adults who currently use remittance services, by region (% of population aged 18-64)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents who indicated that they currently use remittance services.

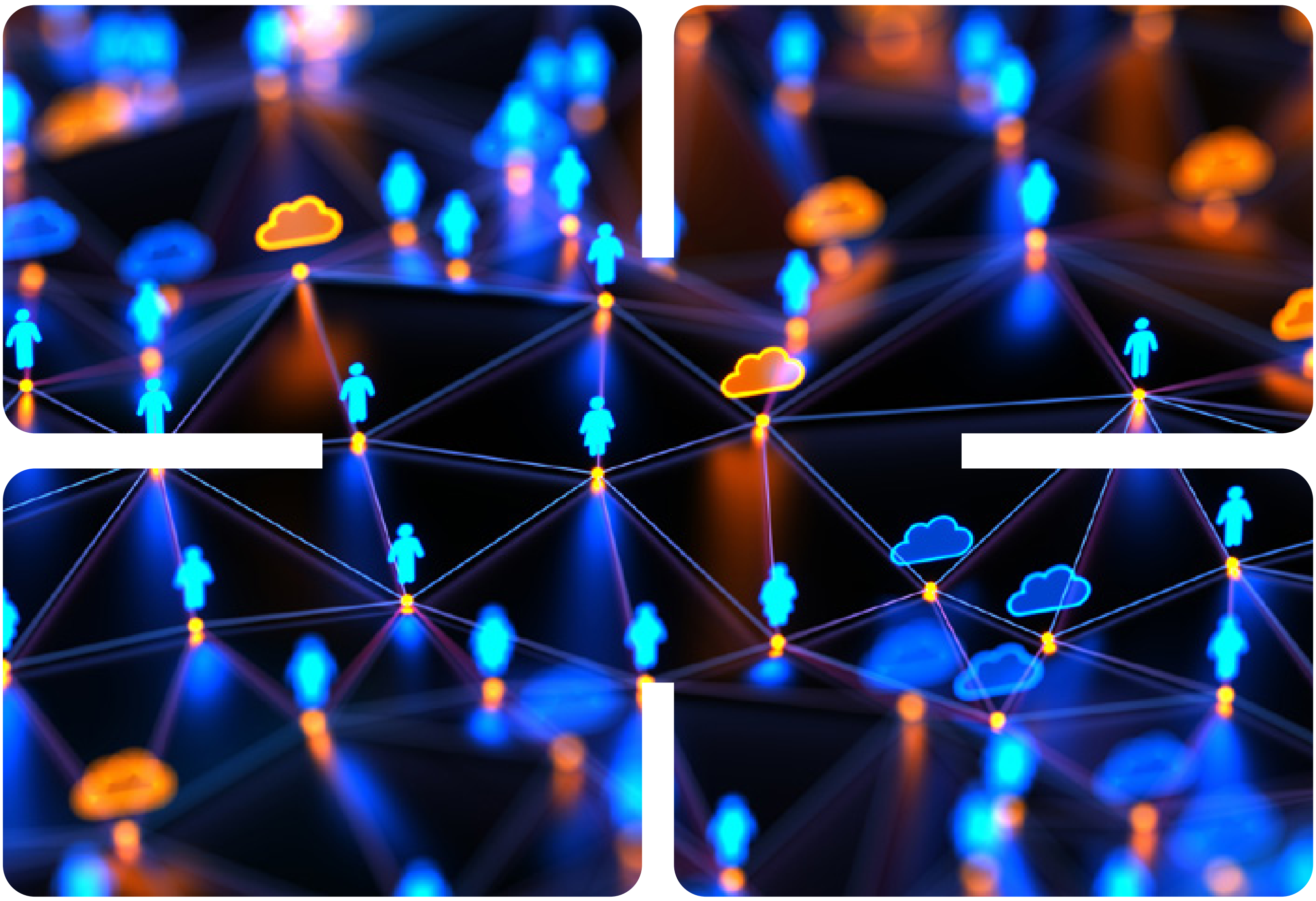
This modest year-on-year decline (−3.1 points emerging; −2.2 developed) reflects short-term cyclical pressures rather than structural retreat. In key corridors such as the Philippines, India, and the UAE, remittances continue to define everyday financial behaviour – a testament to their enduring economic and social importance.

Persistent Friction in Moving Money

Sending money across borders remains one of the most expensive financial activities in the region. Average fees on traditional corridors range from 4 to 6%, with FX spreads and intermediary costs compounding the loss. Survey data show the top frustrations among senders are poor exchange rates (44%), hidden or high fees (35%), and slow settlements (27%).

The problem is not a lack of infrastructure – it is fragmentation. Transfers often move through multiple correspondent networks before reaching recipients, each layer adding cost and delay. Mobile and wallet-based services have expanded, but most operate as closed systems lacking interoperability. Efficiency gains stop at the platform boundary.

Stablecoins collapse these layers into a single transaction, converting friction into function. By replacing intermediaries with programmable value transfer, they demonstrate how inclusion scales when technology serves flow rather than form.



The Behavioral Landscape: Who Sends and Why

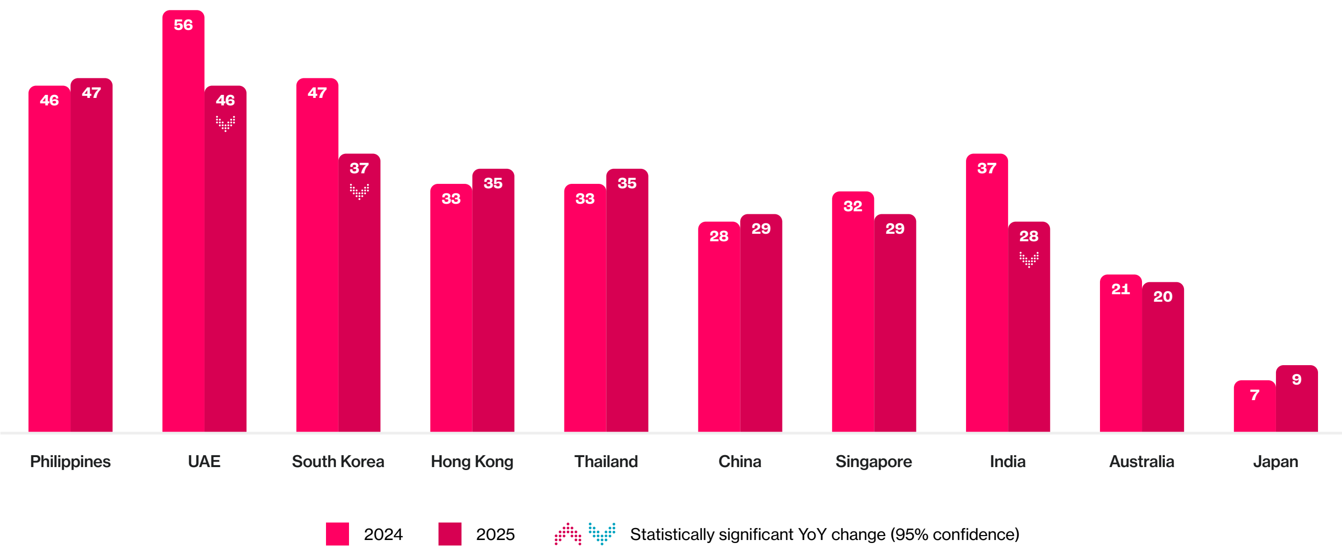
Remittances remain one of the most universal financial behaviors in the region. Roughly one in three adults in emerging markets – and one in four in developed economies – send or receive money across borders. Mobile access, digital wallets, and fintech platforms are redefining how remitters engage with financial systems.

Between 2024 and 2025, participation declined slightly but remained highest in the Philippines (47%), UAE (46%), and Thailand (35%). Even in advanced markets, remittances touch meaningful segments of the population – 33% in Hong Kong and 29% in Singapore – reflecting regional mobility and transnational workforces.

Exhibit 6.2

Remittance activity remains steady across APAC, led by high-dependency corridors in the Philippines and UAE.

Share of internet-connected adults who currently use remittance services, by market (% of population aged 18-64, 2024 vs 2025)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents who indicated that they currently use remittance services.

Motivations are primarily personal and pragmatic: supporting family, meeting obligations, and maintaining connection. Gender parity has improved, and younger migrants increasingly use mobile-first tools.
For many, remittances represent their first independent financial engagement – an accessible gateway to formal digital finance.

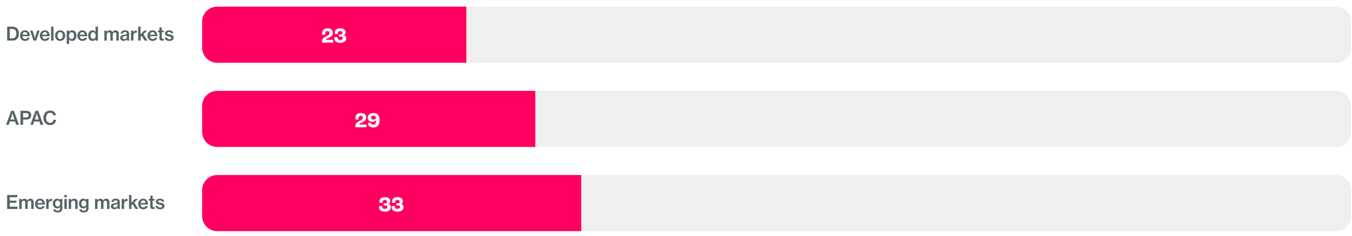
The Stablecoin Connection: From Access to Action

The intersection of remittances and stablecoins illustrates how access transforms innovation into infrastructure. Adoption, however, still lags potential. Across APAC, only 29% of remittance users employ stablecoins, leaving three in four yet to make the shift.

Exhibit 6.3

Despite clear advantages, most remittance users have not yet adopted stablecoins.

Stablecoin usage among current remittance users, be region (% of remittance users aged 18-64)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents who indicated that they currently use both remittance services and stablecoins.

Adoption is strongest where friction is greatest. In the Philippines, Thailand, and India, remitters increasingly use stablecoin rails to bypass fees and delays. Artemis (2025) estimates more than $72 billion in annualized P2P and remittance-like stablecoin flows, with corridors such as Singapore ↔ China and Thailand ↔ Philippines among the most active globally[2].

Still, behavioral inertia remains. Traditional channels are viewed as safer and simpler, even when objectively slower and more expensive. Stablecoins are technically ready but behaviorally nascent – the gap is perception, not capability.

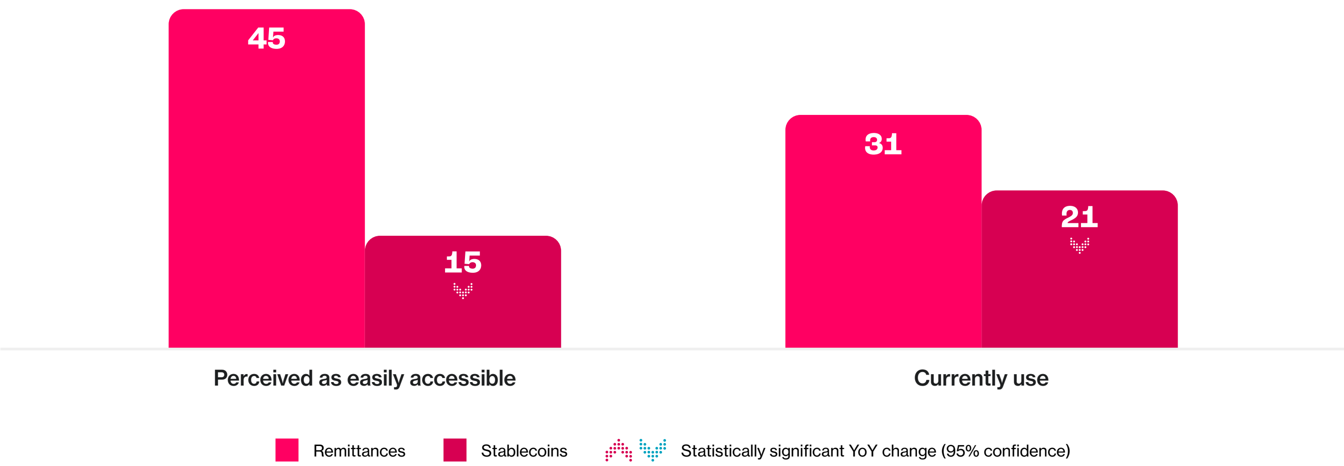
Accessibility and Perception: the Invisible Wall

When asked which services feel "easy to access", 61% of APAC adults selected remittance providers compared with just 15% for stablecoins (21% in emerging vs 9% in developed markets).

Exhibit 6.4

Remittances enjoy far higher perceived accessibility than stablecoins, highlighting a psychological barrier to switching.

Share of internet-connected adults who currently use remittance services, by market (% of population aged 18-64, 2024 vs 2025)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the share of adults who perceive each service as "easily accessible" and who report currently using each service for payments or money transfers.

Perceived accessibility, more than regulation or price, predicts intent to adopt. Statistical modeling shows a strong positive correlation between perceived ease and likelihood of using stablecoins for future remittances. In behavioral terms, accessibility is psychological before it is technical: people adopt what feels simple, not merely what is available.

The Thunes (2025) *Money Without Borders* study reinforces this point: 88% of remitters said they would switch to a new service if it offered a simpler, embedded experience with lower friction[3]. Trust and usability therefore remain the twin gatekeepers of conversion.

Proof in Motion: Emerging Markets Leading the Shift

Across emerging markets, stablecoin remittances are already moving from experiment to habit. In the Philippines, Thailand, India, and the UAE, stablecoin integrations within licensed wallets and payment apps are cutting settlement times from days to minutes. Migrant workers in the UAE now use AED-backed stablecoins to remit funds to South Asia through regulated corridors – an example of utility preceding belief.

External evidence corroborates this momentum. Castle Island (2025) found that in emerging economies, “saving in dollars” and “making payments” are the dominant stablecoin motivations, while corporate data show consistent cost savings on cross-border settlement .

Behaviour comes first; perception follows. These markets demonstrate that digital inclusion scales fastest when usability, not ideology, drives adoption.

The Economic Dividend: Quantifying Inclusion

The benefits extend beyond convenience. Cutting average remittance fees by just two percentage points could generate approximately $9 billion in annual household savings across APAC. Such gains translate directly into local consumption and social mobility, particularly in economies where remittances account for more than 10% of GDP – notably the Philippines, Vietnam, and India.

Cross-border data suggest stablecoins currently power less than 1% of all remittance transactions but could expand to a $16–24 trillion market opportunity when scaled across B2B and P2P segments[5]. Each incremental percentage age of efficiency compounds across millions of transfers, turning technological progress into measurable welfare.

Designing for Scale: Interoperability and Trust

Despite clear potential, fragmentation still limits reach. Accenture (2025) identifies more than 70 distributed ledgers already active in payment and settlement use, many of which cannot interact directly[6]. Without common standards, liquidity remains trapped in isolated networks.

Equally, consumer trust hinges on familiarity. Users prefer stablecoin remittance rails *through* trusted brands – banks, telecom wallets, or fintech platforms – rather than alongside them. Scale, therefore, depends less on invention than integration: embedding stablecoin transfers within systems people already use, where regulation, identity, and experience converge.

From Utility to Inclusion: The New Access Loop

Remittances represent the clearest proof of concept for digital assets as instruments of inclusion. They show that when access is intuitive, trust embedded, and benefits tangible, adoption becomes organic.

Stablecoins are compressing the journey from intent to outcome – from days to minutes, from intermediaries to interfaces, from fees to function. This transition marks the shift from digital assets as speculative instruments to practical financial infrastructure.

The same access–utility loop that drives remittances will define the next phase of digital finance: extending from moving money to moving value. As funds now cross borders with ease, assets themselves are beginning to follow.

References
[1] **Source**: VISA (2025). Money Travels: *2025 Digital Remittances Adoption Report*.
[2] **Source**: Artemis, Castle Island Ventures & Dragonfly (May 2025). *Stablecoin Payments from the Ground Up*.
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[5] **Source**: FXC Intelligence (July 2025). *The State of Stablecoins in Cross-Border Payments: The 2025 Industry Primer*.
[6] **Source**: Accenture & Chainlink (May 2025). *Liquidity Without Borders: Why Cross-Chain Interoperability Is Essential in an Increasingly Multi-Chain Financial Services Landscape*.

Chapter 7: Real-World Assets: The Investment Frontier

At a Glance: From Transactions to Ownership

Asia–Pacific's digital-finance journey is expanding from moving money to owning value. Tokenized real-world assets (RWAs) – digital representations of tangible or regulated assets such as equities, property, infrastructure, and credit – are making ownership more reachable than ever.

Key insights

- **14.8% of internet-connected adults across APAC** now invest in RWAs, including 15.6% in emerging markets and 5.6% in developed economies.
- **Awareness outpaces familiarity:** 50–65% have heard of RWAs, but only 25–35% say they understand them.
- **Access predicts intent:** people who view RWAs as "easily accessible" are 1.5× more likely to plan an investment.
- **Top motivations:** liquidity (37%), fractional ownership (37%), and cross-border access (36%).
- **Only 13% of adults** view RWAs as "easy to access," with the lowest perception in developed markets.

Tokenization applies the same principle that stablecoins brought to payments: **removing unnecessary layers between people and opportunity.**

From Utility to Ownership

Across Asia–Pacific, financial participation is expanding from the ability to move money to the ability to own productive assets. Tokenized real-world assets (RWAs) – digital representations of physical or regulated assets such as equities, property, infrastructure, or credit – enable individuals to hold fractional interests in markets once limited to institutions. Tokenization applies the same principle that stablecoins introduced to payments: removing layers between individuals and opportunity.

For consumers, tokenization offers practical access. It allows fractional ownership of high-value assets, faster settlement, and cross-border participation without the procedural constraints of traditional investment systems. Early adoption remains limited, but measurable patterns are emerging that point to its potential role in broadening investment inclusion.

For institutions, the opportunity is equally compelling: across the region, central banks and institutions are piloting tokenized funds, bonds, and deposits under regulated frameworks. The Monetary Authority of Singapore's *Project Guardian* and the Hong Kong Monetary Authority's *Genesis II* pilot have already demonstrated tokenized bond issuance and secondary trading[1]. BCG (2025) estimates that globally, tokenized financial assets could exceed US $19 trillion by 2033, though Asia's trajectory will depend on how quickly access becomes intuitive[2].

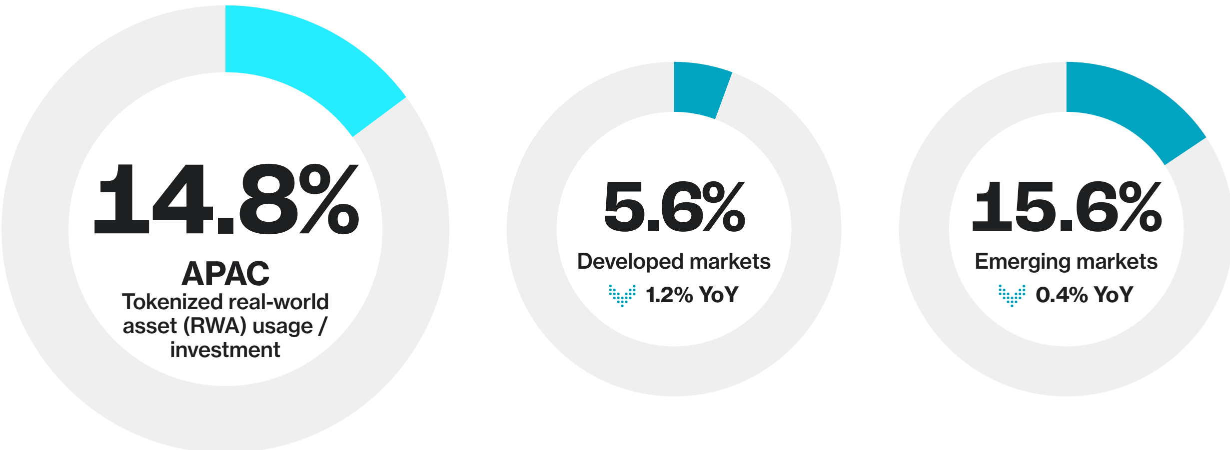
Adoption and Familiarity Across APAC

Adoption of tokenized real-world assets remains nascent but measurable. As of 2025, 14.8% of internet-connected adults across APAC report investing in RWAs – 15.6% in emerging markets and 5.6% in developed economies, a modest decline from the previous year[3].

Exhibit 7.1

Adoption of tokenized assets remains early-stage, with emerging markets leading uptake.

Share of internet-connected adults who currently use or invest in tokenized real-world assets (RWAs), by region (% of population aged 18-64)



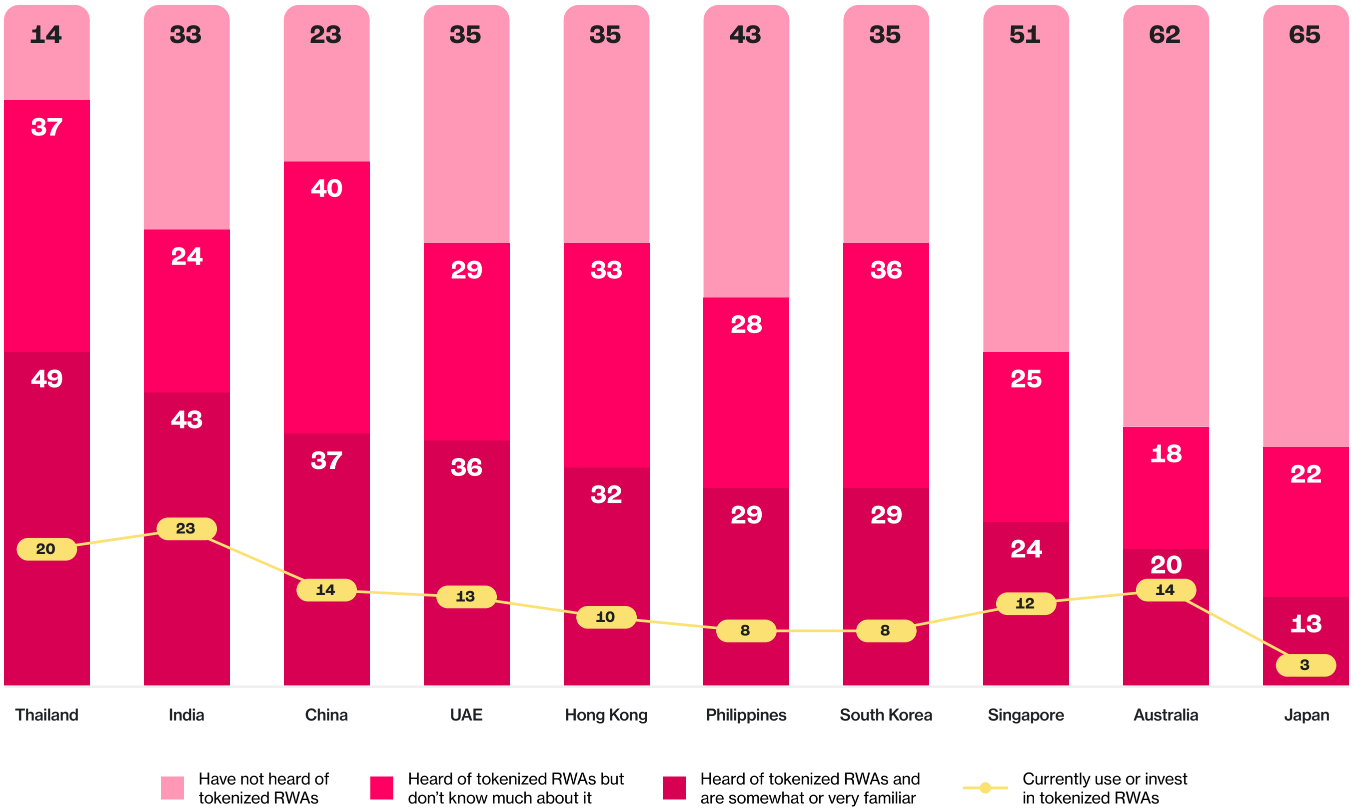
Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents who indicated that they currently invest in tokenized real-world assets (RWAs). Year-on-year change shown relative to 2024 results.

This pattern mirrors the early stages of stablecoin adoption: broad awareness, modest familiarity, and limited direct participation. Awareness of RWAs is relatively high (50–65%), but only 25–35% of adults say they understand how tokenization works.

Exhibit 7.2

Awareness, familiarity, and usage of tokenized RWAs, by market.

Awareness is widespread, but familiarity and participation remain low across most markets.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents who indicated awareness, familiarity ("somewhat" or "very familiar"), or current usage/investment in tokenized real-world assets (RWAs).

Understanding lags visibility. People know of tokenization but not how to participate, reflecting a broader theme across digital assets: "knowing of" is not "knowing how." The *World Economic Forum (2025)* frames RWAs as the bridge between traditional finance and digital markets, but without accessible on-ramps, that bridge remains underused[4].

Financial innovation always crosses the same threshold: from conceptual promise to practical experience. For most people, tokenization feels abstract until it connects to familiar assets such as property or company shares.

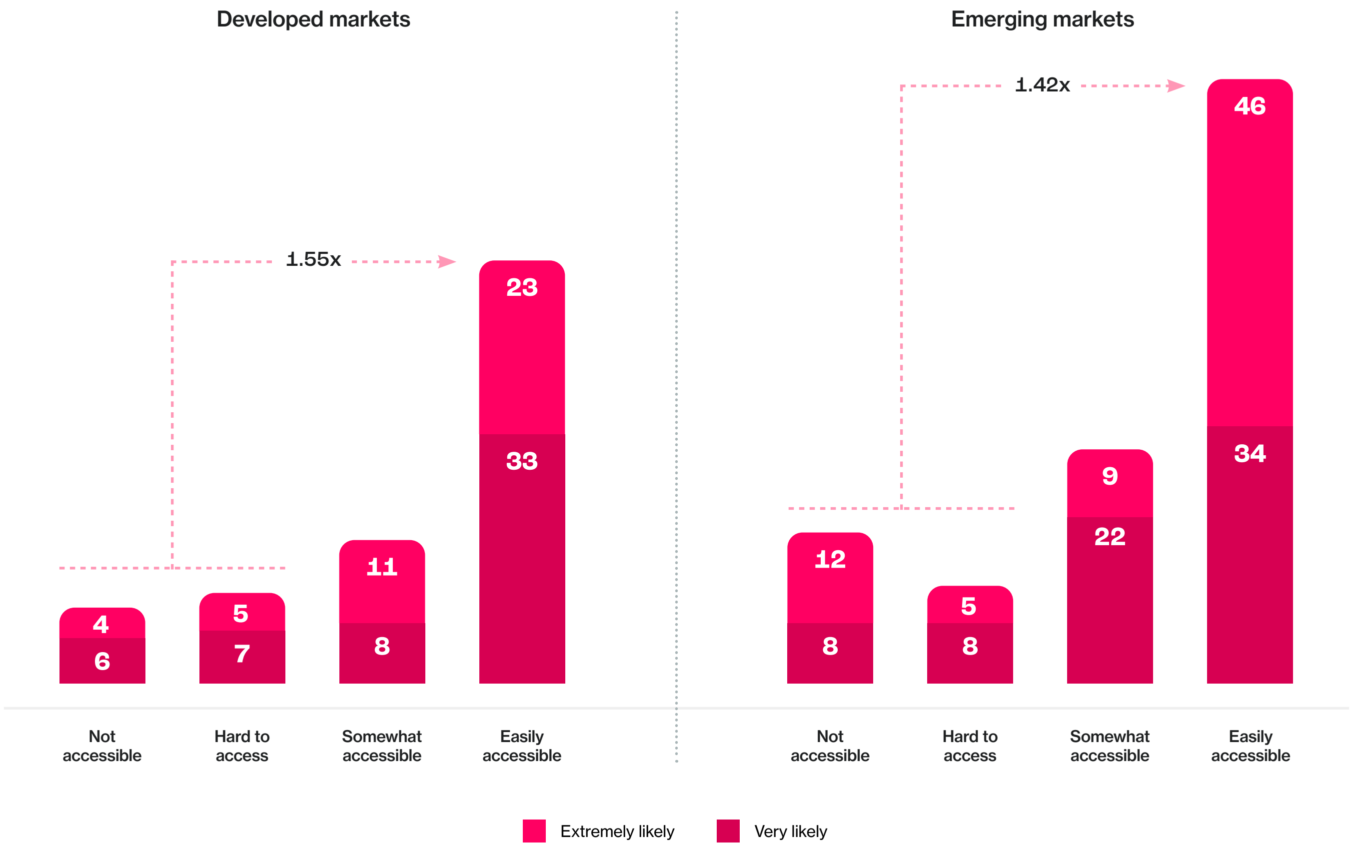
Intent and the Accessibility Effect

Intent to invest in tokenized assets is already substantial. Across APAC, 26% of adults describe themselves as "very" or "extremely" likely to invest in RWAs within the next 12 months. Among those who perceive RWAs as "easily accessible," intent is 1.5 times higher.

Exhibit 7.3

Likelihood to invest in RWAs by perceived accessibility.

Investment intent rises sharply as perceived accessibility improves, highlighting access as the primary growth driver.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent Top 2 Box intent to invest ("very likely" or "extremely likely") and corresponding perceived accessibility levels of tokenized RWAs. Multipliers indicate likelihood relative to those who perceive RWAs as not or hard to access.

This relationship reflects a consistent behavioral pattern across the report: accessibility amplifies adoption. When individuals believe they can act easily, they are more likely to do so. Visa's 2025 pilot with the Hong Kong Monetary Authority, which demonstrated near-real-time subscription and settlement for tokenized funds, underscores how reducing friction converts interest into participation[5].

In behavioral terms, participation can be expressed as:

Familiarity × Perceived Accessibility = Participation

Each factor reinforces the other. Without understanding, access feels unsafe; without access, understanding remains theoretical. Tokenization succeeds when both converge.

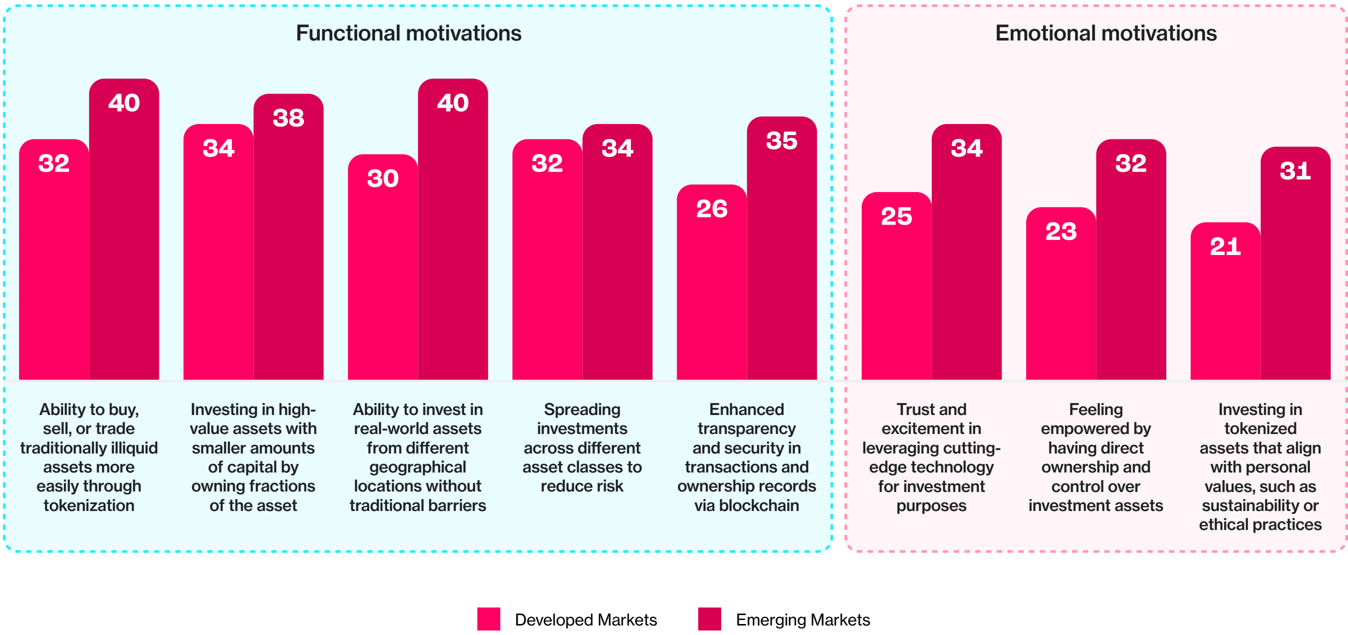
Why People Invest

Motivations for investing in tokenized assets are pragmatic. The leading reasons include liquidity (37%), fractional ownership of high-value assets (37%), cross-border access (36%), diversification (34%), and transparency and security (32%).

Exhibit 7.4

Top reasons for interest in tokenized real-world assets.

Practical benefits – liquidity, fractional ownership, and diversification – dominate consumer motivations.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents selecting each reason for interest in purchasing or investing in tokenized real-world assets (RWAs); multiple responses permitted.

These drivers reflect utility, not novelty. In emerging markets, tokenization provides access to instruments historically beyond reach. In developed markets, it enhances efficiency through faster settlement, improved record-keeping, and more flexible asset management.

The *World Economic Forum (2025)* identifies the same functional themes as core to tokenization's appeal, emphasizing how on-ledger transparency and fractional entry lower both informational and financial barriers[6]. Across APAC, this pragmatic appeal outweighs speculative motives. Tokenization's value lies not in what is new, but in what it simplifies.

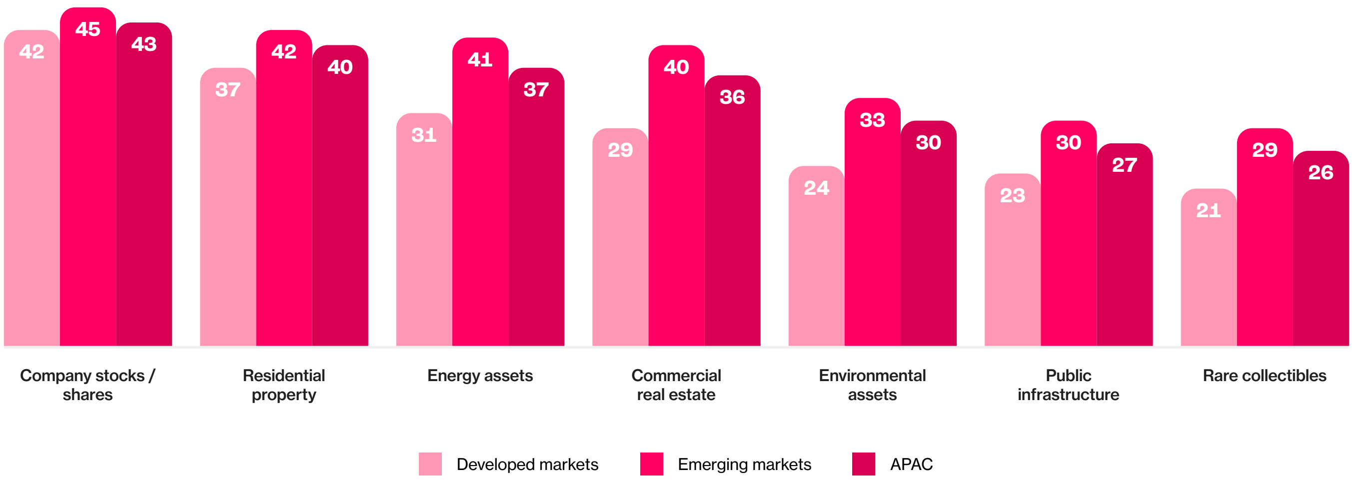
What Investors Want to Own

When asked which assets they would most likely invest in if tokenized, respondents chose company stocks (43%), residential property (40%), and commercial real estate (33%). Energy and infrastructure assets followed closely, cited by roughly one in three adults.

Exhibit 7.5

Assets respondents are most likely to invest in if tokenized.

Investor interest remains concentrated in familiar asset classes, suggesting tokenization will follow established preferences before expanding into new categories.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent non-users who are "very likely" or "extremely likely" to purchase or invest in tokenized real-world assets (RWAs) and who selected each type of asset. Multiple responses permitted.

These preferences illustrate a familiar adoption curve: investors begin with assets they understand before exploring new categories enabled by digital form. In emerging markets, demand for property and infrastructure reflects both aspiration and stability – tangible assets tied to progress. In developed markets, the focus is diversification and yield optimization.

The implication is clear: tokenization gains traction when it begins with what people already trust. Once these assets demonstrate reliability, transparency, and liquidity, confidence can extend to more complex or novel instruments.

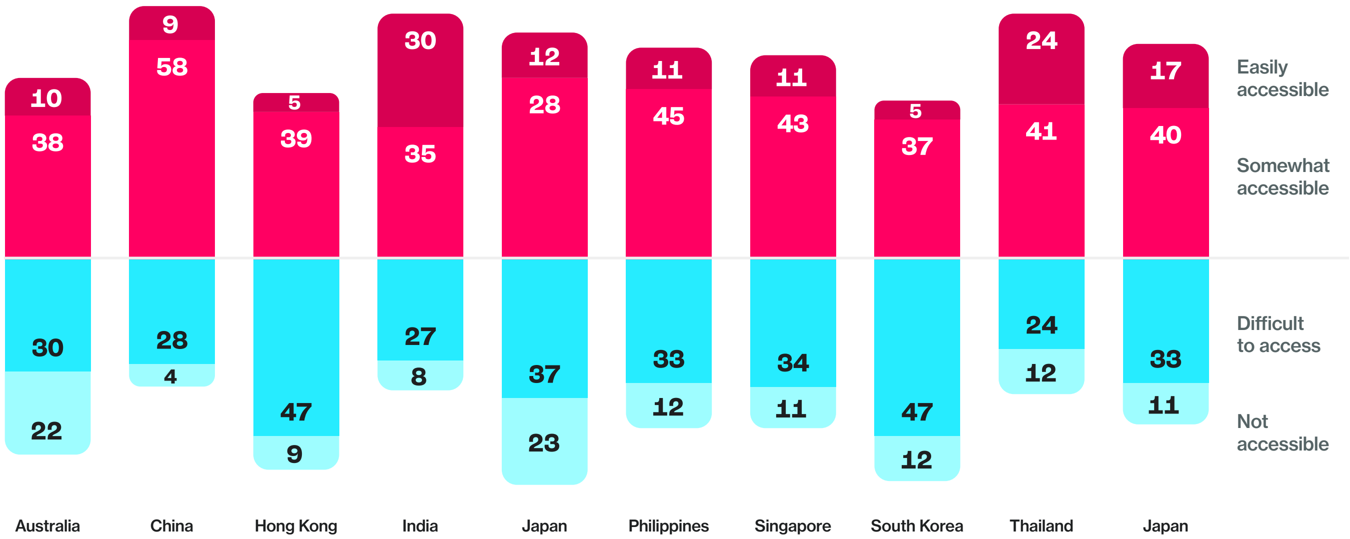
Access and Perception: The Persistent Gap

The primary constraint remains perception of accessibility. Across APAC, only 13% of adults view tokenized assets as "easy to access," falling to 9% in developed markets.

Exhibit 7.6

Perceived accessibility of RWAs by region.

Despite strong intent, low perceived accessibility constrains participation across markets.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent respondents rating the accessibility of tokenized real-world assets (RWAs) on a four-point scale ranging from "not accessible" to "easily accessible."

Markets such as India and the Philippines show the widest gap between intent and access, while Japan ranks low on both – illustrating that optimism alone does not drive participation. Accenture (2025) identifies more than 70 distributed-ledger systems active in tokenization and settlement, each operating as a "liquidity island"[7]. The absence of interoperability creates friction for retail users that institutions can better absorb.

Bridging this gap will require coordinated progress across technology, policy, and education. Without shared standards and clear regulatory frameworks, adoption risks stalling in the space between awareness and usability.

Different Motivations, Shared Ambition

Behavioral differences between emerging and developed markets are distinct but aligned in purpose. In emerging economies, tokenization represents access – enabling investment in stable, income-generating assets once beyond reach. In developed economies, it represents efficiency – streamlined custody, automation, and continuous liquidity.

The outcome is the same: broader financial mobility. Prior research has shown that intent to engage in tokenized assets is roughly **twice as high in emerging markets (32%)** as in developed ones (15%)[8], while *Standard Chartered* (2025) notes rising demand among emerging-market households for on-chain dollar and yield instruments[9]. Tokenization, therefore, is less about geography than capability – the ability to convert opportunity into participation.

From Access to Ownership

Tokenized real-world assets complete the digital adoption arc. Where stablecoins democratized payments and remittances redefined utility, RWAs extend inclusion into ownership. The behavioral principle remains consistent: when people can easily reach, understand, and trust a financial tool, it becomes part of daily life.

Awareness ⟶ Access ⟶ Utility ⟶ Ownership

This progression marks the next phase of digital finance in Asia–Pacific. The future is defined not by replacement but by convergence – the blending of traditional and on-chain systems into a unified financial continuum. As tokenization becomes embedded in everyday investment, inclusion will evolve from participating in transactions to participating in growth.

References
[1] **Source**: Visa (2025). *Transforming Global Payments: The Role of Tokenized Money & Funds in Cross-Border Transactions — Interim Report, e-HKD Pilot Programme Phase 2.*
[2] **Source**: BCG (2025). *Global Payments Report 2025: The Future Is (Anything but) Stable* (September 2025).
[3] **Source**: CoinDesk & Protocol Theory (2024). *Driven by Demand: The People-Powered Crypto Movement in Asia-Pacific.*
[4] **Source**: World Economic Forum & Accenture (2025). *Asset Tokenisation in Financial Markets: The Next Generation of Value Exchange.*
[5] **Source**: Visa (2025). *Transforming Global Payments: The Role of Tokenized Money & Funds in Cross-Border Transactions — Interim Report, e-HKD Pilot Programme Phase 2.*
[6] **Source**: World Economic Forum & Accenture (2025). *Asset Tokenisation in Financial Markets: The Next Generation of Value Exchange.*
[7] **Source**: Accenture & Chainlink (May 2025). *Liquidity Without Borders: Why Cross-Chain Interoperability Is Essential in an Increasingly Multi-Chain Financial Services Landscape.*
[8] **Source**: CoinDesk & Protocol Theory (2024). *Driven by Demand: The People-Powered Crypto Movement in Asia-Pacific.*
[9] **Source**: Standard Chartered Bank (October 2025). *Stablecoins – Implications for Emerging Markets.*

Chapter 8: Digital Asset & TradFi Integration: Access by Design

At a Glance: When Systems Work Together, Access Scales

Digital assets and traditional finance are no longer distinct domains. Across Asia–Pacific, they are beginning to operate as complementary parts of the same financial system. Consumers increasingly expect money to move seamlessly between wallets and bank accounts, supported by the same standards of safety and trust.

Key insights

- **59% of adults** across APAC believe it should be easier to move money between digital and traditional platforms.
- **71%** want closer cooperation among regulators, banks, and exchanges; only 9% oppose it.
- **60%** expect banks to eventually offer digital asset accounts or wallets; 52% say they would store assets with a bank if possible.
- **55%** expect crypto platforms to add traditional financial services, and 47% would open a banking account with an exchange if allowed.
- **Emerging-market consumers** are 1.5× more likely than developed-market peers to call for integration across all measures.
- **Integration is already advancing** through pilots in Singapore, Hong Kong, and Australia, embedding tokenized deposits, stablecoins, and funds within regulated frameworks.

Integration represents the next stage of access – when usability, trust, and interoperability merge to make finance feel seamless.

Integration as the Next Stage of Inclusion

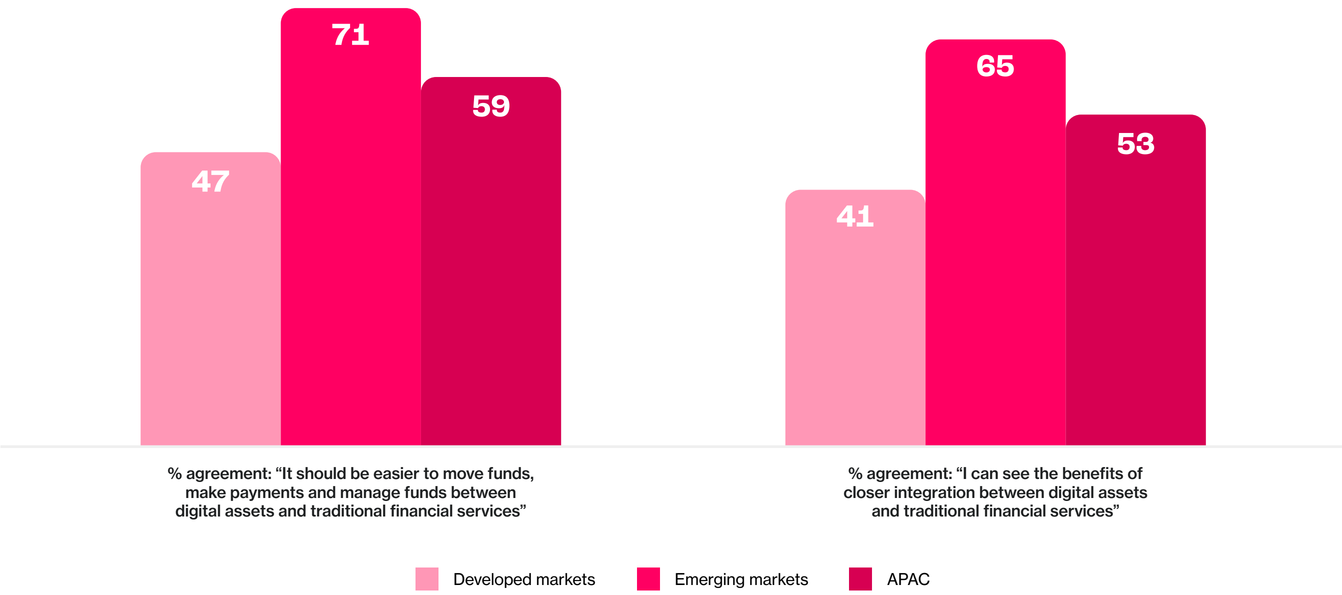
For more than a decade, digital assets and traditional finance have progressed along separate tracks, each addressing different needs in how people save, move, and invest money. That divide is narrowing. Across Asia–Pacific, consumers no longer view digital assets and banks as competing systems but as complementary parts of a single financial experience.

Findings across the region show that 59% of adults believe it should be easier to move and manage funds across both digital and traditional platforms. Appetite for integration is strongest in emerging economies, where financial infrastructure remains fragmented, but is also rising in developed centres such as Singapore and Hong Kong, where interoperability is seen as a marker of maturity and trust.

Exhibit 8.1

Demand for easier movement of funds and closer integration between digital assets and traditional finance is strongest in emerging markets.

Share of adults agreeing with statements about the integration of digital assets and traditional financial services, by region (% Top 2 Box: "strongly agree" or "somewhat agree")



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the share of respondents agreeing (Top 2 Box) with each statement.

This is not a call for disruption but for coherence. Consumers are signaling that the next phase of inclusion depends on systems working together – where managing a digital wallet feels as familiar as checking a bank balance, and where consistent regulatory protection applies across both.

The Cooperation Consensus

Across all ten markets, 71% of adults want greater cooperation among regulators, banks, and exchanges, and 56% say they would be more likely to use digital assets if that collaboration improved. Only 9% oppose closer coordination.

Support for cooperation is broad-based. In India and Thailand, endorsement exceeds 70%, underscoring how convergence often emerges from necessity in emerging markets. In developed economies, 59% in Singapore and 58% in Hong Kong express similar expectations – less as a functional need and more as a measure of legitimacy.

Integration, in other words, is not contentious; it is consensus. The shift from *if* to *how soon* suggests that inclusion in APAC increasingly depends on interoperability rather than invention.

The Institutional Expectation

The majority of consumers now expect banks to play an active role in digital assets. 60% of adults across the region believe banks will eventually offer digital asset accounts or wallets, and 52% say they would store digital assets with a bank if possible. Among current crypto users, that figure rises to around 70%.

This is a practical preference, not nostalgia for traditional institutions. Consumers trust banks for their infrastructure, compliance, and continuity – and increasingly want these strengths applied to digital finance. Singapore's DBS Bank, which already offers institutional-grade custody and tokenized bond trading, illustrates how integration can extend rather than redefine banking's role.

The message is clear: people do not want to replace regulated finance – they want it to evolve.

The Reciprocal Demand

As banks move toward digital assets, consumers expect exchanges to move toward banking. Across APAC, 55% of adults expect crypto platforms to add services such as deposits, loans, or equities trading, and 47% would open a bank account with an exchange if allowed.

Demand is significantly stronger in emerging markets (61%) than in developed economies (33%), showing that the pressure for convergence is greatest where access gaps persist. When consumers experience friction between systems, they seek unification through hybrid solutions.

This is already evident in practice. Crypto debit cards, issued through partnerships between exchanges and payment providers, are now used or considered by 44% of adults, illustrating that cooperation often precedes full integration.

Regional Divergence, Shared Intent

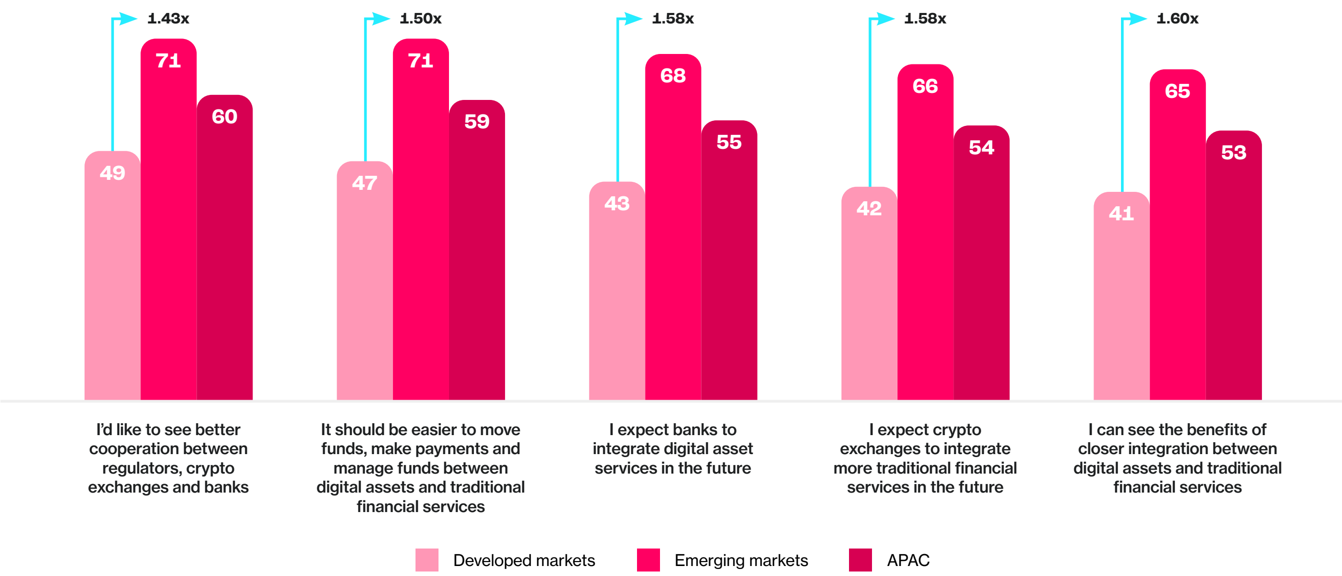
Emerging markets are approximately 1.5× more likely than developed ones to anticipate or call for integration across every measure surveyed.

Exhibit 8.2

Emerging market respondents show stronger expectations for integration between digital assets and traditional finance.

Share of adults agreeing with each statement, by region (% Top 2 Box: "strongly agree" or "somewhat agree")

Note: Across all statements, emerging market respondents are around **1.5× more likely** than those in developed markets to anticipate or call for stronger links between digital assets and traditional finance – highlighting greater openness to convergence in markets where access and innovation pressures are highest.



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the share of respondents agreeing (Top 2 Box) with each statement.

In markets such as India, where 70% of respondents would store digital assets with a bank, integration represents empowerment – a means of formal participation in global finance. In developed centres such as Singapore, integration represents assurance, extending established consumer protections to a once-peripheral category.

Both paths lead to the same outcome: trust. In fragmented markets, integration builds trust through access; in mature markets, it builds trust through oversight.

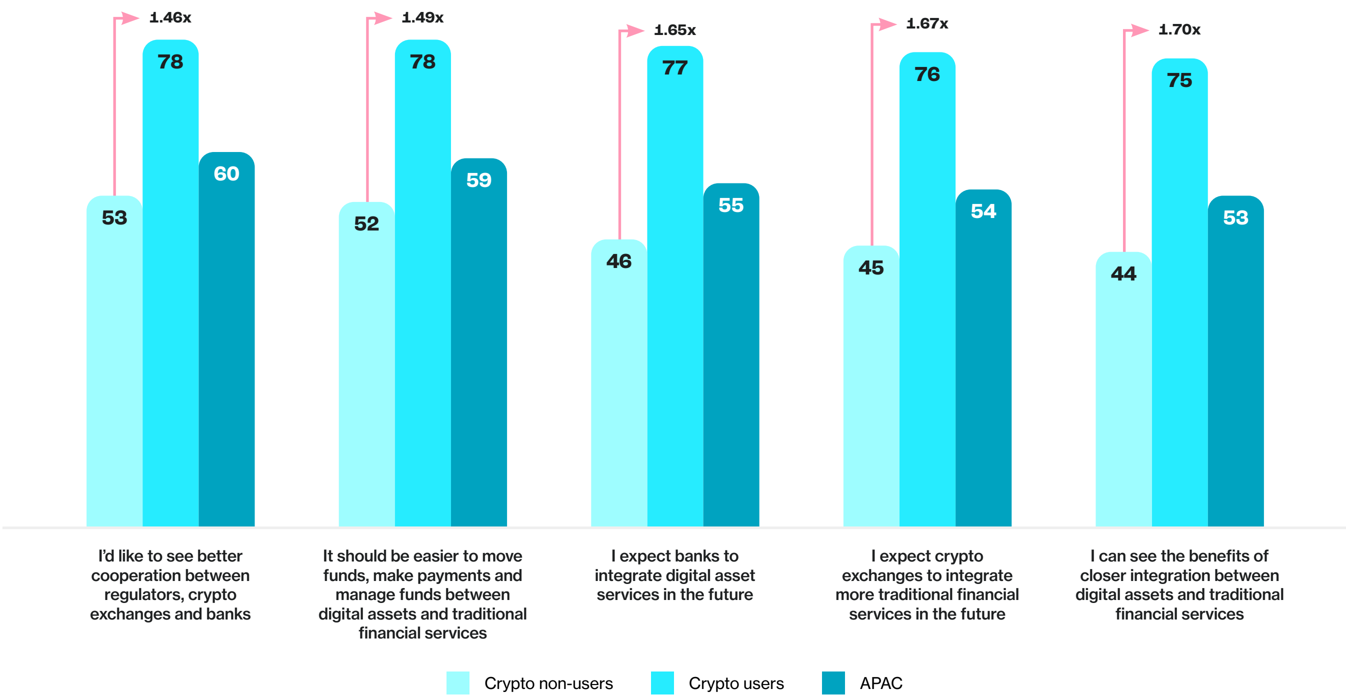
Trust as the Common Currency

Engagement predicts confidence in integration. Among crypto users, 78% support stronger cooperation between regulators, banks, and exchanges, compared with 53% of non-users. Users are also 1.6–1.7× more likely to believe integration will happen and to want banks involved.

Exhibit 8.3

Crypto users are significantly more supportive of integrating digital assets with traditional financial services.

Share of adults agreeing with each statement, crypto users vs. crypto non-users (% (Top 2 Box: “strongly agree” or “somewhat agree”)



Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks. Figures represent the share of respondents agreeing (Top 2 Box) with each statement.

The pattern suggests that interaction fosters trust rather than skepticism. 40% of users say they would open a bank account with a crypto exchange if allowed, compared with 15% of non-users. Likewise, 31% of users already use or plan to use crypto-linked debit cards, compared with 12% among non-users.

Exhibit 8.4

Crypto users also express greater openness to new ways of engaging with digital assets and financial services.

Share of adults agreeing with each statement about accessibility and integration of digital assets, by user type (% of population aged 18-64)

Source: Protocol Theory, 2025. Nationally representative online survey of 4,020 adults aged 18–64, conducted 18–26 September 2025 across 10 markets. Age and gender distributions aligned with population benchmarks.

Integration therefore functions as a trust multiplier – embedding safety and familiarity around existing behaviors. Rather than replacing institutions, digital assets are prompting them to evolve in ways that strengthen confidence.

Integration as Infrastructure

Integration represents the culmination of the region's access story. Consumers are not asking for new financial systems; they are asking for coherence across the ones they already use.

The financial architecture emerging across APAC will be multi-rail: traditional money, stablecoins, tokenized deposits, and real-world assets coexisting on interoperable networks. Inclusion will be defined not by entry into a single system, but by the ability to navigate seamlessly between them.

This expectation is no longer confined to early adopters – it is now a mainstream preference shaping the region's next phase of growth. Integration, by design, converts digital innovation into institutional trust, turning parallel systems into a single, connected financial experience.

Conclusion: Access is the New Adoption

Asia–Pacific's digital asset story has entered a new era – one defined not by speculation or ideology, but by inclusion. Across ten markets, the evidence points to a region that has moved beyond curiosity and conviction toward practicality and integration. Awareness is near universal, optimism remains high, and regulation has matured into an enabling framework. The decisive factor shaping participation today is *access*: whether people can readily use, see, and trust digital assets within the systems they already rely on.

Access is what turns intent into action and belief into behaviour. When crypto, stablecoins, and tokenized assets feel as seamless as mobile payments or online banking, participation grows. Where experiences remain complex or unfamiliar, progress slows – even among those who already believe in their potential.

The region is well positioned: it is home to nearly 60% of global crypto users, regulatory clarity is improving, and stablecoins, remittances, and tokenization are translating financial innovation into everyday value. The next step is reducing friction. Clear language, simpler design, and interoperability can unlock an *accessibility dividend* among millions who are ready to participate once the experience feels familiar and dependable.

Asia–Pacific has long been the testing ground for financial innovation. It is now becoming the proving ground for accessible finance. The future of adoption will be measured by inclusion: by how easily people can reach, understand, and use these tools in daily life.

Access is the new adoption.

And it is through access that digital assets will fulfill their original promise: a more open, connected, and human-centered financial system for everyone.

Appendix A: Glossary

Adoption Science™
An evidence-based research discipline developed by Protocol Theory for understanding how emerging technologies – such as digital assets, Web3, and AI – gain acceptance, usage, and integration into everyday life. It combines behavioral science, diffusion theory, and marketing science to identify the psychological, social, and contextual factors that shape technology adoption.

Accessibility
The degree to which a product, service, or category (like cryptocurrencies or stablecoins) are available, understandable, and usable by ordinary consumers. Accessibility is determined by four interdependent dimensions: availability, language, design and usability, and integration within existing financial systems.

APAC (Asia–Pacific)
A regional grouping that includes East, South, and Southeast Asia, Oceania, and selected Gulf economies. While the United Arab Emirates (UAE) is not conventionally classified as part of the Asia–Pacific region, it is included in this report because of its global relevance to digital asset adoption, its advanced regulatory environment, and its comparable role to emerging APAC markets in cross-border payments and remittance activity.

Awareness
Recognition or general knowledge of a product or concept. In the diffusion of innovation framework, awareness represents the first stage of the adoption process but does not imply understanding or use.

B2B (Bottom-Two Box)
A statistical summary used in survey analysis to express the proportion of respondents selecting the two lowest options on a rating scale (for example, "strongly disagree" + "disagree"). B2B scores help identify negative sentiment, low agreement, or low confidence levels within a population.

Blockchain
A distributed ledger technology that records transactions across a network of computers in a secure, verifiable, and immutable way. It underpins cryptocurrencies, stablecoins, and tokenized assets.

Cryptocurrency (Crypto)
A digital or virtual form of money that uses cryptographic methods to secure transactions and control issuance. Cryptocurrencies may serve as investments, payment mechanisms, or platforms for decentralized applications.

Decentralization
A structural principle that distributes control and verification across a network rather than a single central authority. It supports transparency and resilience but can increase complexity for users.

Developed Markets
Economies characterized by advanced financial systems, high digital penetration, and strong regulatory and institutional frameworks. In this report, developed markets include Australia, Japan, Singapore, Hong Kong SAR, and South Korea. These markets typically exhibit stable adoption patterns, driven by integration and trust rather than necessity or access gaps.

Digital Assets
A broad category of blockchain-based instruments that hold or represent value, including cryptocurrencies, stablecoins, and tokenized real-world assets.

Digital Wallet
An application or platform that allows users to securely store, send, receive, or spend digital assets. Wallets can be custodial (managed by a provider) or non-custodial (controlled directly by the user).

Early Adopter
Individuals who are open to new technologies once they have gathered basic information. They are motivated by progress and curiosity, often influencing others through informed experimentation and early feedback.

Early Majority
Individuals who show interest in new technologies but prefer to wait for evidence of value and reliability before adopting. They represent a pragmatic middle group – interested, but deliberate.

Emerging Markets
Economies characterized by developing financial infrastructure, rapid digital adoption, and high demand for inclusive financial tools. In this report, emerging markets include India, the Philippines, Thailand, the UAE, and China.

Fiat Currency
Government-issued money not backed by a physical commodity. Examples include the Australian dollar (AUD), Indian rupee (INR), and US dollar (USD).

Innovator
Individuals who are first to experiment with new technologies and often seek novelty for its own sake. They enjoy discovery, take calculated risks, and play an outsized role in shaping early adoption patterns.

Integration
The connection between digital asset systems and traditional financial institutions, enabling seamless transfer and management of funds between fiat and digital balances within unified experiences.

Laggard
Individuals who prefer familiar systems and are reluctant to adopt new technologies unless they become unavoidable. They value stability and certainty over novelty and change.

Late Majority
Individuals who are cautious about adopting new technologies until products are proven, widely used, and supported by trusted institutions. They rely heavily on peer experience and reassurance.

Remittances
Cross-border money transfers – often from migrant workers to family members – that serve as a vital economic and social link across APAC. Remittances represent one of the clearest real-world use cases for digital assets.

Stablecoins
Digital tokens that maintain a stable value by being pegged to a reference asset, such as a fiat currency or reserve basket. They combine blockchain efficiency with monetary stability and are central to digital payments, remittances, and settlements.

T2B (Top-Two Box)
A statistical summary used in survey analysis to express the proportion of respondents selecting the two lowest options on a rating scale. T2B scores are commonly used to indicate overall favorability, agreement, or confidence.

Tokenization
The process of converting ownership rights in a real-world asset – such as property, infrastructure, or equities – into digital tokens on a blockchain. Tokenization expands access to investment and enhances liquidity.

Traditional Finance (TradFi)
The established financial ecosystem encompassing banks, payment systems, and capital markets. Integration between TradFi and digital assets represents the key pathway to mainstream adoption.

Usability
The ease with which users can interact with a product or service effectively and confidently. High usability reduces friction and accelerates adoption.

Web3
A decentralized model of the internet built on blockchain technologies that enable user ownership, value exchange, and programmable applications beyond traditional centralized platforms.

Protocol Theory Adoption Science™ Consumer Category Segments

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User Segments

Engaged User
Individuals who regularly use a given technology as part of their daily or routine financial, creative, or digital behaviour. They represent the most advanced stage of adoption and serve as the behavioral benchmark for mainstream integration.

Occasional User
Individuals who use a given technology infrequently or situationally but demonstrate practical familiarity and experience. Their participation reflects functional understanding without habitual engagement.

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Considerer Segments

Active Considerer
Individuals who are currently considering adopting or using a given technology. They display strong intent and represent the most immediate source of future growth once accessibility and confidence barriers are reduced.

Passive Considerer
Individuals who are not yet planning to use a given technology but express openness or conditional interest. They form a latent opportunity group whose participation depends on increased usability, visibility, and integration.

—

Disengaged Segments

Skeptic
Individuals who are aware of a given technology but consciously avoid it due to doubts about its value, safety, or relevance. Their resistance is attitudinal rather than informational, often shaped by perceived risk or lack of trust.

Disinterested
Individuals who understand a given technology but feel no personal relevance or perceived benefit. Their non-participation reflects low motivation to engage rather than overt opposition.

Rejector
Individuals who explicitly rule out any future use of a given technology. They hold strong negative sentiment and perceive little personal benefit or relevance, often viewing the technology as incompatible with their values, priorities, or worldview.

Appendix B: Methodology

Survey Design and Objectives

APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025: Stablecoins, Tokenization & Integration is based on a quantitative survey designed by Protocol Theory in partnership with CoinDesk. The study examines how digital asset participation across Asia-Pacific is evolving from awareness and optimism toward accessibility and practical use.

The questionnaire replicated the 2024 instrument to enable year-on-year comparability, with refinements capturing perceptions of access, usability, and integration with traditional finance. Core modules measured awareness, usage, intent, sentiment, barriers, and product-specific familiarity with stablecoins, remittances, and tokenized assets.

Sampling Framework

Fieldwork was conducted between 18 and 26 September 2025 across ten markets – nine within Asia-Pacific and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), included again as a point of comparison due to its global relevance in digital asset adoption and similarities with emerging APAC economies.

The total sample comprised 4,020 internet-connected adults aged 18–64, recruited through ISO 20252–certified, human-verified online research panels. To achieve national representation wherever possible, interlocking quotas on age, gender, and location were employed, aligned with 2024 benchmarks within ±5% tolerance. Surveys were self-completed on desktop and mobile devices via a secure, device-agnostic platform. The median survey length was 11 minutes.

Market	Sample (n)
Australia	401
China	404
Hong Kong SAR	401
India	410
Japan	401
Philippines	400
Singapore	401
South Korea	400
Thailand	402
United Arab Emirates (UAE)*	400
Total	**4,020**

Respondents were screened out if they were under 18 or 65 and older, or if they had never heard of cryptocurrency. Unless otherwise specified, findings reflect the internet-connected adult population (18–64) in each market.

Sampling weights were applied to reflect national internet-connected populations and to ensure proportional representation between developed and emerging markets. At a 95% confidence level, the maximum margin of error is ±1.5 percentage points for the APAC regional aggregate and ±4.9 points at the country level.

For total-population metrics (e.g., country-level adoption rates), results were re-weighted to account for both internet access and cryptocurrency awareness. Internet-penetration rates ranged from 46.5% in India to 100% in the UAE, while awareness ranged from 86.8% in Japan to 97.6% in Thailand.

Methodological Note: Inclusion of the United Arab Emirates (UAE)

While the *APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025* study focuses on Asia–Pacific, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) was included again as a comparator market, continuing the precedent established in the 2024 edition. The UAE's inclusion serves both analytical and methodological purposes.

The UAE combines one of the world's most advanced digital asset regulatory frameworks with high adoption rates and strong remittance flows connecting the Middle East with South and Southeast Asia – notably India, the Philippines, and Thailand. These characteristics create behavioral and structural parallels with several emerging APAC markets, making the UAE a valuable reference point for comparative analysis.

Including the UAE again in 2025 enables longitudinal comparison with the 2024 dataset, ensuring continuity in the analysis of regional trends and maintaining statistical robustness for year-on-year benchmarking. It also provides an external reference point for understanding how emerging-market adoption dynamics extend beyond geographic boundaries – reinforcing that many of the human and economic drivers of digital asset participation are regional in pattern, but global in relevance.

Methodological Note: Why report adoption among internet-connected adults?

Internet access defines the *realistic ceiling* for crypto participation. Cryptocurrency ownership requires a device, connectivity, and digital literacy – conditions that exclude a substantial share of the global population. Using internet-connected adults as the denominator corrects for this structural access gap and aligns adoption metrics with the segment of the population that could plausibly own or use digital assets.

This approach improves comparability across markets and over time by controlling for differences in connectivity and age structure. It also mirrors the convention used in other digital-economy adoption studies, where internet-connected adults represent the economically active and technologically reachable audience.

Accordingly, two global adoption rates are reported:

- **Total-population adoption rate,** reflecting overall societal penetration.
- **Internet-connected-adult adoption rate,** reflecting adoption among the addressable population.

Both lenses are necessary: the first shows crypto's global footprint; the second, its maturity within the reachable online economy.

Data Collection and Verification

All fieldwork adhered to ESOMAR and GRBN international standards. Multiple safeguards were used to ensure respondent validity and data quality:

- **Duplicate prevention:** digital fingerprinting and cross-panel deduplication.
- **Behavioral checks:** time-on-task thresholds, logic verifications, and randomized attention filters.
- **Consistency testing:** cross-validation of answers across related sections to identify patterned or contradictory responses.
- **Manual review:** automated flags were inspected by analysts before final dataset inclusion.

Median completion time and item-level response patterns fell within expected tolerance ranges, confirming data reliability. Across all markets, 94% of responses met inclusion criteria for analysis. All participants gave informed consent and were assured of confidentiality.

Appendix B: Methodology

Survey Focus Areas

The questionnaire explored:

- Awareness, adoption, and usage of digital assets including cryptocurrencies, stablecoins, and tokenized assets.
- Perceived barriers to access and usability, and trust in regulated institutions.
- Motivations for use such as remittances, financial inclusion, and control over money.
- Perceptions of regulation and integration with traditional finance.
- Demographic and psychographic correlates of adoption readiness.

Measurement, Analysis, and Statistical Testing

The questionnaire employed categorical, ordinal, and attitudinal scales to measure awareness, familiarity, intent, sentiment, and perceived accessibility. Segmentation followed Protocol Theory's proprietary **Adoption Science™ framework**, classifying respondents into Active/Passive Users, Active/Passive Considerers, Skeptics, Disinterested, and Rejectors. Analysis included weighted descriptive and inferential statistics, subgroup comparisons, and driver and correlation testing to explore relationships between accessibility, trust, and adoption outcomes.

All reported differences were tested for statistical significance at the 95% confidence level ($p < 0.05$) using two-tailed tests of proportion or mean difference. Non-significant results were interpreted as directional only. All figures were weighted and rounded to the nearest whole number for clarity and comparability.

Interpretation and Limitations

The online mode means findings represent the internet-connected adult population within each market rather than the entire national population (unless otherwise specified). Self-report data may be subject to recall bias, and regional variations in regulation, digital literacy, and other sociocultural factors may limit cross-market comparability.

Despite these inherent limitations, the use of verified panels, rigorous quality controls, and population-aligned weighting ensures a high level of methodological reliability and cross-market validity.

Ethical Compliance

All research activities complied with international ethical standards, including informed consent, respondent confidentiality, and ISO 27001 data-security requirements in line with GDPR principles. No personally identifiable information was stored with analytical data.

Appendix C: Calculation Notes and Methodology

Purpose

This appendix explains the data sources, definitions, and computational steps used to estimate global and regional cryptocurrency ownership as of **November 2025**.

1. Conceptual Definitions

Term	Definition
Owner	A person who currently holds at least one crypto asset (wallet or custodial account). This includes both active and dormant holders.
User (Active)	A person transacting on-chain or through an exchange within a given month. This subset is smaller than the total owner population.
Internet-connected adult	Adults (18+) with regular Internet access, used as a denominator for penetration rates in adoption analyses.
Adoption rate	Share of the relevant population (total or Internet-connected adults) who own crypto.

2. Primary Data Sources

Source	Description & Role in Calculation
a16z Crypto – *State of Crypto 2025* (Oct 2025)	Latest late-year global owner estimate: **716 million people**. Distinguishes owners from 40–70 million monthly active users.
Crypto.com Research – *Crypto Market Sizing H1 2025* (Jun 2025)	Mid-year global owner benchmark: **708 million** (up from 681 million in Jan 2025). Method: blended on-chain and exchange-account deduplication.
United Nations DESA Population Division – *World Population Prospects 2024*	Baseline for 2024 global population (~8.2 billion) and adult share.
Statistics Times (2025)	Daily interpolation of global population; 8.255 billion on 3 Nov 2025 used for cross-check.
Worldometer (2025)	Live-counter corroboration (~8.231 billion mid-2025; ~8.23 billion projected 2025 average).
Triple-A – *Global Crypto Ownership 2024*	Historical benchmark (~560 million owners in 2024) illustrating prior underestimation in public datasets.
Internal survey data (10 APAC markets)	Provides country-level awareness-adjusted and Internet-adjusted adoption rates forming the weighted APAC rate (24.3%).

Appendix C:
Calculation Notes and Methodology

3. Population and Connectivity Inputs

Variable	Value	Source / Derivation
World population (Nov 2025)	8,250,000,000	UN WPP 2024 + Statistics Times + Worldometer triangulation.
World adult population	5,791,620,319	Derived using 70.2% adult share (UN WPP 2023 ratios).
World Internet-connected population	6,039,000,000	ITU / DataReportal 2024 benchmarks interpolated to 2025.
World Internet-connected adults	4,239,466,073	70.2% of connected population.
APAC total population	4,800,000,000	UN regional estimate (Asia + Oceania, 2025 mid-year).
APAC adult Internet-connected population	2,198,215,656	Regional Internet penetration 65.24% × adult share ~70%.

4. Estimation Steps

4.1. Global Owners (Nov 2025)

Linear interpolation between Crypto.com (31 Jun 2025 = 708M) and a16z (22 Oct 2025 = 716 M):

$(716M\text{-}708M)\times114\ days = 70k\ per\ day$

Linear interpolation between a16z (22 Oct 2025 = 716M) and *APAC Digital Asset Adoption 2025* publication (14 Nov 2025):

$716M \times (70k \times 26\ days) = 717M$

Rounded to **717 million global owners**.

4.2. Global Adoption Rates

Adoption rate (total population) = $717M$ / $8.25B$ = 8.7%

Adoption rate (internet-connected adults) = $717M$ / $4.239B$ = 16.9%

4.3. APAC Owners and Adoption

Weighted APAC adoption (internet-connected adults) = 24.3399%.

$2.198B \times 0.243399 = 535.0M owners$

Adoption rate (total population) = $535.0M$ / $4.80B$ = 11.1%

Adoption rate (internet-connected adults) = 24.3%

APAC share of global owners = $535.0M$ / $717M$ = 74.6%

Interpretation and Caveats

- **Owner vs user distinction.** Figures represent ownership, not monthly on-chain activity.
- **Direct vs. indirect ownership.** The survey does not distinguish between direct and indirect ownership (e.g., holdings via ETFs or custodial investment products).
- **Regional extrapolation.** The APAC average is derived from ten markets (China, India, Japan, South Korea, Singapore, Philippines, Thailand, Australia, Hong Kong, UAE). Representativeness outside this basket is assumed.
- **Connectivity adjustments.** Internet penetration and adult shares use 2024–2025 interpolations; small deviations (<1 pp) in penetration change adoption rates by <0.2 pp.
- **Linear growth assumption.** Interpolating from mid-year to November assumes no material acceleration or slowdown between June and October 2025.
- **User share vs. volume share.** Estimates capture the share of adults using digital assets, not the share of transaction or trading volume.

5. Reproducibility Summary

Metric	Formula	Result
Global owners	Interpolated (716M Oct → 717M Nov)	**717 M**
Global adoption – total pop	717M ÷ 8.25B	**8.7%**
Global adoption – connected adults	717M ÷ 4.239B	**16.9%**
APAC owners	2.198B × 24.3399%	**535 M**
APAC adoption – total pop	535M ÷ 4.80B	**11.1%**
APAC adoption – connected adults	535M ÷ 2.198B	**24.3%**
APAC share of owners	535M ÷ 717M	**74.6%**

6. Citation List

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7. Protocol Theory APAC Survey Dataset (2025). Internal calculation of awareness- and internet-adjusted adoption rates.

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